Pathfinder Guidebook

FYE 100: Strategies for College Success

Offline edition. The online guidebook, with fill-in forms, is at https://octc-instructional-design.github.io/FYE100-pathfinder-guidebook/. Due dates and points are in Blackboard.

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START HERE

How to Use This Book

How the book and Blackboard fit together, and how to keep your work safe.

On this page

- The book and Blackboard
- How each module is laid out
- You don't have to read every word
- Keep your work safe
- How Mile Markers are scored
- AI use labels
- Getting around
- The guides
- Reading your way

A few minutes here will save you time all semester.

The Pathfinder Guidebook holds the readings for FYE 100, plus tools you can fill in as you go. Your course in Blackboard is where you submit work, see due dates, and check your grades. This page shows how the two fit together, how each module is laid out, and how to keep your work safe.

The book and Blackboard

In this book

- Your readings, one lesson at a time
- Trail Tools you can fill in and save
- Each Mile Marker, with support for every question
- The Merit Guide and the STAR(T) Stories Guide

In Blackboard

- Due dates and points
- Where you submit your work
- AI Chats, discussions, and journals
- Your grades and feedback

The book never lists due dates, because they can change from section to section. When you see "Check Blackboard for the due date," that's where to look.

How each module is laid out

Every module follows the same pattern, so once you know one, you know them all.

- Overview

  ### Module overview

  Why the module matters, what you'll be able to do by the end (your "I can" goals), and the skills you'll build. Start here.

- Trail Tool

  ### Trail Tools

  Worksheets you fill in right on the page. They sit at the top of the module because you'll use them as you read, and they feed the Mile Marker.

- Lesson

  ### Lessons

  Short readings, usually 5 to 10 minutes each. Most modules open with a Skill Spotlight on one of the 10 Essential Skills.

- Trail Tip

  ### Trail Tips

  Practical how-tos: setting up an account, finding a resource, or figuring out how something works.

- Mile Marker

  ### Mile Marker

The module's main assignment, with help for each question and a form you can fill in and save as a PDF.

- Wrap Up

Wrap Up

Key takeaways and one question to reflect on before you head back to Blackboard.

You don't have to read every word

This book is a resource. Read what you need for each assignment, and come back to the rest when it helps, now or later in the semester.

Here's a quick way to find what you need in any module:

1. **Start with the module overview**

   The "I can" goals tell you what the module is for, and each one names where you'll show it.

2. **Look at the Mile Marker**

   Its "Before you start" list and its "Look back at" links point to the Trail Tools and lessons the assignment uses.

3. **Read those first**

   Everything else is there when you want it.

Prefer to listen? The book is written to make sense when it's read aloud, so a read-aloud tool or screen reader works well.

Keep your work safe

When you type into a Trail Tool or a Mile Marker form, your answers save automatically, but only **in this browser, on this device**. They are not sent anywhere, and nobody else can see them.

That keeps your work private. It also means your answers won't follow you. You'll lose them if you:

- switch to a different computer, phone, or browser
- use a private or incognito window
- clear your browser's history or site data

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
>
> Make a habit of it: finish a form, select **Save as PDF**, and keep the file in your OneDrive. Then it's safe no matter what device you're on.

Saving a PDF

1. #### Type your name

   Every form needs your name before it will save, so your instructor knows whose work it is.

2. #### Select Save as PDF

   In the print window, choose **Save as PDF** (or **Microsoft Print to PDF**) as the printer. On a phone the print window looks different; look for an option to save as a PDF or save to your files.

3. #### Upload it to Blackboard

   The file is named for the assignment and your name, like "Mile Marker #3 - Your Name." Upload it to the matching assignment. You can also type or paste your answers straight into Blackboard instead.

How Mile Markers are scored

Every Mile Marker is scored the same way, with the Mile Marker rubric in Blackboard. Full credit comes down to two things:

1. #### Answer every prompt

   Each numbered box is one prompt. Fill in all of them.

2. #### Make each answer about you

   Include at least one real detail from your own life, your results, or your work in the module. That's what "specific" means here.

General or about you?

- **General:** "I waste time on my phone."
- **About you:** "I lose about an hour a night on my phone after my shift, so my homework starts late."

The second one doesn't need to be longer or more polished. It just needs to be yours. Each question also has an **"A strong answer"** note that shows what specific looks like for that question. Honest beats polished.

Your instructor won't take points off for length, spelling, or writing style. If you lose credit, your instructor will name the prompt so you know what to fix next time.

AI use labels

Every Mile Marker has a label near the top that tells you how AI can be used on it: **No AI**, **AI-supported**, or **AI-integrated**. Many also include an optional prompt you can try. Using AI is never required.

Lessons include short **AI Literacy** boxes, tagged with the BE behavior they build: BE Safe, BE Honest, BE Critical, BE Responsible, or BE Reflective.

> **LEARN MORE**
>
> Lesson 1.3: The five BE behaviors
>
> Lesson 1.4: AI use labels

Getting around

- **Home and Contents.** The buttons at the top of every page take you to the book's home page or straight to the list of modules.
- **The module menu.** The list on the left shows every page in the module and the sections of the page you're on. On a phone, tap **Lessons** to open it.
- **Previous and Next.** The buttons at the bottom of each page take you through the module in order.
- **Margin notes.** Boxes beside the reading give you a **Key term**, a **Pathfinder Tip**, or a place to **Look back at**. On a phone, they appear in the reading.
- **Outside links** open in a new tab, so you never lose your place in the book.

The guides

Two guides at the back of the book cover things you'll use all semester:

- The Merit Guide: setting up your Merit page, finding activities, and writing your reflections.
- The STAR(T) Stories Guide: your capstone, with a practice guide for each story.

Reading your way

The book works on a phone, tablet, or computer. You can zoom in, use a screen reader, or print any page. If something in the book doesn't work for you, tell your instructor. If you have a disability or think you might need an accommodation, OCTC Accessibility Services (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/about/student-life/accessibility-services.aspx) can help.

Questions about an assignment or a due date? Ask your instructor.

MODULE 1

Your Pathfinder Journey Begins

Every journey starts with a single step, and this one is yours.

10 ESSENTIAL SKILLS IN THIS MODULE

 #1 Communication

 #5 Adaptability & Leadership

 #6 Professionalism

 #10 Information Literacy

Why this matters

You already know how to do school. College is still school, but the stakes are higher and the rules shift: what's expected of you, how to ask for help, and what it means to own your learning.

This module puts those things on the table early, while there's still time to build the right habits. What you set up here, including your goal, your sense of what college expects, and your first look at the skills and tools you'll use all semester, becomes the foundation for everything that follows. New to this book? Take a few minutes with How to Use This Book first.

What you'll be able to do

By the end of this module:

A

I can describe my personal reasons for attending college and define what success means to me right now.

B

I can navigate Blackboard and locate key course information, assignments, and instructor contact details.

C

I can set one personal or academic goal for this semester and describe how I plan to reach it.

D

I can explain what artificial intelligence is and identify where it already shows up in my daily life.

AI Literacy: BE behaviors in this module

- BE Safe
- BE Honest

This module also introduces all five BE behaviors you'll use throughout the book.

Lessons in this module

1.1 College-Level Expectations

The rules changed. Here's what nobody told you.

1.2 The 10 Essential Skills

What Kentucky says every college graduate should be able to do, and where you're headed.

1.3 What's AI, Really?

AI is already part of your daily life. This lesson is about using it thoughtfully.

1.4 Navigating AI Policies

Every course sets its own AI rules. Here's how to find them, and a routine for using AI well.

1.5 Getting Around Blackboard Ultra

The basics you need to navigate your courses with confidence.

Trail Tip: Your Free Microsoft Office 365 Access

As a KCTCS student, you already have the full Microsoft Office suite. Here's how to get it.

Mile Marker: Mile Marker #1: My Starting Point

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

Wrap Up: Module 1 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

LESSON 1.1

College-Level Expectations

The rules changed. Here's what nobody told you.

Most students who struggle in their first year of college are smart enough. What trips them up is that the rules changed, and nobody told them how, or how much.

High school and college are both called "school," and they look similar from the outside. But how they work, what they expect from you, and what happens when you fall short are very different. This lesson makes those differences visible so you can navigate them instead of running into them the hard way. No matter where you're coming from (straight out of high school, a dual enrollment program, years in the workforce, or somewhere in between), this is worth your full attention.

Who's in this room

OCTC classrooms, online and in person, bring together students from very different places. Two of the most common are students coming from high school and students returning to education after time in the workforce. The expectations in this lesson apply to everyone, but they land differently depending on where you're starting.

If you're coming from high school

You may have been an excellent student. You may have earned high grades, taken advanced courses, and had teachers who knew your name and followed up when you were struggling.

In college, the support is still here, but you have to go looking for it. Nobody will chase you down for a missing assignment, because you're expected to manage your own academic life as an adult, even if you're 16 or 17. The adjustment has less to do with ability than with habits: following through, following directions, and taking ownership.

If you're returning after time away

You may have been out of school for years, maybe decades. You've been managing real responsibilities: jobs, families, finances, communities. That experience works in your favor.

The professional habits you've built (showing up, communicating clearly, following through on commitments) are exactly what college expects. You already know more about accountability than you might think.

The adjustment is often the systems: Blackboard, academic language, citation formats, the pace of a semester. All of that can be learned, and you're bringing a solid foundation to build on.

The big shift: responsibility moves to you

> **In high school, the system was designed to catch you. In college, the system is designed to support you, but only if you engage with it.**

This is the most important difference, and it shows up everywhere. In high school, teachers often remind you about deadlines, follow up when you're absent, and give you chances to redo work. In college, those things still exist, but they're your job to start, not your instructor's job to offer.

BEFORE

Your teacher reminded you about the assignment due Friday. If you missed it, they asked you what happened.

NOW

The due date is in the syllabus. If you're going to miss it, you reach out first, before the deadline, not after.

BEFORE

If you didn't understand something, your teacher noticed and checked in with you.

NOW

If you don't understand something, you go to office hours, email your instructor, or visit the Teaching & Learning Center. You start the conversation.

BEFORE

You could skim the directions and still do well because you had a sense of what was expected.

NOW

Directions are specific and intentional. Not following them, even on a strong piece of work, costs you points. Read everything.

BEFORE

Your relationship with your teacher was ongoing. They knew you over time and gave you the benefit of the doubt.

NOW

Your instructor may have 30, 60, or 150 students. They'll learn who you are through how you show up: your work, your communication, your follow-through.

The syllabus is a contract. Read it that way.

Every course you take has a **syllabus**. Most students skim it once and never look at it again, which is one of the most common first-year mistakes.

Your syllabus tells you exactly what's expected, how you'll be graded, what happens if you miss a deadline, how to contact your instructor, and what the academic integrity policy is for that course. If something goes wrong and you say you didn't know, the first question will be whether it was in the syllabus.

For FYE 100, the Syllabus Acknowledgement you completed before Module 1 checked the parts students most often miss. Use the same habits in every course you take.

Read it before the first week is over. Read the policies section too, not only the assignment schedule.

Note every deadline. Put them in your phone, your planner, or your weekly map. Don't trust yourself to remember.

Find the late work policy. Some instructors accept late work with a penalty and some don't. Know which one you're dealing with before it matters.

Find the communication policy. How does your instructor want to be contacted? How quickly do they respond? Do they hold office hours?

Find the AI policy. It matters, and it varies from course to course.

KEY TERM

Syllabus: the document that lays out a course's expectations, grading, deadlines, and policies. Each course has its own.

PATHFINDER TIP

When something in the syllabus is unclear, ask before you act on your assumption. "I read the syllabus and wasn't sure how X works. Can you help me understand?" is a professional way to ask, and it shows you actually read it.

SEE ALSO

Lesson 1.4: Navigating AI Policies covers how AI rules differ between courses.

What instructors expect (that they don't always say out loud)

Four expectations come up in almost every college course. None of them is complicated, but all of them are easy to miss if nobody points them out.

Follow the directions, all of them

Assignment directions exist for a reason. Word counts, formatting requirements, citation styles, and submission formats aren't arbitrary. They reflect what the instructor is actually assessing. Submitting excellent content without following the directions tells your instructor you either didn't read them or decided they didn't apply to you. Neither is a good look.

This is one of the most common places strong students trip up in their first semester. The work is good, but points are lost for something entirely preventable.

PATHFINDER TIP

Before you submit anything, reread the directions one more time and check your work against each stated requirement. Ask "does this meet every requirement?" rather than "does this seem right?"

Communicate like a professional

Email to your instructor is professional communication, not a text message. That means a subject line, a greeting, complete sentences, and a signature. It also means being specific about what you need instead of saying something is confusing.

Instead of this

> "hey i was confused about the assignment"

Try this

> "Professor [Name], I'm working on this week's reflection assignment and want to make sure I understand Question 3. I read it as asking for [your interpretation]. Is that right, or am I missing something? Thank you for your time."

The second version tells your instructor exactly what you need, shows you've already tried to figure it out, and treats them as a professional. Aim for that every time.

SEE ALSO

Module 2 goes deeper on professional email.

Manage your own deadlines

Deadlines in college are real. Life happens, and most instructors are human about genuine emergencies. But "I forgot" or "I didn't realize it was due" is a planning problem, not an emergency, and it's yours to own.

If something comes up that affects your ability to meet a deadline, reach out to your instructor **before** the deadline, not after. Most instructors are far more willing to work with a student who communicated early than one who disappeared and came back with an explanation after the fact.

PATHFINDER TIP

An email the day *before* a deadline explaining a problem shows ownership. An email the day *after* asking for an exception asks your instructor to absorb the cost of your planning.

Academic integrity is non-negotiable

Academic integrity means your work represents your own thinking, effort, and understanding. It means citing sources when you use someone else's ideas. It means not submitting work that someone else, or an AI, produced as if it were your own. It means being honest about what you did and didn't do.

The consequences for academic integrity violations in college are serious, and they can follow you. Think it through before you make a decision you can't undo.

Every course has an academic integrity policy, and many also have a specific AI policy. Read both. When you're unsure whether something crosses a line, ask your instructor before you do it, not after.

KEY TERM

Academic integrity: doing your own work, giving credit to others' ideas, and being honest about how your work was produced.

Owning your own learning

Everything in this lesson comes back to one idea: in college, you are the person most responsible for your academic success. More than your instructor, your advisor, or your family, it's you.

That can sound like a burden, but it's also an invitation. You have more say over your college experience than you've ever had over your education. You choose how much effort you put in, how much support you seek, and what you take away from each course. Nobody can do that for you.

The students who do well in college often weren't the best prepared coming in. They figured out how college works, and then they worked it. This lesson gives you a head start.

REFLECT

Look back at the four "Before / Now" shifts. Which one will take the most adjustment for you, and what's one thing you could do this week to get ahead of it?

You don't have to have all of this figured out on day one, and nobody does. Start paying attention now, though, because the habits you build in your first few weeks tend to stick. Make them good ones.

LESSON 1.2

The 10 Essential Skills

What Kentucky says every college graduate should be able to do, and where you're headed.

Every college in Kentucky's public system, including OCTC, uses the same framework to describe what a college education should develop in you. It's called the Kentucky Graduate Profile, and at its center are 10 Essential Skills.

These are the skills that show up in every job posting, every performance review, and every meaningful challenge you'll face after college. FYE 100 is built around them.

Use this page as a reference. Skim it now, before your Skills Snapshot. You'll come back to it all semester, because each module spotlights one or more of these skills, and your STAR(T) Stories capstone is built on them.

GO TO THE SOURCE

Read the full Kentucky Graduate Profile (https://cpe.ky.gov/ourwork/kygradprofile.html) from the Kentucky Council on Postsecondary Education.

The 10 Essential Skills

You'll use every one of these well beyond the classroom.



Communication

Listening carefully, responding clearly, and expressing your ideas in writing, conversation, and presentations in ways that land.



Critical & Creative Thinking

Questioning assumptions, evaluating information, and coming up with new ideas or better solutions instead of accepting the first answer.



Quantitative Reasoning

Using numbers and data to make sense of problems and reach informed conclusions, whether that's a budget, a chart, or a statistic in the news.



Interpersonal Relations

Understanding yourself and others, and working respectfully with people who think, live, and communicate differently than you do.



Adaptability & Leadership

Adjusting when things change, staying effective under pressure, and helping others move toward a goal, even when you're not in charge.



Professionalism

Acting with integrity, managing your time, taking initiative, and being accountable for your work: the habits that define a reliable person in any field.



Civic Engagement

Participating in your community and the broader world as someone who contributes to making things better, rather than watching from the sidelines.



Collaboration & Teamwork

Showing up reliably for a group, managing disagreement constructively, and making the team stronger.



Knowledge Application

Taking what you've learned and actually using it: connecting academic content to real situations in your career and your life.



Information Literacy

Finding, evaluating, and responsibly using information to make good decisions, especially in a world full of sources that aren't all trustworthy.

Where you're starting, and where you're headed

Kentucky describes these skills at three levels. Most students start college around Benchmark and work toward Milestone over two years of college.

KEY TERM

Milestone: the level Kentucky expects after two years of college, when you can use a skill on your own in real situations.

Benchmark

Where students typically are when they start college. You're beginning to develop these skills, often with some guidance or support still needed.

Roughly equivalent to high school completion.

Milestone

YOUR TARGET

Where you should be after two years of college. You can demonstrate each skill independently, in real situations, without being told exactly how.

Expected at associate degree completion or halfway through a bachelor's program.

Capstone

Where bachelor's degree graduates should be: applying each skill with expertise and precision in professional and civic settings.

Expected at bachelor's degree completion.

Tracking your own growth

You don't need to master all 10 skills in one semester. FYE 100 is the starting point: a chance to name the skills, see what they look like in practice, and start building the habits that carry you toward Milestone.

In Blackboard, you'll rate yourself on these skills, and on how you use AI, with the **My Skills Snapshot** near the start of the course. You'll take it again at the end, then compare the two. The goal is an honest starting point you can measure your growth against later, not a high score now.

At the end of the course, you'll write or record four short STAR(T) Stories: one for each of three assigned skills (Adaptability & Leadership, Professionalism, and Knowledge Application) and one for a skill you choose. STAR(T) is a structured way to tell a story that shows a skill in action, using real experiences from your own life, and the groundwork starts here.

You can write your stories or record them, and recording is worth a try. Telling a story out loud, in your own voice, is the closest practice you'll get for how you'll actually use it: in a job interview, a scholarship conversation, or any time someone asks, "Tell me about a time when…"

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
>
> When you rate yourself, be honest rather than generous. A realistic starting point makes your growth easier to see.

LESSON 1.3

What's AI, Really?

AI is already part of your daily life. This lesson is about using it thoughtfully.

You already use AI. You may not call it that, but you do.

Every time you ask a voice assistant something, get a "you might also like" recommendation, or see a summary at the top of a search page, something behind the scenes is deciding what you see. That something is artificial intelligence.

AI isn't a robot, and it isn't magic. The chat tools most people mean when they say "AI" are systems trained on enormous amounts of human-written text. They've gotten very good at producing responses that sound confident, authoritative, and complete.

KEY TERM

Artificial intelligence (AI): computer systems that do tasks we usually connect with human thinking, like answering questions, writing, or recognizing patterns.

> **Sounding confident isn't the same as being right.**

AI doesn't know you. It doesn't know your situation, your goals, or whether the answer it just gave you actually applies to your life. It produces what's statistically likely to be useful, which is often helpful and occasionally very, very wrong.

The part that trips people up

AI doesn't get things wrong the way a broken calculator does. Here's a better way to picture it.

TRY IT

Hum this bassline: **bum, bum, bum, buttabum, bum…** (Bear with me.)

Now ask a few different people what song it is. Some will say Queen and David Bowie's "Under Pressure." Others, depending on their age and what they grew up with, will say Vanilla Ice's "Ice Ice Baby." **Neither person is wrong.** They both recognized a real pattern and completed it in the direction that was most familiar to them.

That's surprisingly close to what an AI chat tool does. Instead of looking up a fact and checking whether it's true, it recognizes patterns in language and produces the most likely next words, based on everything it was trained

on. Most of the time, that's accurate and useful. But sometimes the answer that *sounds* most likely isn't the correct one. It's only the one that fits the pattern best.

When AI produces something that sounds completely believable but isn't true, it's called a **hallucination**. Hallucinations aren't a glitch that will eventually go away. They happen when a pattern-completing system runs into a gap and fills it with whatever fits.

So when something an AI tells you seems off, "did it make a mistake?" is the wrong question. A better one is: **that sounded right, but is sounding right the same as being right?** That's why **how you use AI matters more than whether you use it.**

> **KEY TERM**
>
> *Hallucination:* when AI produces information that sounds believable but is false, such as a fact, quote, or source that doesn't exist.

Five ways to show up thoughtfully

This course uses five behaviors to describe what thoughtful AI use looks like. You'll see them throughout the book. Two of them, BE Critical and BE Reflective, come up again and again, because they're the habits that travel with you into every course, every job, and every situation where someone is trying to tell you something.

BE Safe

Know what you're sharing and with whom. Your personal information, financial details, and private circumstances stay private.

BE Honest

There's a real difference between getting help from a tool and letting a tool do your thinking for you. Be clear about which one you're doing.

BE Critical

Don't take AI output at face value. Check it. Ask where it came from. Notice when something seems off. This is the most transferable habit you'll build.

BE Responsible

Make intentional choices about when AI supports your learning and when it gets in the way. Knowing the difference is the skill.

BE Reflective

Notice what happens to your thinking when you use AI. Are you learning more, or less? Are you more confident in your own ideas, or less?

These five behaviors describe *who* you want to be as an AI user. The next lesson turns them into something you can do, every time you use AI for coursework. In Blackboard, the BE Check asks you to match each behavior to a real situation.

SEE ALSO

Lesson 1.4: Navigating AI Policies puts these behaviors into practice.

Your choice to make

You don't have to love AI, and you don't have to use it. What this course asks is simpler: think before you act, and pay attention to what you're learning and how. That goes for AI, and for everything else in this book, too.

PATHFINDER TIP

If you want to explore, start with Microsoft Copilot. It comes with your KCTCS Microsoft Office 365 account, so you sign in with your student login.

LESSON 1.4

Navigating AI Policies

Every course sets its own AI rules. Here's how to find them, and a routine for using AI well.

There's no single AI rule for college. Each course, and sometimes each assignment, sets its own.

In one course, you might be encouraged to brainstorm with AI. In another, using AI at all could count as an academic integrity violation. Both can be true in the same week. This lesson shows you where to find the rules, what to do when they aren't clear, and a simple routine to use any time you work with AI.

Where to find the rules

Look in two places, in this order.

1. ### The AI Course Policy

   Look for the AI Course Policy section of your syllabus. It explains your instructor's overall approach to AI for that course.

2. ### The assignment instructions

   Each assignment has an AI use label. The label tells you how AI can be used on that specific piece of work.

> **SEE ALSO**
>
> Lesson 1.1 on reading your syllabus like a contract.

Three AI use labels

Assignments use one of three labels. Think of them as points on one scale, from no AI at all to AI as part of the assignment itself.

No AI

You do this work on your own. Your instructor chose this because the skill itself is what you're practicing.

Example: a short quiz that checks what you know on your own.

AI-supported

You can use AI for the parts your instructor names, like brainstorming or checking grammar. The thinking and the final work are yours.

Example: using Copilot to brainstorm topic ideas, then choosing one and writing the paper yourself.

AI-integrated

Using AI well is part of the assignment. You might check what AI gives you against a standard, or explain how you used it.

Example: asking AI a question, checking its answer against your textbook, and explaining what it got right and wrong.

Labels are chosen **assignment by assignment**, not for a whole course. The same course can have one assignment at No AI and the next at AI-integrated. Check the assignment instructions every time.

> What an AI use label looks like at the top of an assignment
>
> ●○ AI use: AI-supported
>
> You may use AI to brainstorm ideas. Your response must be written in your own words.
>
> See the AI Course Policy in the syllabus.

If an assignment doesn't have an AI use label, or you aren't sure what it means, ask your instructor instead of guessing.

When the rules aren't clear

Ask before you use AI, not after. An instructor can easily answer a question before you start. It's much harder to sort things out once work has been turned in.

> Try asking like this
>
> > "Professor [Name], the directions for [assignment] don't mention AI. Would it be okay to use Copilot to brainstorm topic ideas if I write the paper myself?"

A specific question gets a specific answer. It also shows your instructor that you take the rules seriously.

The 3 Qs

Once you know the rules, three questions keep you on track. Each one belongs to a moment in your work.

Before you ask AI

Should I use AI for this part of my assignment?

BE Responsible · BE Honest

Before you use AI's answer

How would I know if AI's answer is wrong?

BE Critical

Before you turn in your work

Can I explain my work and how AI helped me?

BE Honest · BE Reflective

Notice the behaviors under each question. The 3 Qs are the five behaviors from Lesson 1.3 turned into a routine. The fifth, BE Safe, applies every time: never paste other people's personal information, passwords, or anything private into an AI tool.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> When AI is optional, choosing not to use it is a good choice too.

Keep a trail

A trail is a record of how your work grew over time. If your instructor asks how you did an assignment, you can show them. Tools that try to spot AI writing are sometimes wrong, and your trail is real evidence of your own work. It also lets you say exactly how AI helped you.

Write in Word, saved to OneDrive. Word keeps a dated history of your draft as you write. Type your work in the document instead of pasting it in at the end.

Keep a OneNote notebook for each course. Save your notes, sources, and ideas there while you work.

Write down how you use AI. Copy your question into OneNote and note what you kept, changed, or left out.

SEE ALSO

Trail Tip: Your Free Microsoft Office 365 Access shows how to get Word, OneDrive, and OneNote.

Keep a Trail (https://octc-instructional-design.github.io/Bb_Start_Here/ai-keep-a-trail.html) in OCTC Student Resources walks through setup and shows a sample notebook page.

Take it with you

OCTC Student Resources has an AI Literacy page with the same labels, the same 3 Qs, and a page for each question with checks and examples. It works for every course you take here, so bookmark it.

Open AI Literacy in Student Resources (https://octc-instructional-design.github.io/Bb_Start_Here/ai-literacy.html)

TRY IT

Open the syllabus for one of your other courses this semester. Find its AI Course Policy, then look at one assignment's AI use label. What does it allow, and is anything unclear enough that you'd want to ask your instructor?

LESSON 1.5

Getting Around Blackboard Ultra

The basics you need to navigate your courses with confidence.

Blackboard Ultra is where your courses live: your assignments, your grades, your instructor's feedback, and your connection to your classmates.

Use this page as a reference. Skim it now, and come back whenever you can't find something in Blackboard.

It doesn't take long to learn, and knowing where things are from the start makes a real difference. This lesson covers the handful of things you need in your first week. For everything else, you'll find two help resources at the end.

1 Set up your profile

Before you do anything else, add a profile photo. Online courses can feel anonymous, and a photo changes that. It tells your instructor and classmates that there's a real person on the other end of the screen, and it makes discussions feel more like actual conversations.

You don't need a professional headshot. A clear, recent photo where people can see your face is all it takes.

1. Select your avatar or initials in the top-right corner of any Blackboard page.
2. Select **Profile** from the menu.
3. Select the profile image area and upload a photo from your device.
4. Save your changes.

> PATHFINDER TIP
> While you're in your profile, make sure your name appears the way you want your instructors and classmates to see it.

2 Find your way around

Inside each course, a menu takes you to the main areas you'll use every week:

Course Content
Home base. Your modules, lessons, and assignments are listed here in order, top to bottom. Open a module to see everything inside it. Most weeks, this is where you'll start.

Calendar

What's coming up in this course: assignment due dates, plus class meetings if your instructor has added them. Switch to the **Due Dates** view to see your assignments listed in order, soonest first.

Gradebook
Your grades for everything you've submitted, plus what's still ahead. Select any item to see your score and the feedback your instructor left. (More on feedback in step 5.)

Messages
Private messages between you and your instructor or classmates, sent inside the course. It's a quick way to ask your instructor a question about this class. Some instructors prefer email, so check your syllabus.

Announcements
Updates from your instructor: reminders, changes, and heads-ups. New announcements often appear when you open the course, and they're also sent to your KCTCS email. Check these regularly.

One calendar for all your courses

The Calendar inside a course shows only that course. For the big picture, go to the main Blackboard page you see right after you log in, before you open any course, and select **Calendar** from the menu there. That calendar pulls in due dates from all of your courses at once, color-coded by course, so you can see a busy week coming before you're in the middle of it.

> PATHFINDER TIP
> Every instructor organizes modules a little differently. Spend a few minutes clicking through the first module of each course to learn its pattern.

3 Submit your work

Assignments in Blackboard Ultra are submitted through the course, not by email. Most follow the same steps:

1. Open the assignment from its module.
2. Read the instructions carefully before you start.
3. Type your response in the text box, or attach a file if the assignment calls for one.
4. Select **Submit** when you're done. You'll see a confirmation that your work was received.

> PATHFINDER TIP
> Don't wait until the last minute to submit. Technical issues happen, and submitting early gives you time to fix them.

4 Take part in discussions

Discussions usually work in two parts: your first post, and your replies to classmates. Many discussions have **two separate deadlines**, one for each part. Check the discussion in Blackboard for the exact dates.

1. Open the discussion from its module.
2. Select **Add a Response** to write your first post.
3. After posting, read what your classmates have written.
4. Reply to classmates by the reply deadline.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> Replies are usually graded too. A reply that responds to something specific your classmate said is worth far more than "great point, I agree."

5 Read your instructor's feedback

After your instructor grades your work, they often leave written feedback along with your score. It's one of the most valuable parts of a course and one of the most commonly ignored.

Your instructor took time to write it. In an online class, it's the closest thing you get to a one-on-one conversation, so read it.

1. Go to the **Gradebook**.
2. Select the assignment you want to review.
3. Look for written comments alongside your score.
4. If something is unclear, use **Messages** to follow up with your instructor.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> Feedback on early assignments tells you exactly what your instructor values. Reading it closely can change how you approach everything that comes after.

6 Stay in the loop

Instructors post announcements throughout the semester: reminders, clarifications, encouragement, and updates. Announcements appear in your course and are also sent to your KCTCS email.

Make a habit of checking both. Missing an announcement is one of the most common reasons students are caught off guard by a change.

PATHFINDER TIP

Set up your KCTCS email on your phone. It's the official channel for everything at OCTC: announcements, financial aid, registration, all of it.

Go deeper: Blackboard Ultra video tutorials

Short how-to videos on navigation, assignments, discussions, grades, and more. Bookmark it; you'll use it more than once.

Open the playlist on YouTube (https://www.youtube.com/playlist?list=PLontYaReEU1vndBOA5qA-u_Gwyh9xk8U3)

Look it up: Blackboard Help for Students

Blackboard's official help pages for students, with step-by-step instructions for getting started, course content, assignments and tests, grades, and the Blackboard app. When you're stuck on how to do something, search here.

Open Blackboard Help for Students (https://help.anthology.com/blackboard/student/?lang=en)

TRAIL TIP

Your Free Microsoft Office 365 Access

As a KCTCS student, you already have the full Microsoft Office suite. Here's how to get it.

Every KCTCS student currently enrolled in a course can install the full version of Microsoft Office 365 for free, on up to five devices: PC, Mac, Apple phones and tablets, and Android phones and tablets.

The software keeps working as long as you're enrolled in at least one class at a KCTCS college. That includes Word, Excel, PowerPoint, OneNote, Teams, and OneDrive.

Install on a PC or Mac

1. Sign in to your KCTCS Microsoft Office 365 account (https://portal.office.com/account/#installs).
2. Select **Install Office**.
3. If you're asked to save or run the file, choose **Run**.
4. Follow the on-screen prompts to install Office.
5. After Office is installed, if you're asked to sign in, use your KCTCS email address and password.

Install on a phone or tablet

1. Install the **Microsoft Office** app from the App Store or Google Play.
2. Open the app and sign in with your KCTCS student email and password.

What's included

Word

Papers, reports, and assignments. The standard for academic writing.

Excel

Spreadsheets, budgets, and data tracking.

PowerPoint

Presentations and slides for class projects.

OneDrive

Cloud storage, so your files are on every device you use.

OneNote

A digital notebook for notes, ideas, and class materials.

Microsoft Copilot

The AI assistant in your Microsoft Office 365 account. Sign in with your student login.

Need help installing or signing in? Contact OCTC Information Technology Services (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/current-students/information-technology/information_technology.aspx).

> **SEE ALSO**
>
> Keep a trail in Lesson 1.4 uses Word, OneDrive, and OneNote.

MILE MARKER

Mile Marker #1: My Starting Point

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

Every journey starts somewhere. This first Mile Marker is about getting clear on where you are right now: why you're here, what you're hoping for, what you already bring to the trail, and where you stand with AI.

Your responses don't need to be perfect. They need to be honest and specific. You'll come back to this reflection later in the course when you build your capstone project.

What you'll do

1. **Answer five questions** in the form below.
2. **Save as PDF** and upload it to the **Mile Marker #1** assignment in Blackboard.

●○ AI use: AI-supported

You may use AI as a thinking partner to explore your ideas. Work with what it gives you, then write your responses in your own voice. See the AI Course Policy in the syllabus and Lesson 1.4: AI use labels.

Optional prompt to try: "Ask me a series of questions to help me reflect on why I chose college, what success means to me right now, what strengths I bring as a new student, and how I feel about using AI for school." Use what's useful. Your final responses must be in your own words.

Your Mile Marker

Type your answers in the boxes. Your typing is saved in this browser as you go, so you can come back later on the same device. Nothing is sent anywhere until you upload it.

Your name (required)

Date

QUESTION 1

Why College, and Why OCTC

To get you thinking (no separate answer needed)

- What motivated you to take this step? Was it career goals, personal growth, a fresh start, family, stability, or something else?

> **A STRONG ANSWER**
>
> Names at least one **specific reason you chose college**, and **one reason you chose OCTC**.

1. Name one reason you chose to attend college.

2. Name one reason you chose OCTC.

Look back at: Lesson 1.1: Who's in this room

QUESTION 2

Success, in Your Own Terms

To get you thinking (no separate answer needed)

- Consider grades, habits, balance, confidence, exploring careers, or something entirely personal to you.

> **A STRONG ANSWER**
>
> Defines success **in your own words**, and connects it to **something you actually want** this semester.

1. Describe what success looks like for you this semester, in your own words.

2. Explain why that matters to you this semester.

Look back at: Lesson 1.1: Owning your learning

QUESTION 3

What You Bring

To get you thinking (no separate answer needed)

- Think about what you already bring to the table: work ethic, persistence, curiosity, communication skills, resilience, or something else.
- When has it helped you before?

A STRONG ANSWER

Names **one strength** and explains **how it will help you** this semester, ideally with an example of when it has helped you before.

1. Name one strength, habit, or quality you already have.

2. Explain how it will help you reach your goals this semester.

Look back at: Lesson 1.2: The 10 Essential Skills

QUESTION 4

One Goal, Two Steps

A goal is specific when someone else could tell whether you reached it. A step is concrete when you could put it on your calendar.

To get you thinking (no separate answer needed)

- "Do better" isn't a goal. "Pass my math class" or "meet with my Success Coach twice" is a goal.

A STRONG ANSWER

States **one specific, realistic goal**, names at least **two concrete steps** you'll take, and says **what success will look like** when you reach it.

1. State one goal you want to accomplish before this semester is over.

2. Name two concrete steps you'll take to reach it.

3. Describe what success will look like when you reach it.

QUESTION 5

Where You Stand with AI

To get you thinking (no separate answer needed)

- AI can be obvious, like a chatbot, or hidden, like autocorrect or your recommended videos.
- Maybe you're excited, unsure, skeptical, or you'd rather not use it at all. All of those are fair answers.
- If you can, think of one way AI could support your learning without doing the learning for you.

A STRONG ANSWER

Names at least **two specific examples** of AI in your daily life and describes **honestly** how you feel about using it for school. There's no right position here, only a clear one.

1. Name at least two places you already use or run into AI.

2. Describe how you feel about using AI for school right now.

Look back at: Lesson 1.3: What's AI, Really?

Submit it

Upload your PDF to the **Mile Marker #1** assignment in Blackboard. Check Blackboard for the due date.

In an in-person class? Your instructor may give you a printed copy. Fill it in by hand, then upload a photo or scan.

How it's scored: full credit means every prompt is answered, and each answer is about you, with at least one real detail. See How Mile Markers are scored.

WRAP UP

Module 1 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

You've reached the end of Module 1. These are the ideas to carry forward.

Key takeaways

In college, responsibility moves to you. The support is there, but you start the conversation, and you reach out before a deadline, not after.

Your syllabus is a contract. Read the policies, note every deadline, and ask when something is unclear.

The 10 Essential Skills are your map. They describe what college should build in you, and you'll track your own growth on them.

Sounding right isn't the same as being right. AI completes patterns; it doesn't check facts. How you use it matters more than whether you use it.

AI rules differ by course and assignment. Check the AI Course Policy and each assignment's AI use label, use the 3 Qs, and keep a trail.

Know your tools. Blackboard and Microsoft Office 365 are how your work gets done and seen. Learn them early.

REFLECT

Think about why you came to college and what success looks like for you this semester. After reading this module, what's one habit you want to start this week to move toward it?

That's Module 1.

Head back to your course in Blackboard for this module's activities.

MODULE 2

Building Your Support System

No one completes a journey alone. Every great Pathfinder relies on maps, tools, and traveling companions.

10 ESSENTIAL SKILLS IN THIS MODULE

 #1 Communication

 #4 Interpersonal Relations

 #9 Knowledge Application

Why this matters

College success takes more than willpower. It also takes knowing when and where to reach out. The students who struggle most are often the ones who wait too long to ask, not the ones who know the least.

This module helps you build your support map: the people and resources you can actually use when things get hard. That network is one of the smartest investments you can make right now.

What you'll be able to do

By the end of this module:

A

I can identify people and OCTC resources that can support my success and explain how each one helps.

B

I can describe how I will use my support system intentionally this semester.

C

I can identify one new campus resource I want to explore and explain why it matters for my goals.

D

I can practice asking for help clearly and specifically in a realistic college scenario.

AI Literacy: BE behaviors in this module

- BE Honest
- BE Responsible

Lessons in this module

2.1 Skill Spotlight: Interpersonal Relations

Interacting effectively with people, and understanding what you bring to every relationship.

2.2 Who's Your Success Coach?

Every Pathfinder needs a guide. Here's how to find yours.

2.3 Help-Seeking as a Strength

Asking for help is a skill successful students use every day.

2.4 Professional Communication & Email Etiquette

Your KCTCS email is your lifeline. Here's how to use it well.

Trail Tip: Set Up Your Digital Presence

Two quick tasks that help you show up as a real person in a digital course.

Trail Tip: Setting Up Your Merit Page

Your Merit page is your official record of involvement and achievement at OCTC.

Trail Tip: What's Actually Happening in That AI Chat?

Pull back the curtain on how the course AI Chats work.

Mile Marker: Mile Marker #2: My Support Team

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

Wrap Up: Module 2 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

LESSON 2.1

Skill Spotlight: Interpersonal Relations

Interacting effectively with people, and understanding what you bring to every relationship.



10 Essential Skills · #4

Interpersonal Relations

What this skill is

Interpersonal Relations is about more than being friendly.

It's the ability to understand yourself well enough to interact effectively with others. Your background, experiences, and perspective shape every conversation you have. This skill means seeing that, and respecting people who see things differently than you do. In college, at work, and in life, the people around you will be different from you in ways that matter. This skill is what lets you work alongside them, and learn from them.

Where you're headed

Kentucky describes this skill at different levels. Below, in plain terms, is the difference between where most students start and where you're headed.

SEE ALSO

Lesson 1.2 explains Benchmark, Milestone, and Capstone.

Benchmark Where you're starting

- You can describe your own perspective and experiences.
- You recognize that other people have different perspectives than yours.
- You understand that those differences affect how people interact.

Milestone

YOUR TARGET

- You can explain *how* your own background and experiences shape your relationships, not just that they do.
- You actively look for positive ways to connect and work with others.
- You engage with multiple perspectives, ideas, and beliefs instead of noticing them from a distance.

You don't have to become a different person to move from Benchmark to Milestone. What grows is your awareness of how you show up, and your intention to show up well.

Where it shows up in this module

This whole module is interpersonal relations in practice.

Mapping your support team means looking honestly at your relationships: who's in your corner, how they help, and what makes it hard to lean on them.

Reaching out to your Success Coach is a professional, specific, intentional interaction, the kind of behavior Milestone describes.

Asking for help means getting past what usually gets in the way, which is almost always interpersonal: pride, fear of judgment, or not knowing how to ask.

Talking with classmates whose situations are different from yours, and engaging with what they actually said, is how this skill grows.

In your own life

You don't have to write anything down. Just sit with these questions for a moment.

REFLECT

Think about a relationship that matters to you: a friend, a family member, a coworker. How has your background or experience shaped how you show up in that relationship?

Is there someone in your life whose perspective is very different from yours? What have you learned from that difference, or what has made it hard?

When you think about asking for help, what gets in the way? Is any of that connected to how you see yourself in relation to other people?

How it shows up later

At the end of this course, you'll write or record four short STAR(T) Stories: three for assigned skills (Adaptability & Leadership, Professionalism, and Knowledge Application) and one for a skill you choose. Interpersonal Relations is one of the most common choices for that fourth story, because it shows up in almost every meaningful experience students reflect on.

As you move through the semester, notice moments when how you interacted with someone (a teammate, an instructor, a stranger in a group project) made a real difference in what happened. Those are your stories. Start paying attention now.

Skill definition and Milestone indicators are based on the Kentucky Council on Postsecondary Education's Kentucky Graduate Profile (https://cpe.ky.gov/ourwork/kygradprofile.html).

LESSON 2.2

Who's Your Success Coach?

Every Pathfinder needs a guide. Here's how to find yours.

Your Success Coach is here to help you navigate college life, connect to resources, and stay on track toward your goals.

Knowing who they are, and how to reach them, before you need help is one of the smartest moves you can make.

PATHFINDER TIP

Already know your Success Coach? Skip ahead to Next steps.

Find your Success Coach

There are two ways to look up your coach. Use whichever one you're more comfortable with.

Option 1

Student Self-Service

1. Go to Student Self-Service (https://students.kctcs.edu/) and select **Login Here**.
2. Enter your User ID in all capital letters, for example **JSMITH0004**.
3. Enter your password and select **Sign In**.
4. Select **Main Menu → Self Service → Student Center**.
5. From your Student Homepage, select the **Advising & Classes** tile.
6. In the left menu, look for **Academic Advisor(s)**. Your Success Coach's information appears there.

SEE ALSO

You can also reach Student Self-Service through KCTCS MyPath (https://mypath.kctcs.edu/). The Student Self-Service Tutorials (https://kctcs.sharepoint.com/sites/tlc/SitePages/StudentSelf-Service.aspx) cover your schedule, enrolling, and payments.

Option 2

Starfish

1. Log in to Starfish through MyPath (https://mypath.kctcs.edu/) or from your Blackboard course menu.
2. Select **My Success Network**.
3. Find your assigned Success Coach and note their name, photo, and contact information.

Next steps

Once you've found your coach:

Save their name and contact information somewhere you'll find it: your phone contacts, a note, wherever works for you.

Submit their name in Task #2 in Blackboard. You'll use it again in Mile Marker #2.

Introduce yourself. A short email now makes it much easier to reach out later. Lesson 2.4 shows you how to write it.

PATHFINDER TIP

Your Success Coach is your compass. Check in before you're lost, not after. A quick email early in the semester is far easier than a crisis conversation near the end.

LESSON 2.3

Help-Seeking as a Strength

Asking for help is a skill successful students use every day.

College can feel like a long trail with steep climbs and unexpected turns, but no one reaches the summit alone.

Successful students know when and how to ask for help, and that's a sign of confidence and self-awareness, not weakness. Reaching out early keeps small challenges from becoming big obstacles.

> **The students who struggle most aren't the ones who don't know things. They're the ones who wait too long to ask.**

What help-seeking really means

It's more than raising your hand in class. Help-seeking means using your resources, relationships, and communication skills to stay on track before things go sideways. It can look like:

- Asking a classmate to study together.
- Emailing your instructor when you're confused about an assignment.
- Meeting with your Success Coach to talk about goals or time management.
- Visiting tutoring or the library for extra support on a specific skill.
- Reaching out to financial aid or counseling when life gets complicated.

Each of these takes initiative, which is the opposite of giving up.

> **KEY TERM**
> *Help-seeking:* reaching out to people and resources on purpose, before a small problem becomes a big one.

Four tips for confident help-seeking

You already know how to do this. When your car makes a noise you don't recognize, you ask someone. When a shift gets switched on you, you text the person who can fix it. Asking for help isn't a skill you need to build from

scratch. It's one you already have, aimed somewhere new.

With people you trust, you probably already ask early, get specific, and follow through. The tip that's new is communicating professionally, because the relationship is different.

1. ### Ask early

   Don't wait until you're overwhelmed. A question early in the semester is easier to answer than a crisis near the end.

2. ### Be specific

   Instead of "I don't get this," try "I'm confused about this part. Could you walk me through another example?" Specific questions get specific help.

3. ### Communicate professionally

   Be polite, be clear, and sign your name. Your instructors and advisors are colleagues, not customer service. You wouldn't text your instructor the way you text your cousin. It's the same skill in a different setting.

4. ### Follow through

   Use the advice you get. If someone helps you, let them know how it went. That's how professional relationships are built.

> **SEE ALSO**
> Lesson 2.4 shows what a clear, specific request looks like in an email.

OCTC support resources

You don't have to figure out where to go on your own. These are good places to start.

Success Coach

Your first stop for academic planning, course selection, and guidance when you're not sure what to do next.

Find your Success Coach

Teaching & Learning Center

Free tutoring for writing, math, and more. Use it early, not just when you're stuck.

Teaching & Learning Center (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/current-students/academic-resources/teaching-and-learning-center.aspx)

Counseling Center

For stress, motivation, or personal challenges that are affecting your ability to show up and focus.

Counseling Center (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/current-students/counseling-center/index.aspx)

Library & Research Guides

Help finding credible sources, citations, and research support for any class.

OCTC Library (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/current-students/student-resources/library/index.aspx)

Accessibility Services

Support and accommodations for students with documented disabilities. Connect early in the semester.

Accessibility Services (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/about/student-life/accessibility-services.aspx)

Student Support Services (TRIO)

Academic, financial, and personal mentoring for eligible students. Ask whether you qualify.

Student Support Services (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/about/student-life/student-support-services.aspx)

Information Technology Services

Help with logins, your KCTCS email, and software like Microsoft Office 365.

IT Services (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/current-students/information-technology/information_technology.aspx)

More student services

Career Services, Veterans Services, childcare resources, online student resources, Ready to Work, campus safety, Title IX, and how to raise a concern or complaint.

All student support services (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/about/student-life/student-support-services.aspx)

For current locations, hours, and contact information, follow the links above or visit the OCTC Current Students page (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/current-students/index.aspx). When in doubt, ask your instructor or Success Coach where to start.

Pay attention to where you are

These resources exist because OCTC knows that success depends on more than what happens in the classroom. They're here because students need them, and using them is one of the smartest moves you can make.

You don't have to be in crisis to ask for help. You just have to be paying attention to where you are on the trail.

REFLECT

Think of a time you asked for help, in school, at work, or in life, and it made things better. Who did you ask, and what made it easy to ask them? What happened? Now picture asking someone at OCTC. What would make that feel different, and what would make it easier?

LESSON 2.4

Professional Communication & Email Etiquette

Your KCTCS email is your lifeline. Here's how to use it well.

Your KCTCS email is how OCTC contacts you, not your personal Gmail or Yahoo account.

Missing messages can mean missing deadlines, financial aid updates, or important class announcements. Knowing how to get to your email, check it regularly, and write professionally keeps you on the right path from day one.

Get to your KCTCS email

On a computer

1. Log in to MyPath (https://mypath.kctcs.edu/) with your KCTCS username and password.
2. Select the **Email** tile (it shows the Outlook logo). This is the easiest way in.
3. Your inbox opens. It's automatically linked to your college account.

Another way in: once you're signed in to any Microsoft page, select the **app launcher** (the grid of nine dots, sometimes called the "waffle") in the upper-left corner. It opens all your Microsoft apps in the browser, including Outlook, Word, OneDrive, and Teams.

On your phone

Install the Outlook app and sign in with your KCTCS account. Turn on notifications so you don't miss a message.

> **SEE ALSO**
> Trail Tip: Set Up Your Digital Presence walks through the phone setup step by step.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> Check your email at least three times a week, and daily if you can. Make it part of your routine, the same way you check Blackboard.

Communicate professionally

College email isn't like texting. It reflects your professional self, and instructors notice the difference.

1

Address people correctly

Use a respectful title and last name: **Professor, Dr., Mr., or Ms.** Don't use first names unless your instructor has said it's okay. When in doubt, "Professor" works for any college instructor.

2

Write a subject line

The **subject line** is the short title you type in the **Subject** box, above your message. It's the first thing your instructor sees in their inbox, before they open your email.

Not this

> Subject: hi can u tell me if the reflection is due friday or monday because i work friday

Not this either

> Subject: (blank) or Subject: Question

This

> Subject: FYE 100 Section 201: Question About Reflection Due Date

A good subject line is short, specific, and includes your course. Your instructor can tell what you need before opening the email, and can find it again later.

KEY TERM

Subject line: the short title of an email. It tells the reader what the email is about. The message itself goes in the body below.

3

Write a clear, complete message

Every professional email has the same basic parts. Skip text shortcuts, emojis, and slang, even if your instructor seems casual in class.

Greeting
"Hello Dr. Smith,"

Introduction
"My name is Jordan Lee, and I'm in your online FYE 100, Section 201."

Purpose
"I wanted to ask whether the reflection assignment has a rubric."

Closing
"Thank you," followed by your full name

4

Stay respectful and calm

If you're upset about a grade, a deadline, or a situation, step away before you reply. Reread your email out loud and ask yourself: *would I say this in person?*

Once you hit Send, you can't take the words back. Your instructor is a real person who wants to help you succeed.

5

Be specific and prepared

Your instructor may be working with more than 100 students this semester. The more your email tells them up front, the faster they can help.

- Include the **course name and section number** in every email. Instructors often teach several sections.
- Check the **syllabus and announcements first**. Your question may already be answered there, and showing that you looked goes a long way.

See the difference

Not this

Subject: Hey

can u tell me how to do number 4 on the problem set. i no u went over it in class but i have had a VERY LONG week lol tests ha ha ha and i lost my notes. pleeease help

Stu

This
Subject: Question About Reflection Assignment Instructions

Dear Professor Brown,

I hope you're having a good start to the week!

I'm in your FYE 100, Section 203, that meets on Tuesdays and Thursdays. I wanted to ask for clarification about the reflection assignment. I've reviewed the syllabus, my notes, and the course announcements, and I also checked with a classmate. I think the reflection is supposed to be posted to a separate portal, but I want to make sure before I submit.

Could you please confirm where we should post it?

Thank you for your time and help!

Sincerely,
Jordan Lee

Quick check before you hit Send

- [ ] A short, specific subject line that includes your course (your message goes in the body, not the subject)
- [ ] Professional greeting with the correct title
- [ ] Your name and course/section number
- [ ] A clear, specific message with no text slang or shortcuts
- [ ] You checked the syllabus or announcements first
- [ ] A polite closing with your full name
- [ ] A respectful, calm tone (read it out loud)

Professional communication builds respect with instructors and staff, gets you answers faster, and practices skills you'll use in every job you ever have. **Every email you send is a small but real picture of who you are as a student and a professional. Make it count.**

TRAIL TIP

Set Up Your Digital Presence

Two quick tasks that help you show up as a real person in a digital course.

Optional · Highly recommended

Two quick tasks that help you show up as a real person in a digital course.

Online courses can feel anonymous. A profile photo and working email on your phone go a long way toward making you feel like a real participant rather than a username in a gradebook.

Instructors will tell you it's genuinely nice to see faces on discussion posts and in the gradebook. It makes a course feel like a community. Take five minutes and do these.

1 Put your KCTCS email on your phone

Your KCTCS email is how OCTC reaches you about everything that matters: class announcements, financial aid, deadlines, and instructor messages. Having it on your phone means you'll actually see them.

BEFORE YOU START

Install and set up the **Microsoft Authenticator** app first. It's required for secure sign-in and protects your account. Search "Microsoft Authenticator" in the App Store or Google Play.

Install the Outlook app

- Go to the **App Store** (iPhone) or **Google Play** (Android).
- Search for **Microsoft Outlook** and install it.

Add your KCTCS account

1. Open the Outlook app.
2. Tap **Add Account**, or enter your school email address if you're prompted.
3. Enter your KCTCS email address. It looks like **jdoe0000@kctcs.edu**.
4. Tap **Add Account** or **Continue**.
5. You'll be taken to the KCTCS sign-in page. Enter your full KCTCS email and password.
6. Follow any security prompts that appear.

Verify your sign-in

- If you're asked, approve the sign-in in the **Microsoft Authenticator** app.
- Once you're verified, your KCTCS email starts syncing automatically.

You're all set. You can now send and receive KCTCS email from your phone.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> Turn on notifications for Outlook. Missing a message from your instructor or financial aid can have real consequences.

2 Add a photo to your profiles

A photo on your Blackboard and Microsoft profiles takes a few minutes and makes a real difference in how connected your online courses feel, for you and for everyone you work with.

> **SEE ALSO**
> Lesson 1.5 lists the steps for your Blackboard profile.

How to update your Blackboard profile

Add a photo so your instructor and classmates can put a face to your name.

Watch the video (https://www.loom.com/share/22ec582e280e4a91a78026e08af1a280?sid=96a71fca-d4c3-4b34-94b2-02641a3c8a21)

How to update your Microsoft profile

Your Microsoft photo appears in Outlook, Teams, and the other Office apps you'll use at OCTC.

Watch the video (https://www.loom.com/share/9331e2c8815a40f884fff8010b65f32b?sid=4e940b82-f8d0-41da-8822-cbe1b4375ba4)

Prefer steps to a video?

1. Go to myaccount.microsoft.com (https://myaccount.microsoft.com/).
2. Sign in with your full KCTCS email address and password.
3. Select **Personal Info** from the left menu.
4. Select your current photo or initials, then **Upload a new photo**. Choose an image and select **Save**.

5. Your photo appears across Outlook, Teams, and Word Online within a few minutes.

PATHFINDER TIP

You don't need a professional headshot. A clear, recent photo where people can see your face is all it takes.

TRAIL TIP

Setting Up Your Merit Page

Your Merit page is your official record of involvement and achievement at OCTC.

Merit is OCTC's official student recognition platform.

It tracks your accomplishments, activities, and achievements throughout your time at OCTC, including the Merit activities for this course. Setting up your page takes less than ten minutes.

CAN'T GET IN YET? THAT'S NORMAL.

OCTC's Student Affairs office adds students to Merit **after the add/drop period ends**. If your invitation hasn't arrived, or your login doesn't work yet, wait a day or two and try again.

Still stuck after that? Let your instructor know. They'll follow up with the Student Affairs office for you.

What your Merit page does for you

Celebrates your involvement

Documents your participation in campus and community life beyond the classroom.

Builds your digital presence

A professional profile you can share with family, employers, and future programs.

Tracks your activities

A single place to record the events and activities you take part in, including the ones your courses ask for.

Set up your page

1 Check for your invitation email

Look in your KCTCS email for an invitation with this subject line:

"Claim Your Merit Page at Owensboro Community & Technical College"

Open it and select **Claim My Page**.

> **DIDN'T GET THE EMAIL?**
>
> Go to owensboro-kctcs.meritpages.com (https://owensboro-kctcs.meritpages.com/), select **Sign In**, then **Forgot Password**, and enter your KCTCS student email to activate your account.

2 Claim and personalize your page

Once you're logged in, take a few minutes to make it yours:

1. Add a profile photo (optional, but encouraged).
2. Review your bio and update your academic program, hometown, and goals.
3. Link your LinkedIn profile if you have one.
4. Review any preloaded achievements, such as Dean's List or program awards.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
>
> Keep your Merit page professional: a friendly photo, proper capitalization, and short, clear sentences. Think college résumé, not social media.

3 Stay connected

After you claim your page, you'll get notifications automatically when:

- You attend a Merit-approved event
- You're recognized for an achievement or milestone
- OCTC adds new updates

Keep an eye on your KCTCS email for Merit updates.

4

Find and customize your profile URL

Merit assigns your page a web address when you claim it. To make it easier to share, go to **My Account → Merit Page Settings**. You can personalize the address and add profile and background photos there.

Examplehttps://meritpages.com/yourname

PATHFINDER TIP

Copy your Merit page address and save it somewhere handy. You'll need it whenever you're asked to share your page.

Helpful links

- OCTC Merit home page (https://owensboro-kctcs.meritpages.com/)
- KCTCS student email login (MyPath) (https://mypath.kctcs.edu/)

Merit helps you track and share your growth, so set it up now while it only takes a few minutes.

The Merit Guide

Everything else about your three Merit activities, including how to find one, what proof to include, and how to write your reflection, is in the Merit Guide at the back of this book.

Open the Merit Guide

TRAIL TIP

What's Actually Happening in That AI Chat?

Pull back the curtain on how the course AI Chats work.

Pull back the curtain. Knowing how it works makes you better at using it.

Before you open your first AI Chat in this course, it helps to see something most people never do. It isn't a secret, but nobody usually takes the time to explain it: the AI Chats in this course aren't a generic chatbot pointed at you. Each one was set up inside Blackboard for a specific moment in your learning, with a specific purpose.

What is a large language model?

Tools like ChatGPT, Copilot, and the AI Chats in this course are all powered by a **large language model**: an AI system trained on enormous amounts of text, so it can predict and generate language that sounds clear and relevant.

On its own, it's a very capable generalist. It has read more text than any person ever could, and it can discuss almost any topic. But it doesn't know who you are, what class you're in, or what you're supposed to be thinking about today. Until someone gives it direction, it's just potential.

> **An AI is only as useful as the directions it's been given.**

LOOK BACK AT

Lesson 1.3: What's AI, Really?

The part nobody shows you: the setup

Before you type your first message, the AI has already read a set of instructions you don't see. Those instructions tell it how to behave in this specific chat.

For the AI Chats in this course, the instructions come from the setup in Blackboard: the type of chat, the topic, the coach's name and personality, how it should respond, and how complex its answers should be. Blackboard turns those choices into instructions the AI reads first, and they shape everything that happens next.

KEY TERM

System prompt: the hidden instructions an AI reads before a conversation starts. Almost every AI tool has one.

Below is a simplified example of what those instructions might say for one of the chats in this course. It isn't the exact setup, but it's close.

> Simplified example: how Coach Pathfinder gets set up
>
> - **Role:** You are Coach Pathfinder, a warm, direct coach for first-year college students at OCTC.
> - **Purpose:** Help this student think through their support network and what it means to ask for help. Ask questions that help them find their own answers.
> - **Tone:** Encouraging but honest. Treat the student as capable. Don't be generic or vague.
> - **Opening:** Welcome the student and ask: "When things get hard in college, what's your instinct: push through alone, or reach out? Tell me about that."
> - **Rule:** "Do not write the student's answers for them. Your job is to help them find what they already know."
> - **Guardrails:** Stay on the topic. If the student asks you to do their homework, guide them back to reflecting.

The same AI that could draft a legal brief or explain quantum physics has been given one specific job, and it does that job every time a student opens that chat.

Same AI, completely different behavior

The engine underneath is the same kind of AI used all over the world. What it does depends on what it's been told to do. Look at the same message, typed into two setups:

"I'm struggling to ask for help."

WITHOUT COURSE INSTRUCTIONS

Five generic tips, a suggested app, a reminder that everyone struggles, and an encouraging emoji. Helpful in a general way, but not very useful for you, right now.

WITH THE COURSE SETUP

"Tell me more. Is it that you don't know who to ask, or that asking feels uncomfortable? What's underneath it?" It doesn't answer for you. It pushes you to figure out what you think.

Two kinds of AI Chats in this course

Socratic

Coach Pathfinder asks you questions, one at a time, to help you think something through. It won't hand you answers.

Modules 2, 8, and 9

Role-play

You work through a scenario with the AI playing a part. You do the thinking and the evaluating as the scenario unfolds.

Module 4

What this means for you

1. ### It has a job to do

   The AI Chats aren't here to answer every question you have. Each one has a purpose, usually to help you think, not to think for you. If it keeps asking you questions instead of giving answers, it's doing what it was set up to do.

2. ### Your instructor can see the conversation

   After you submit, your instructor can review the whole chat. That's how you get credit, and how your instructor learns whether the activity is working. Have an honest conversation.

3. ### It can still be wrong

   Even with good instructions, the AI can misunderstand you, wander off track, or say something that doesn't land. Each chat ends with a reflection question where you can say what worked and point out anything that seemed wrong or biased.

4. ### Have a concern? Talk with your instructor

   If you have a concern about using the AI Chats, talk with your instructor before the chat is due. That might be an accommodation, a privacy worry, or just not feeling comfortable with AI. Your instructor can work out another way for you to complete it.

AI Literacy BE Safe BE Critical

The AI Chats use Blackboard's AI Conversation tool, which runs on Microsoft's Azure OpenAI Service. According to Blackboard, your conversation isn't used to retrain the AI. It's saved with your assignment, where

your instructor can review it.

The same rule applies here as with any AI tool: don't share other people's personal information, passwords, or anything private in the chat.

Next time you use any AI tool, ask yourself: what was this told to do before I showed up? The answer shapes everything you're about to experience. That question is the beginning of AI literacy.
Behind every AI Chat are instructions, context, and a very capable language engine pointed in a specific direction by a person with a goal. In this course, the goal is your learning. Now go have an honest conversation.

MILE MARKER

Mile Marker #2: My Support Team

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

No one completes a journey alone.

This Mile Marker is about the people and resources around you, and how you'll use them on purpose. You'll come back to it when you build your capstone project.

What you'll do

1. **Before you start,** find your Success Coach. Your AI Chat, Who Has Your Back?, also helps with Question 1.
   - Lesson 2.2: Who's Your Success Coach? (you'll need your coach's name for Question 1)
2. **Answer three questions** in the form below.
3. **Save as PDF** and upload it to the **Mile Marker #2** assignment in Blackboard.

●○ AI use: AI-supported

You may use AI as a thinking partner to explore your ideas. Work with what it gives you, then write your responses in your own voice. AI isn't a substitute for people: if you're dealing with stress or anything personal, reach out to your instructor, your Success Coach, or the OCTC Counseling Center. See the AI Course Policy in the syllabus and Lesson 1.4: AI use labels.

Optional prompt to try: "Ask me questions to help me identify the people and resources in my life that support my success as a college student, and how I can use them more intentionally this semester." Use what's useful. Your final responses must be in your own words.

Your Mile Marker

Type your answers in the boxes. Your typing is saved in this browser as you go, so you can come back later on the same device. Nothing is sent anywhere until you upload it.

Your name (required) | **Date**

QUESTION 1

Three People at OCTC

Start with your Success Coach. At least two of your three should work at OCTC: an instructor, a tutor, a peer mentor, or someone in an office like TRIO, Counseling, or the Library. A classmate can be your third.

A STRONG ANSWER

Names **three people at OCTC**, at least two who work here, including your **Success Coach by name**, and says **how each one can help**. A person, not an office. If you don't know a name yet, say who they are and where you'd find them.

1. Your Success Coach

2. A second person at OCTC

3. A third person at OCTC (a classmate can count)

4. Optional: Who else is in your corner? Family, friends, coworkers, or mentors.

Look back at: Lesson 2.2: Who's Your Success Coach?; Lesson 2.3: OCTC support resources

QUESTION 2

Using Your Network

Not just "I'll reach out when I need help," but when, how, and for what.

To get you thinking (no separate answer needed)

- Which connections do you want to strengthen this semester?

A STRONG ANSWER

Describes **two specific ways** you'll use your network, each with **when, how, and for what** you'll reach out.

1. Describe the first way you'll use your support network this semester.

2. Describe a second way.

Look back at: Lesson 2.3: Four tips for confident help-seeking

QUESTION 3

One New Resource

Choose one you haven't used yet, such as the Teaching & Learning Center (tutoring), the Counseling Center, the Library, Accessibility Services, TRIO, Career Services, Student Life and clubs, or Financial Aid.

A STRONG ANSWER

Names a resource **you haven't used yet**, explains how it **connects to your goals**, and names **one concrete next step**.

1. Name one campus resource you want to explore.

2. Explain what it offers and how it connects to your goals.

3. Name one next step you'll take to use it.

Look back at: Lesson 2.3: OCTC support resources

Submit it

Upload your PDF to the **Mile Marker #2** assignment in Blackboard. Check Blackboard for the due date.

In an in-person class? Your instructor may give you a printed copy. Fill it in by hand, then upload a photo or scan.

How it's scored: full credit means every prompt is answered, and each answer is about you, with at least one real detail. See How Mile Markers are scored.

WRAP UP

Module 2 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

You've reached the end of Module 2. These are the ideas to carry forward.

Key takeaways

No one does this alone. The students who struggle most are usually the ones who wait too long to ask, not the ones who know the least.

Interpersonal Relations starts with self-awareness. How you show up with other people shapes what help you ask for, and what help you get.

Know your Success Coach before you need them. Save their contact information and introduce yourself early.

Help-seeking is a skill you already have. Ask early, be specific, communicate professionally, and follow through.

OCTC has more support than most students use. Tutoring, counseling, accessibility, TRIO, the library, and IT are all there for you.

Your email is part of your professional reputation. Write a clear subject line, use a greeting, name your course, ask a clear question, and close politely.

REFLECT

Who is one person or resource you haven't reached out to yet, but should? What's one small step you could take this week to connect with them?

That's Module 2.

Head back to your course in Blackboard for this module's activities.

MODULE 3

My Time Plan — Managing Time & Energy

You have the same 168 hours as everyone else. This module is about figuring out where yours are actually going.

10 ESSENTIAL SKILLS IN THIS MODULE


#5 Adaptability & Leadership


#6 Professionalism

Why this matters

Most students who struggle academically are overwhelmed, under-rested, and running on empty, not lazy, and they often don't realize it until things start falling apart.

This module asks you to look honestly at where your time and energy are actually going: not the week you wish you had, but the one you actually live, because that's the honest starting point for building something better.

What you'll be able to do

By the end of this module:

A
I can analyze how I currently spend my time and identify at least one pattern or time-waster.

B
I can create a realistic weekly schedule that reflects my actual priorities and commitments.

C
I can identify which of my five energy batteries needs the most attention and describe one way I will recharge it.

D

I can describe one small habit or adjustment I will make to manage my time more effectively.

AI Literacy: BE behaviors in this module

- BE Responsible

Lessons in this module

Trail Tool: Where My Time Goes

Look back: an honest log of where your time and energy actually go.

Trail Tool: My Week at a Glance

Look ahead: plan from your priorities, not from empty boxes.

3.1 Skill Spotlight: Professionalism

Being reliable, accountable, and intentional, not perfect.

3.2 Map Your Week

Before the week runs you, run the week.

3.3 Run the Day (Don't Let It Run You)

Small, intentional decisions, made consistently, are how the day becomes yours.

3.4 The Multitasking Myth

You're not doing two things at once. You're switching really fast, and paying for it.

3.5 The Five Batteries: Running Low vs. Running Out

Understanding your energy before it's gone, and what burnout actually is.

Bonus Read: Divergent Minds: Your Brain, Your Way

Some brains work differently. That's not a flaw, but it does matter.

Mile Marker: Mile Marker #3: Managing My Time & Energy

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

Wrap Up: Module 3 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

TRAIL TOOL

Where My Time Goes

Look back: an honest log of where your time and energy actually go.

Before you can plan your time well, you need an honest picture of where it's actually going: not the week you meant to have, but the one you really had.

This tracker is a reality check. For each day, jot down what you actually did in the morning, afternoon, and evening, and how your energy felt. It takes a few minutes at the end of the day. Nobody grades this log, and there are no wrong answers.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> Start today. Aim for a full week. If your Mile Marker is due sooner, log as many days as you can. Even three honest days will show you something.

Two tools, two jobs

Look back: Where My Time Goes

A **reality check**. Log what actually happened with your time and energy, day by day. No judging, no fixing yet. Just notice.

Use it for: Mile Marker #3, Question 1

YOU ARE HERE

Look ahead: My Week at a Glance

A **plan**. Use what you learned from looking back to map your priorities into the week ahead.

Use it for: Mile Marker #3, Question 3

Open My Week at a Glance

How to log honestly

Write what happened, not what you planned. "Meant to study, ended up on my phone" is more useful than "study."

Keep it short. A few words per block is plenty: "work shift," "class, then errands," "TV and scrolling."

Check your energy. Low, OK, or high. This is how you'll find your best hours.

Log it the same day. By tomorrow, you'll remember the day you meant to have.

LOOK AHEAD

Lesson 3.3 names common time-wasters. Lesson 3.5 explains energy.

Fill in your log

Your entries save in this browser as you go, so you can come back each day on the same device. When your week is done, select **Save as PDF** to keep a copy. You may attach it to Mile Marker #3 if you like, but you don't have to.

Your name (required)

Week starting

Monday

MORNING	AFTERNOON	EVENING
Circle one: Low / OK / High	Circle one: Low / OK / High	Circle one: Low / OK / High

Tuesday

MORNING	AFTERNOON	EVENING
Circle one: Low / OK / High	Circle one: Low / OK / High	Circle one: Low / OK / High

Wednesday

MORNING	AFTERNOON	EVENING
Circle one: Low / OK / High	Circle one: Low / OK / High	Circle one: Low / OK / High

Thursday

MORNING	AFTERNOON	EVENING
Circle one: Low / OK / High	Circle one: Low / OK / High	Circle one: Low / OK / High

Friday

MORNING	AFTERNOON	EVENING
Circle one: Low / OK / High	Circle one: Low / OK / High	Circle one: Low / OK / High

Saturday

MORNING	AFTERNOON	EVENING
Circle one: Low / OK / High	Circle one: Low / OK / High	Circle one: Low / OK / High

Sunday

MORNING	AFTERNOON	EVENING
Circle one: Low / OK / High	Circle one: Low / OK / High	Circle one: Low / OK / High

LOOKING BACK

What does your week tell you?

When were you most focused or productive? What was different about that time?

Where did time slip away? Name any time-wasters you spotted.

One pattern you notice about how your time and energy actually move

TRAIL TOOL

My Week at a Glance

Look ahead: plan from your priorities, not from empty boxes.

Plan from your priorities, not from empty boxes.

This planner walks you through the three steps from Lesson 3.2 in order: name your priorities, know your energy, then block your week. Use what your time log showed you. If mornings kept slipping away or evenings were your best hours, plan for that.

LOOK BACK AT

Lesson 3.2: Map your week in three steps

Two tools, two jobs

Look back: Where My Time Goes

A **reality check**. Log what actually happened with your time and energy, day by day. No judging, no fixing yet. Just notice.

Use it for: Mile Marker #3, Question 1

Open Where My Time Goes

Look ahead: My Week at a Glance

A **plan**. Use what you learned from looking back to map your priorities into the week ahead.

Use it for: Mile Marker #3, Question 3

YOU ARE HERE

Plan your week

Your plan saves in this browser as you go. Select **Save as PDF** to keep a copy or print it for your fridge, your binder, or your phone's photos. You may attach it to Mile Marker #3 if you like, but you don't have to.

PATHFINDER TIP

This is a tool, not a contract, and plans change. The point is to start with intention instead of reacting to whatever shows up.

Your name (required) _____ **Week of** _____

STEP 1

Name your priorities first

List up to five things that need to happen this week. Tag each one: **Must** (non-negotiable), **Should** (important but flexible), or **Could** (nice if time allows).

1 _____ Circle one: Must / Should / Could

2 _____ Circle one: Must / Should / Could

3 _____ Circle one: Must / Should / Could

4 _____ Circle one: Must / Should / Could

5 _____ Circle one: Must / Should / Could

STEP 2

Know your energy

When am I at my best this week? _____

When do I usually hit a wall? _____

STEP 3

Block your week

Put your Musts and Shoulds in your best hours. You don't need to fill every box. White space is part of the plan.

Monday

MORNING	AFTERNOON	EVENING

Tuesday

MORNING	AFTERNOON	EVENING

Wednesday

MORNING	AFTERNOON	EVENING

Thursday

MORNING	AFTERNOON	EVENING

Friday

MORNING	AFTERNOON	EVENING

Saturday

MORNING	AFTERNOON	EVENING

Sunday

MORNING	AFTERNOON	EVENING

CHECK YOUR PLAN

Does it fit your real life?

One part of this plan that reflects what I value most

Notes: things to remember this week

LESSON 3.1

Skill Spotlight: Professionalism

Being reliable, accountable, and intentional, not perfect.



10 Essential Skills · #6

Professionalism

What this skill is

Professionalism can sound vague, like something that happens in an office somewhere, after college, when you're wearing different clothes.

Kentucky's definition is more specific and more immediate than that. Professionalism means acting with honesty and fairness, managing your time and tasks, taking initiative, and being accountable for your own actions, including your mistakes.

Professionalism is a pattern of behavior, not a performance, and that pattern either builds or erodes trust over time. It starts right now, in how you show up for this course.

> **Professionalism means being someone people can count on, not being perfect.**

Where you're headed

Below, in plain terms, is the difference between where most students start and where you're headed.

SEE ALSO

Lesson 1.2 explains Benchmark, Milestone, and Capstone.

Benchmark Where you're starting

- You treat people honestly and fairly in your interactions.
- You know that deadlines and punctuality matter for success.
- You follow through on obligations and commitments.
- You're curious about professional fields and what they require.

Milestone

YOUR TARGET

- You can describe what ethical behavior looks like, and you make choices that reflect it.
- You use organization and time management skills to prioritize and complete tasks, not just intend to.
- You take personal accountability for your actions, including when things go wrong.
- You communicate using the language and tools of your field.

The shift from Benchmark to Milestone is the shift from knowing what professionalism looks like to doing it consistently, including when it isn't easy.

Where it shows up in this module

Module 3 is where Professionalism gets personal. Here, time management and organization are the content of the module itself.

Planning your week. Setting priorities before you fill in your schedule is an organizational skill, not busywork. At the Milestone level, your plan reflects real priorities instead of good intentions.

Managing your day. Protecting your best hours, starting before you feel ready, and recovering when a day goes sideways is time management where it counts.

Taking accountability. When an assignment is late, when you miss something, when you're overwhelmed, how you respond is a professionalism moment. Reaching out early, owning the situation, and asking for help are Milestone behaviors.

Knowing your limits. Understanding when you're sharp and when you're running low, and planning around it, is self-management. Professionalism means working with how you actually function, not grinding through exhaustion.

In your own life

You don't have to write anything down. Just sit with these questions honestly.

REFLECT

Think about someone in your life (a coworker, a family member, a former teacher) you'd describe as truly professional. What specifically do they do that earns that description?

Where do you feel most confident in your own professionalism right now? Where do you feel the gap between where you are and where you want to be?

When something goes wrong, like a missed deadline or a forgotten commitment, what's your default response? Is it building trust with the people around you, or wearing it down?

How it shows up later

Professionalism is one of the three assigned skills for your STAR(T) Stories at the end of this course. You'll write or record one story that shows this skill in action, which means the experiences you're having right now are possible material. It's also the skill this course assesses in Mile Marker #8, when you evaluate a career for how well it fits you.

Pay attention to moments this semester when you showed accountability, managed your time under real pressure, or made a professional choice when it would have been easier not to. Those moments are your stories, and the habit of noticing them starts now.

Skill definition and Milestone indicators are based on the Kentucky Council on Postsecondary Education's Kentucky Graduate Profile (https://cpe.ky.gov/ourwork/kygradprofile.html).

LESSON 3.2

Map Your Week

Before the week runs you, run the week.

Students who fall behind usually care. What happened is that Monday arrived before they knew what it was going to ask of them.

A weekly map doesn't solve everything, but it means you're never caught completely off guard. You don't need a perfect schedule. You need five minutes at the start of the week to see what you're actually dealing with, so you can make better decisions when the week gets complicated.

> **The goal is a plan that helps you recover faster when things go sideways, not one you follow perfectly.**

Look back, then look ahead

This module gives you two tools, and they do different jobs. **Tracking** is looking back: an honest record of where your time and energy actually went. **Planning** is looking ahead: deciding where your time should go next week. You need the first to do the second well. A plan built on the week you wish you had won't survive the week you actually have.

Look back: Where My Time Goes

A **reality check**. Log what actually happened with your time and energy, day by day. No judging, no fixing yet. Just notice.

Use it for: Mile Marker #3, Question 1

Open Where My Time Goes

Look ahead: My Week at a Glance

A **plan**. Use what you learned from looking back to map your priorities into the week ahead.

Use it for: Mile Marker #3, Question 3

Open My Week at a Glance

Map your week in three steps

1 Name your priorities before you touch the calendar

Before you look at a single time slot, answer one question: **What absolutely has to happen this week?** Then sort your priorities into three buckets.

MUST
Non-negotiable. Missing this has real consequences.

SHOULD
Important, but could flex if something urgent comes up.

COULD
Nice to do, but it won't derail your week if it waits.

Most students have two or three Musts, a handful of Shoulds, and a long list of Coulds they'll never get to, and that's normal. The point is knowing which is which before the week decides for you.

PATHFINDER TIP
If everything feels like a Must, it isn't. Push back on yourself. What actually has a deadline? What actually has consequences? Start there.

2 Know your energy before you block your time

Before you drop anything into a time block, ask yourself: **When am I actually sharp this week?** Not when you think you should be productive, but when you actually are. Are you a morning person or a night owl? Does your energy crash after lunch? Do you need a slow start before you hit your stride?

Put your most important work in your best hours. Don't schedule a hard assignment for the time of day when you're running on empty.

PATHFINDER TIP
Your best hours are your most valuable resource. Protect them the way you'd protect a meeting with someone important, because you are someone important.

3 Block broadly, and leave white space

Place your Musts and Shoulds into a morning, afternoon, and evening grid. You don't need to schedule every hour. Anchor your priorities to the times you're most likely to do them.

Then leave gaps. White space is where you handle the unexpected, move between tasks, eat lunch without rushing, and remember that you're a person, not a productivity machine.

- Weekends are for rest as well as catching up. Plan them that way on purpose.
- Buffer time between commitments is part of the plan, not a failure of the plan.
- If every block is full, something won't happen. Decide in advance what flexes.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> A plan with white space is more realistic than a packed plan, and a realistic plan is the only kind that works.

What gets in the way

These are the most common planning mistakes, and what to do instead.

MISTAKE
Planning from empty boxes. Filling in a schedule without knowing your priorities first. The schedule looks full, but nothing important is protected.

INSTEAD
Priorities first, schedule second. Name your Musts before you touch the calendar. Then place them in your best hours.

MISTAKE
Planning for your best self. Scheduling six hours of focused study on a day you work a full shift and have a family commitment. It won't happen.

INSTEAD
Planning for your real self. Be honest about what's actually possible each day. A small, realistic plan beats a big, aspirational one every time.

MISTAKE
Treating the plan like a contract. When something disrupts the plan, giving up entirely because "the week is ruined." One missed block isn't a failed week.

INSTEAD
Using the plan to recover. When something shifts, look at the plan and ask: what's the next best move? The plan helps you recover. It doesn't have to be followed perfectly.

Lookout: Ask Your Success Coach



If you've mapped your week honestly and the hours still don't fit, talk with your Success Coach. Your coach can help you decide whether to adjust your plan or change your schedule.

After the add period ends, you can't swap one course for another. Your options are usually to withdraw from a course, and possibly to add a shorter bi-term course. Either one can affect your financial aid, so talk with your coach **before** you make a change. Your coach can also help you choose a course load for next semester that fits your schedule.

Not sure who your coach is? Lesson 2.2 shows you how to find them.

Five minutes to start

Students who manage their time well still get overwhelmed. The difference is that they know what they're dealing with **before** it overwhelms them, and they have a map to find their way back when it does.

Getting started takes five minutes on Sunday evening or Monday morning.

Try it: My Week at a Glance

A fill-in planner that walks you through priorities first, then time blocking, in exactly the order this lesson describes. It saves as you go, and you can save it as a PDF or print it.

Open My Week at a Glance

LESSON 3.3

Run the Day (Don't Let It Run You)

Small, intentional decisions, made consistently, are how the day becomes yours.

> **"The bad news is time flies. The good news is you're the pilot."**
>
> Michael Altshuler

You've heard "time flies" your whole life, usually as the reason something didn't happen: the assignment that didn't get done, the week that got away, the semester that's almost over before you noticed it going.

Time doesn't fly on its own, though. Days fill up because we let them, with the urgent instead of the important, the easy instead of the necessary, and the scroll instead of the start. You're already in the cockpit, and the question is whether you're flying the plane or along for the ride. This lesson covers four small moves that help you run the day instead of letting the day run you.

Four moves that keep you in the cockpit

1 Find your best hour, and protect it

Every day you have at least one window when your brain is working well. Maybe it's first thing in the morning, before everything else starts pulling at you. Maybe it's late evening, when the house is finally quiet. Maybe it's the 45 minutes between classes when you're already in the zone.

That window is the most valuable part of your day, so learn when it is and save it for your most important work. Watch for the time-wasters that feel like breaks but quietly drain the hour before you notice it's gone:

- **Phone scrolling.** Social media, videos, anything that pulls you in. You pick it up for two minutes and look up 40 minutes later.
- **Notification interruptions.** Every buzz pulls you out of focus, and it takes longer than you think to get back in.
- **Fake productivity.** Reorganizing notes, color-coding your planner, making a to-do list instead of doing it. It feels like work, but nothing on the list gets done.
- **Easy stuff in your best hours.** Handling low-effort tasks during your peak window because they feel satisfying. Save the easy stuff for when your energy is low.
- **Avoidance dressed up as something else.** Cleaning your space, texting to stay connected, watching one more episode because the task feels too big to start.

PATHFINDER TIP

You probably already know when your best hour is. You may even know whether you're reading this in a good window or a bad one. When your best hour arrives, put your phone face down and out of reach, even in another room if you can.

2 Start before you feel ready

For almost any task, starting is harder than finishing. Your brain resists beginning something unfamiliar, uncomfortable, or uncertain, and it will find a hundred small things to do instead. That's how brains work, especially under stress, and it doesn't mean you're lazy. Avoidance often looks like something reasonable:

- **Over-preparing.** Gathering every resource and watching every tutorial before touching the actual task. Preparation becomes its own avoidance.
- **Helping someone else first.** Being genuinely useful to a friend or family member when your own work needs to happen. Doing your work first isn't selfish.
- **The clean-space trap.** The desk has to be organized, the dishes done, the room perfect before you can possibly begin. It never is.
- **Research spirals.** Looking up one thing for an assignment and ending up somewhere completely unrelated 30 minutes later.

So start anyway. Open the document and write one sentence, or read the first paragraph, or do the first problem. The first two minutes are the hardest. Once you've begun, the resistance drops and the task starts to feel manageable.

PATHFINDER TIP

If starting is hard for you most of the time, and not only once in a while, pay attention to that. It isn't a character flaw, and there are strategies that help.

LOOK AHEAD

Divergent Minds: Your Brain, Your Way, this module's bonus read, explains why starting is harder for some brains, and what helps.

3 Handle the small stuff when it shows up

A simple rule helps here: **if something takes less than two minutes, do it now.** Reply to the email, submit the quick task, or send the message to your instructor. Small things that pile up are one of the most common causes of low-grade overwhelm, that feeling of always being behind without knowing why. Handle them when they show up, before they stack into a list that feels heavy before you've started.

PATHFINDER TIP

The flip side: if something takes more than two minutes, don't start it in a two-minute window. Give it a real block in your weekly plan. Starting something you can't finish creates more mental clutter than not starting it at all.

4 Recover, don't catastrophize

> **"Either you run the day, or the day runs you."**
>
> Jim Rohn

Some days go sideways. A kid gets sick, work runs long, or you sleep through your alarm, and the plan falls apart before noon. You don't have to rescue the whole day. Ask one question instead: **What's the next best thing I can do right now?** Not the ideal thing, and not what you would have done if the day had gone as planned, but the next good move in the situation you're actually in.

- A day that went sideways but ended with one task done is better than one that ended with none.
- Missing a block isn't failing the week. Giving up on the week after missing one block is.
- Recovery is a skill, and like every skill, it gets easier with practice.

PATHFINDER TIP

Students who manage their time well still have bad days. They just recover faster. Your plan is a tool for getting back on track, not a standard you've failed to meet.

What running the day sounds like

It comes down to small decisions, made on purpose, at a few moments in the day.

MORNING

“Before I check my phone, I'm going to look at what has to happen today.”

BEFORE CLASS

“I have 20 minutes. I'm going to use them to start the reading, not scroll.”

WHEN YOU'RE STUCK

“I don't have to finish this. I just have to do the next small thing.”

WHEN THE DAY GOES WRONG

“What's one thing I can still do today that would make this day count?”

BEFORE BED

“What's the one thing tomorrow needs from me? I'll put it somewhere I'll see it.”

END OF THE WEEK

“What did I actually get done? What did I learn about how my week works?”

You're the pilot

> **"Until we can manage time, we can manage nothing else."**
>
> Peter Drucker

Drucker saw time management as the skill underneath all the others. When your time gets away from you, everything else suffers: your grades, your relationships, your energy, and your sense of control over your own life.

You don't need a perfect system. You need to decide, each day, that you're the pilot: that you're going to run the day, even imperfectly and even on the hard days, rather than let it run you.

Make one good decision, and then the next one.

LESSON 3.4

The Multitasking Myth

You're not doing two things at once. You're switching really fast, and paying for it.

Most people believe they're good at multitasking. The research says that multitasking, the way we usually mean it, doesn't really exist.

What we call multitasking is rapid task-switching. Your brain moves back and forth between tasks in quick succession: one thing, then another, then back to the first. It never does two at once, and every switch costs something.

> **What feels like multitasking is task-switching, and every switch has a price.**

The cost nobody talks about

When you switch from one task to another, your brain doesn't just pick up where it left off. It has to reorient: figure out where it was, what it was doing, and what comes next. Researchers call this the **switching cost**, and it adds up faster than you'd expect.

Research on interruptions has found that it can take more than 20 minutes to get back to a task after being pulled away from it. So every time you stop to check your phone, reply to a message, or flip between tabs, you may be losing far more than a few seconds.

KEY TERM

Switching cost: the time and mental effort it takes to get back up to speed after you move from one task to another.

Does any of this sound familiar?

STUDYING

"I'll just check this notification real quick…" Fifteen minutes later, you're somewhere completely different.

IN CLASS

You're half-listening while scrolling, then realize you missed something important and have no idea when it happened.

WORKING ON AN ASSIGNMENT

You have three tabs open, a text conversation going, and the TV on, and nothing feels like it's getting done.

GETTING READY TO START

You've been "about to start" for 45 minutes, but every time you almost begin, something pulls you away again.

Transition friction: why switching is harder than it looks

Beyond the switching cost, there's something else worth naming: **transition friction**. It's the resistance your brain feels when it moves from one task to another: the mental drag of leaving something unfinished, reorienting to something new, and rebuilding momentum from scratch.

For most people, transition friction is a minor inconvenience. For some brains, including those with ADHD or other executive function differences, it can feel like a wall. The task itself may not be hard. Getting started on it after switching away from something else is.

KEY TERM

Transition friction: the resistance you feel when moving from one task, place, or mental state to another.

If this lands harder for you

If switching between tasks is noticeably more disruptive for you than it seems to be for others, that's real, and it's worth paying attention to. Some things that help:

- **Finish a thought before you switch.** Before you respond to a notification or move to a new task, write down exactly where you are and what comes next. Even one sentence makes coming back much easier.
- **Build transitions into your plan.** Don't schedule tasks back to back with no buffer. Give yourself five minutes between subjects, places, or types of work. That time is necessary, not wasted.
- **Batch your interruptions.** Instead of answering every notification as it arrives, pick specific times to check messages. Your focus stays intact in between.

PATHFINDER TIP

Remember the phone face-down rule from Lesson 3.3? It's about more than willpower. Every notification that pulls you away is a task switch, and a switching cost. Face down and out of reach means fewer switches.

You don't need to eliminate all task-switching, and you couldn't if you tried. Noticing when you're doing it, and what it costs you, is the first step toward protecting the focus you have. **So start by noticing.**

LESSON 3.5

The Five Batteries: Running Low vs. Running Out

Understanding your energy before it's gone, and what burnout actually is.

Most conversations about time management treat time like the only resource that matters. But you've probably noticed that having time isn't always enough.

You can have a free afternoon and still get nothing done, not because you're lazy, but because something else is empty. That something else is energy, and energy comes in five different forms. When even one of them runs critically low, everything gets harder: focus, motivation, patience, and follow-through. Learning to recognize which battery is draining, and doing something about it before you crash, is one of the most practical self-management skills you can build.

> **Managing your time also means managing your energy, and the two aren't the same.**

The five batteries

Physical

Your body's fuel level: sleep, food, movement, and rest. When this battery is low, everything else suffers. You can't think clearly, manage your emotions, or stay focused on four hours of sleep and a gas station coffee.

WHAT DRAINS IT

- Poor or too little sleep
- Skipping meals or eating inconsistently
- Sitting for long stretches without moving
- Ignoring physical discomfort or illness

HOW TO RECHARGE

- Protect sleep. Even 30 more minutes matters.
- Eat something real before a demanding task
- Move your body. Even a short walk changes your state.
- Rest without guilt when your body is asking for it

Mental

Your thinking capacity: focus, concentration, decision-making, and problem-solving. This battery has a daily limit. Every decision you make, every problem you think through, and every piece of information you take in draws from it.

WHAT DRAINS IT

- Switching between tasks constantly
- Information overload: too many inputs at once
- Making too many decisions in a short window
- Worry and rumination, which drain you whether the problem is real or imagined

HOW TO RECHARGE

- Work in focused blocks, one thing at a time
- Take real breaks: actual rest, not phone breaks
- Cut down on small decisions by batching them or setting defaults
- Give your brain something easy or enjoyable to do

Emotional

Your capacity to handle feelings: stress, anxiety, frustration, grief, and conflict. When this battery is low, small things feel big. Patience disappears. Tasks that would normally feel manageable suddenly feel impossible.

WHAT DRAINS IT

- Unresolved conflict with people you care about
- Carrying stress without acknowledging it
- Pushing down emotions that need attention
- Financial pressure, family stress, or grief

HOW TO RECHARGE

- Name what you're feeling, out loud or in writing
- Talk to someone you trust
- Do something that brings real comfort, not just distraction
- Reach out to counseling when what you're carrying is too heavy to carry alone

Social

Your capacity for connection: belonging, support, and community. This battery works differently for different people. Some people recharge through connection and need people around them to feel energized. Others recharge through solitude, and too much social time drains them, even when they enjoy it.

WHAT DRAINS IT

- Isolation: going too long without meaningful connection
- Overextension: more social obligation than fits your wiring
- Conflict or tension in important relationships
- Feeling like you don't belong somewhere you spend time

HOW TO RECHARGE

- Know whether you recharge with people or alone, and plan for it
- Invest in one or two relationships that truly restore you
- Protect alone time if crowds drain you
- Seek connection if isolation drains you. Even a brief conversation counts.

Spiritual

Your sense of meaning, purpose, and alignment: the feeling that what you're doing matters, and that your values and your actions point in the same direction. This battery doesn't require religious belief. It's about the deeper question: *why does any of this matter to me?*

When this battery is low, even tasks you're capable of feel pointless. Motivation disappears, not because you're tired, but because you've lost sight of why you're here.

WHAT DRAINS IT

- Doing things that feel out of line with your values
- Losing sight of your reasons for being in college
- Going through the motions without a sense of purpose
- Feeling like your effort doesn't lead anywhere meaningful

HOW TO RECHARGE

- Reconnect with your reasons. Why did you come here? What are you working toward?
- Do something that fits what you value: service, creativity, faith, nature, or community
- Talk to someone who helps you see the bigger picture
- Give yourself permission to ask the big questions. They're worth asking.

What burnout actually is

"Burnout" gets used loosely. "I'm so burned out" often just means tired, stressed, or overwhelmed. Real burnout is more specific and more serious. It's what happens when several batteries have been running on empty for too long without a real recharge.

Burnout is more than exhaustion. It has three distinct signs:

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> The difference between running low and burned out is time. Running low happens to everyone. Burnout is what happens when you ignore running low long enough. The five batteries help you catch it early.

Exhaustion

Deep, lasting fatigue that a good night's sleep doesn't fix. You're tired before you start. Your physical and mental batteries are both critically low.

Cynicism

Detachment, or a "what's the point" feeling toward things that used to matter. Your spiritual battery is drained, and nothing feels meaningful anymore.

Ineffectiveness

The sense that nothing you do makes a difference. Your mental battery is so low that tasks you used to handle now feel impossible.

They don't work alone

The five batteries affect each other. When your physical battery is critically low, your emotional battery drains faster. When your emotional battery is depleted, your mental battery can't perform at its best. When your spiritual battery runs empty, your social battery often follows.

That's why "I just need to push through" is sometimes the wrong strategy. Pushing through doesn't recharge a drained battery. It just makes the crash harder when it comes.

PATHFINDER TIP

You don't need all five batteries full to function well. You need to know which one is lowest, and do one small thing about it before it runs out.

WORTH SAYING CLEARLY

When your emotional or spiritual battery is truly empty, not just tired, that isn't a time management problem. It's a human problem, and it deserves real support. Your instructor, your Success Coach, and the OCTC Counseling Center (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/current-students/counseling-center/index.aspx) are there for exactly these moments. Please use them.

Check in with yourself

REFLECT

Right now, which battery is most depleted? What's draining it?

Is there one battery you've been ignoring for a while, telling yourself you'll deal with it later?

What's one small, realistic thing you could do in the next 24 hours to start recharging your lowest battery?

LOOK AHEAD

These questions are the heart of Question 2 in Mile Marker #3.

Time management gets all the attention, but the students who really find their way through college learn to read their own gauges. They know when they're running low and what they need, and they don't wait until they're completely empty to do something about it.

That's self-knowledge, not weakness, and self-knowledge is one of the most professional things you can develop.

BONUS READ

Divergent Minds: Your Brain, Your Way

Some brains work differently. That's not a flaw, but it does matter.

Most time management advice assumes a particular kind of brain: one that starts tasks without much friction, stays focused with reasonable effort, tracks time naturally, and moves between activities without losing the thread.

If that sounds like you, great. If it doesn't, if you've spent years wondering why the standard strategies don't work the way everyone says they should, this lesson is for you.

It's also for everyone else. Understanding that brains work differently makes you a better student, a better teammate, and eventually a better colleague and leader.

> *If you've ever been told you're lazy when you were trying harder than anyone knew…*
>
> *If you've ever started a task ten times without getting past the first line…*
>
> *If you've ever looked up and realized three hours had passed without you noticing, or felt like you'd been staring at something for three hours when it had only been ten minutes…*
>
> *If deadlines feel unreal until they're dangerously close…*
>
> *If you work brilliantly in some conditions and can barely function in others…*
>
> **This course sees you. And this lesson is specifically for you.**

What neurodivergence actually means

Neurodivergence is an umbrella term for brains that process, learn, and function differently from what's considered neurotypical, the brain type most school and workplace systems were designed around. It includes ADHD, autism, dyslexia, dyspraxia, anxiety disorders, sensory processing differences, and more.

Some neurodivergent people have a formal diagnosis. Many don't, because they were never evaluated, because their differences were masked or compensated for, or because they're only now recognizing what's been true about them all along. You don't need a diagnosis for this lesson to apply to you.

What neurodivergence is *not* is a measure of intelligence, ability, or potential. Some of the most capable people you'll ever meet have brains that work very differently from the standard model. Usually the challenge has less to do with what they can do than with places that weren't designed with their brains in mind.

ABOUT THIS LESSON

This lesson isn't a diagnostic tool. It's meant to give you language for experiences you may have carried without a name, and strategies that work for a wider range of brains than the usual advice does.

Executive function: the control center

Most of the challenges neurodivergent students face in college come back to one thing: **executive function**. It's the set of mental skills that manage how you plan, start, organize, focus, handle emotions, and shift between tasks. Think of it as the brain's control center, or, to borrow from Lesson 3.3, the cockpit.

For some brains, that system works less reliably because of how the brain is wired, not because of laziness or not caring. These challenges are real, common, and worth naming.

KEY TERM

Executive function: the mental skills you use to plan, start, organize, focus, manage emotions, and shift between tasks.

Task initiation: starting is truly hard

For many neurodivergent brains, starting a task, especially one that feels uncertain, boring, or overwhelming, takes far more effort than it looks like from the outside. This is real friction, not procrastination in the casual sense, and it can make the gap between "I need to do this" and "I'm doing this" feel impossible to close.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

- Sitting with an assignment open for an hour without producing anything
- Starting and restarting without getting traction
- Feeling frozen by a task you're fully capable of doing
- Needing a deadline crisis to get going, and then doing great work under pressure

Time blindness: time feels different

Many neurodivergent people, especially those with ADHD, experience time differently. There are really two times: *now* and *not now*. Future deadlines don't feel real until they become now. It's a difference in perception, not a choice, and it makes traditional planning advice unhelpful.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

- Deadlines that seemed far away suddenly arriving as emergencies
- Losing track of time completely when you're into something
- Regularly underestimating how long tasks take
- Time seeming to pass at different speeds depending on the situation

Working memory: holding things in mind

Working memory is your brain's ability to hold information for a moment while you use it, like a mental sticky note. When working memory is limited or unreliable, things slip: instructions get lost, multi-step tasks fall apart, and the thought you had two seconds ago is gone before you can use it.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

- Walking into a room and immediately forgetting why
- Losing your train of thought mid-sentence
- Reading a paragraph and retaining almost nothing
- Needing to write everything down, or it's gone

Emotional regulation: feelings hit differently

Many neurodivergent people feel emotions more intensely and have a harder time settling them quickly. Frustration, rejection, and overwhelm can hit hard and linger. It reflects a difference in how the brain processes and manages emotion, not immaturity.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

- A critical comment landing harder than it "should"
- Emotional reactions that feel bigger than the situation
- Having a hard time bouncing back after something goes wrong
- Avoiding tasks or situations that might bring frustration or failure

Transitions: switching gears takes effort

Moving from one task, place, or state of mind to another can take real effort for some brains. When you're deeply focused, sometimes called hyperfocus, switching away feels disruptive. And getting started on something new after a transition means rebuilding momentum from scratch.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

- Having trouble stopping a task even when you need to move on
- Needing extra time and energy to shift between subjects or places
- Feeling derailed after an interruption and struggling to get back on track
- Hyperfocusing on one thing at the expense of everything else

Strategies that work for more brains

These strategies aren't only for neurodivergent students. They tend to work for a wider range of people than the standard advice does. Try what fits. Leave what doesn't.

For task initiation

Body doubling. Work near another person, even silently. Many brains get going more easily with someone else nearby: the library, a coffee shop, a study group that doesn't talk.

The smallest possible start. Not "write the paper," but "open the document and type one sentence." Set the bar so low that starting is almost impossible to resist.

Transition rituals. A specific song, a cup of something, a short walk before you sit down. It signals to your brain that work is starting.

For time blindness

Make time visible. Analog clocks, timers you can see, time-tracking apps. If time is invisible, your brain won't track it, so make it physical and present.

Time anchors. Attach tasks to events instead of clock times. "After lunch, I'll do this" is more reliable than "at 1:00."

Work backward from deadlines. If something is due Friday, when does it need to be done for that to happen? Set your own earlier deadline and make it real.

For working memory

Get it out of your head. Don't trust your brain to hold it. Write it down the moment it appears: checklists, voice memos, sticky notes, whatever you'll actually use.

Close the loops. Unfinished tasks create mental background noise. When something is done, mark it done. When something can't be done now, write it down so your brain can let it go.

One thing at a time. Single-tasking protects working memory. Every task switch costs more than you think.

For emotional regulation

Name it to tame it. Labeling an emotion, out loud or in writing, makes it less intense. "I'm frustrated" is easier to handle than a wave of something you can't name.

Build in recovery time. After something emotionally hard, you may need more time than others to reset. Plan for it instead of fighting it.

Know your triggers. What situations, times of day, or kinds of feedback reliably knock you off course? Knowing ahead of time lets you prepare instead of react.

For transitions

Warn yourself. Five minutes before a switch, acknowledge it's coming: "In five minutes, I'm switching to math." Sudden transitions are harder than prepared ones.

Build buffers. Don't schedule tasks back to back. Give yourself time between classes, subjects, and places.

Leave a breadcrumb. Before you stop working, write one sentence about where you left off and what comes next. Restarting gets much easier.

For your environment

Know what your brain needs. Silence or background noise? Movement or stillness? Natural light or controlled light? Experiment on purpose instead of defaulting to what you think you should need.

Protect your best conditions. When you find a place where you work well, treat it like a resource. Go back to it. Protect it.

Simplify your setup. The more decisions you make before starting, the less energy you have for the work itself.

If any of this sounds like you, there's support

OCTC's Accessibility Services office helps students whose brains work differently get the accommodations and support they need to succeed. You don't need a diagnosis to start a conversation with them, and you don't need to have it all figured out.

Accommodations might include extended time on tests, a different testing environment, note-taking support, or other adjustments that level the playing field without lowering the bar. They're tools that let your real abilities show.

If you've spent years compensating, masking, or wondering why things are harder for you than they seem to be for others, it's worth making that appointment.

OCTC Accessibility Services

Current contact information, hours, and how to get started. Your Success Coach can also help you take the first step.

Visit Accessibility Services (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/about/student-life/accessibility-services.aspx)

The academic system was designed for a particular kind of brain. If yours works differently, and many do, that doesn't mean you don't belong here. It means you may need different strategies, different environments, and different support than the standard advice offers.

You've probably already figured out more about how your brain works than you realize. This lesson is an invitation to get more intentional about that knowledge: to use it, build on it, and stop apologizing for it.

Your brain is the one you have. Learn how it works and work with it. That will take you further than working against it ever could.

MILE MARKER

Mile Marker #3: Managing My Time & Energy

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

You have the same 168 hours as everyone else, but you don't have the same brain, the same responsibilities, or the same energy reserves.

This Mile Marker isn't about building the perfect schedule. It's about starting to understand how you actually work: your patterns, your energy, and your limits. You'll come back to what you learn here when you build your capstone project.

What you'll do

1. **Before you start,** finish these two Trail Tools. You'll use them in Questions 1 and 3.
   - Where My Time Goes (your time log)
   - My Week at a Glance (your week plan)
2. **Answer four questions** in the form below.
3. **Save as PDF** and upload it to the **Mile Marker #3** assignment in Blackboard.

●○ AI use: AI-supported

You may use AI as a thinking partner to explore your ideas. Work with what it gives you, then write your responses in your own voice. See the AI Course Policy in the syllabus and Lesson 1.4: AI use labels.

Optional prompt to try: "Ask me questions to help me understand how my energy and focus work throughout the day, and what that means for how I should structure my time." Use what's useful. Your final responses must be in your own words.

Your Mile Marker

Type your answers in the boxes. Your typing is saved in this browser as you go, so you can come back later on the same device. Nothing is sent anywhere until you upload it.

Your name (required) **Date**

QUESTION 1

Your Patterns

Look at your Where My Time Goes log.

A STRONG ANSWER

Uses **your log** to name one real pattern or time-waster, explains **why it happens**, and says **what it costs you**. Not a general statement that could apply to anyone.

1. When were you most focused, and what was different about that time?

2. Name one pattern or time-waster you found.

3. Explain why it happens and what it costs you.

Look back at: Lesson 3.3: Find your best hour

QUESTION 2

Your Energy

Think about the five batteries: physical, mental, emotional, social, and spiritual.

A STRONG ANSWER

Names **one battery**, explains what's draining it **in your life right now**, and describes one small action that's realistic for this week.

1. Choose the battery that's most depleted right now.

Circle one: Physical / Mental / Emotional / Social / Spiritual

2. Describe what's draining it.

3. Name one small, realistic action you could take this week to start recharging it.

Look back at: Lesson 3.5: The five batteries

QUESTION 3

Your Week

Look at the week you mapped in My Week at a Glance.

A STRONG ANSWER

Names your **real** non-negotiables, explains why your most important work landed **where your energy is best**, and connects one part of the plan to **something you value**.

1. List your non-negotiables this week.

2. Explain where you put your most important work, and why there.

3. Name one part of your plan that reflects what you value most.

Look back at: Lesson 3.2: Map your week in three steps

QUESTION 4

Your Self-Knowledge

This one doesn't have a wrong answer.

To get you thinking (no separate answer needed)

- Did anything in this module describe how your brain works in a way you hadn't had words for before? You don't have to name a diagnosis.
- Why is your habit realistic for your life right now?

A STRONG ANSWER

Names one specific thing you're learning about yourself and why it matters, and describes **one small, realistic habit** with a clear way to tell **whether it's working**. Honest beats polished.

1. Name one thing you're learning about how you work, and why it matters.

2. Describe one small habit or adjustment you'll try, and how you'll know it's working.

Look back at: Divergent Minds: Strategies that work for more brains (bonus read)

Submit it

Upload your PDF to the **Mile Marker #3** assignment in Blackboard. Check Blackboard for the due date.

In an in-person class? Your instructor may give you a printed copy. Fill it in by hand, then upload a photo or scan.

Optional: attach your time log or week plan too.

How it's scored: full credit means every prompt is answered, and each answer is about you, with at least one real detail. See How Mile Markers are scored.

WRAP UP

Module 3 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

You've reached the end of Module 3. These are the ideas to carry forward.

Key takeaways

Professionalism is a pattern, not a performance. It's being someone people can count on, including owning it when things go wrong.

Priorities first, schedule second. Name your Musts before you touch the calendar, and leave white space for real life.

Protect your best hour. Put your most important work where your energy is highest, and put the phone out of reach.

Multitasking is really task-switching. Every switch has a cost. Noticing it is the first step to protecting your focus.

Manage your energy, not just your time. Know which of your five batteries is lowest, and do one small thing about it before it runs out.

Your brain is the one you have. Learn how it works, use strategies that fit it, and reach out for support when you need it.

REFLECT

Think about the week ahead. What's one small change you'll make to how you plan your time or protect your energy, and how will you know if it's working?

That's Module 3.

Head back to your course in Blackboard for this module's activities.

MODULE 4

Your Academic Toolkit

The right tools make all the difference, but only if you know how to use them.

10 ESSENTIAL SKILLS IN THIS MODULE

#6 Professionalism

#10 Information Literacy

Why this matters

You're surrounded by more information than any generation before you, and more of it is wrong, misleading, or designed to grab your attention rather than inform you.

This module helps you build your academic toolkit: study strategies that actually work, a framework for evaluating what you read, and a direct look at where AI helps, and where it doesn't.



Merit reminder: Merit Activity #1 is due with this module

Find an activity, then submit your reflection to the Merit Activity #1 submission portal in Blackboard. Check Blackboard for the due date. The Merit Guide has your options, what proof to include, and how to write your reflection.

What you'll be able to do

By the end of this module:

A

I can identify and apply at least one evidence-based study strategy and describe what I noticed about my learning.

B

I can evaluate a source or AI-generated response using the SIFT method and explain whether I would use it and why.

C

I can apply at least one digital organization strategy to manage my course files.

D

I can recognize AI creep in my own work and describe honestly how I used AI.

E

I can write one SMART goal for continuing a study strategy or academic habit this semester.

AI Literacy: BE behaviors in this module

- BE Honest
- BE Critical
- BE Responsible

Lessons in this module

Trail Tip: Your Microsoft Office 365 Academic Toolkit

You already have powerful tools. Here's how to use them for school.

4.1 Skill Spotlight: Information Literacy

Finding, evaluating, and responsibly using information to make good decisions.

4.2 Study Strategies That Actually Work

What the research says, and what to do with it.

4.3 SIFT: Stop Before You Scroll

Four moves for evaluating any information, including what AI tells you.

4.4 AI Literacy: Beware of the Creep

Did you cross the line, and did you notice?

Trail Tip: Recording in the Classroom

Technology made recording easy. That doesn't make it automatic.

Mile Marker: Mile Marker #4: My Academic Toolkit

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

Wrap Up: Module 4 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

TRAIL TIP

Your Microsoft Office 365 Academic Toolkit

You already have powerful tools. Here's how to use them for school.

As a KCTCS student, you have free access to the full Microsoft Office 365 suite, including tools that go well beyond Word and PowerPoint.

This Trail Tip covers the ones most useful for school: OneNote for organizing your course life, OneDrive for keeping your files safe and easy to reach, Teams for group work, and Microsoft Copilot as a study support tool. You don't need to master them. Knowing they exist lets you reach for the right one when you need it.

> LOOK BACK AT
>
> Module 1 Trail Tip: Your Free Microsoft Office 365 Access shows how to get the apps.

OneNote: your digital Trapper Keeper Start here

OneNote is a free-form digital notebook organized into notebooks, sections, and pages. Think of it as a Trapper Keeper that lives in the cloud: you can open it on any device, it never gets left at home, and you can't lose pages because you forgot to put them back.

Unlike a Word document, OneNote isn't linear. You can type anywhere on the page, add images, paste links, record audio, and draw diagrams, and organize it all the way your brain works, not the way a template tells you to.

How to use it for school

- **One notebook per semester.** Make a section for each class, then a page for each lecture or topic, so everything is in one place.
- **Capture anything.** Paste a screenshot of a slide, type your notes next to it, and add a question you want to follow up on. No formatting required.
- **Search everything.** OneNote searches all of your notes. If you wrote it down, you can find it.
- **Share with study partners.** Share a section with a classmate to take notes together without sending files back and forth.
- **Come back and add to it.** Revisit old notes, add new thoughts, and mark what mattered. Your notes become a living document.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> Set up a "Class Notes" notebook before your first class of the semester, with one section per course. Five minutes of setup pays off every week.

OneDrive: your files, everywhere

OneDrive is Microsoft's cloud storage, included with your KCTCS account. Every file you save there is backed up and available from any device where you sign in with your KCTCS account.

The most common academic disaster is a lost, broken, or forgotten file. OneDrive prevents most of those before they happen.

How to use it for school

- **Save everything there by default.** If you worked on it, it lives in OneDrive, not only the important files.
- **Organize by semester and course.** A simple folder structure (Semester → Course → Assignments) takes two minutes to set up and saves hours of searching later.
- **Name files so you can find them.** Pick one pattern and stick to it, like FYE100_MileMarker4_Draft. Future you will know exactly what's inside.
- **Share a link instead of an attachment.** When sharing is allowed, a OneDrive link is cleaner than an email attachment, and you can update the file without resending it.
- **Get to it from anywhere.** Forgot your laptop? Sign in on a library computer and everything is there.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> On a device that isn't yours, like a library computer or a family member's laptop, save to OneDrive as you go, not just at the end. Sessions time out.

Teams: communication that isn't email

Teams is Microsoft's chat, video call, and file-sharing tool, all in one place. Some OCTC courses and programs use Teams for class communication, office hours, or group projects.

- **Check whether your instructor uses it.** Some instructors hold virtual office hours or post updates in Teams.
- **Group projects.** Instead of endless email threads, set up a Teams chat for your group. Share files, chat, and meet in one place.
- **Study sessions.** Video calls with study partners are included with your KCTCS account.

Microsoft Copilot: AI with your school account

Microsoft Copilot is an AI assistant you can use with your KCTCS Microsoft account. It's a good place to start with AI as a student: when you're signed in with your KCTCS email, you're using it under your school account's privacy protections instead of a separate personal account.

Go to copilot.microsoft.com (https://copilot.microsoft.com) and sign in with your KCTCS email and password.

AI Literacy BE Responsible

Good ways to use Copilot for school

- **Brainstorming.** "Give me five angles I could take on this essay topic." Then choose one and develop it yourself.
- **Explaining concepts.** "Explain [topic] in plain language, then give me three questions I should be able to answer about it."
- **Reviewing your own notes.** Paste in notes you wrote and ask for the key points. Then use that list to quiz yourself.
- **Feedback on clarity.** "Read this paragraph and tell me if the main idea is clear." Then revise it yourself, in your own words.
- **Email drafting.** "Help me write a professional email to my instructor asking about [topic]." Review it, revise it, and send it as your own.

Copilot, like any AI tool, sounds confident whether or not it's right. Check facts against your course materials or credible sources before you rely on them. Lesson 4.3 gives you a method for doing exactly that. And check the AI rules for each assignment first (Lesson 1.4).

All of these are free with your KCTCS account

Get to them through MyPath (https://mypath.kctcs.edu/) or by signing in at office.com (https://www.office.com/) with your KCTCS email and password. Need help getting set up? Contact OCTC Information Technology (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/current-students/information-technology/information_technology.aspx).

LESSON 4.1

Skill Spotlight: Information Literacy

Finding, evaluating, and responsibly using information to make good decisions.



10 Essential Skills · #10

Information Literacy

What this skill is

You're living in the most information-rich moment in human history, and one of the most information-polluted.

More content is produced every day than anyone could take in over a lifetime. AI tools produce confident, detailed, believable answers in seconds. Social media shows you whatever is most engaging, not most accurate. News, opinion, marketing, and misinformation often look identical at first glance.

Information Literacy is the skill that cuts through all of that. It means knowing how to ask the right questions, find credible sources, evaluate what you're reading, and use information responsibly to make real decisions, without doubting everything.

It's one of the most transferable skills you'll build in college. It applies to every class, every job, and every decision you make as a citizen, consumer, and professional.

> **Information is everywhere. The real question is whether it's trustworthy, and whether you can tell.**

Where you're headed

Below, in plain terms, is the difference between where most students start and where you're headed.

> SEE ALSO
>
> Lesson 1.2 explains Benchmark, Milestone, and Capstone.

Benchmark Where you're starting

- You can identify topics that call for information before you decide.
- You can use basic search strategies with familiar resources.
- You can name strengths and weaknesses of information sources.
- You can describe the main ideas from a variety of sources.
- You can identify where information came from.

Milestone

YOUR TARGET

- You ask questions sized right for your field or situation.
- You use search strategies that find credible resources for your specific need.
- You analyze sources for bias, expertise, and point of view, not just surface credibility.
- You see connections between sources and use them to make well-informed decisions.
- You give appropriate credit to the sources you use.

The shift from Benchmark to Milestone is the shift from taking information in to actively questioning it, and using what you find with intention and integrity.

Where it shows up in this module

Module 4 is where Information Literacy becomes a hands-on skill instead of an idea.

The SIFT method. Stop, Investigate the source, Find better coverage, Trace claims. SIFT turns Information Literacy into four moves you can make in real time, on any source, including AI.

Evaluating AI output. AI answers are fluent and confident, and they can be partly or completely wrong. Checking claims, spotting gaps, and tracing sources is Information Literacy applied to the tool you'll use most.

Choosing study resources. When you look for help with course material, like a video, a website, or an AI explanation, you're making an information decision. Is it credible? Is it accurate? Does it answer what you actually need?

Digital organization. Managing your files, notes, and resources so you can find them when you need them counts too. Information you can't find might as well not exist.

In your own life

Take a moment with these before you move on.

REFLECT

Think about the last time you looked something up to make a decision: a purchase, a health question, something for a class. How did you decide whether to trust what you found?

Have you ever acted on information that turned out to be wrong or misleading? What happened, and what would you do differently now?

When you get an answer from an AI tool, what do you do with it? Check it, use it as is, or something in between?

How it shows up later

Information Literacy is one of the skills you can choose for your fourth STAR(T) Story at the end of the course. As the semester goes on, notice moments when you had to find, evaluate, or responsibly use information to make a real decision, in class, at work, or in your personal life. Those are your stories.

The SIFT skills you build in this module make strong material. "I checked a source using SIFT and changed my decision because of what I found" is exactly the kind of specific, honest story the capstone is looking for.

Skill definition and Milestone indicators are based on the Kentucky Council on Postsecondary Education's Kentucky Graduate Profile (https://cpe.ky.gov/ourwork/kygradprofile.html).

LESSON 4.2

Study Strategies That Actually Work

What the research says, and what to do with it.

Most students study the way they were taught to study, which often isn't how learning actually works.

Rereading notes feels productive. Highlighting feels like engagement. Cramming the night before feels like urgency. None of these is especially effective, and the research on this is consistent.

This lesson covers four strategies with strong evidence behind them. They aren't magic, and they don't work the same way for every brain. But understanding *why* they work helps you decide whether and how to use them in your own life.

> **The goal is to study in ways that stick, not to study more.**

Four strategies worth trying

1 Retrieval practice: test yourself before the test tests you

The best-supported study strategy in learning research is also one of the least intuitive: testing yourself on material, before you feel ready, works better than reviewing it. Pulling information out of memory strengthens it in ways that rereading doesn't.

Every time you struggle to recall something and then find the answer, you build a stronger memory than if you'd just read it again. That struggle is what makes it work.

- Close your notes. Write down everything you remember from class without looking. Then check what you missed. The gaps are what you need to study.
- Use flashcards, but try to recall the answer before you flip the card. Looking at both sides at once is review, not retrieval.
- After a reading, close the book and answer: what were the three most important things I just read?

Try it and noticeAfter your next class, spend five minutes writing down what you remember without looking at your notes. Notice what came easily and what didn't. That's your study list.

KEY TERM

Retrieval practice: studying by pulling information out of your memory, like quizzing yourself, instead of reading it again.

2 Spaced practice: come back before you forget

Memory fades over time, and reviewing material just as it starts to fade works better than reviewing it right after you learn it. This is called the **spacing effect**, and it's why cramming gets you through tomorrow's test but not next month's.

You don't need a complicated system. Study something, wait a day or two, and review it again. Wait a little longer, and review again. Each time you come back, the memory gets stronger and lasts longer.

- Spend 10 minutes on your notes the day of class. Come back two days later for another 10. Review again before the exam. Three short sessions beat one long one.
- Keep a running list of concepts you're shaky on. Revisit it every few days instead of waiting for exam week.

Try it and noticeSchedule one 10-minute review of this week's material for two days from now, and set a reminder. Notice whether you remember more or less than you expected, and what that tells you about how spacing works for your brain.

> **LOOK BACK AT**
>
> Put your review sessions in My Week at a Glance.

3 Elaborative interrogation: ask why until it makes sense

Elaborative interrogation means asking "why" and "how" as you study, and connecting new information to things you already know. Instead of memorizing facts, you build meaning, and meaning sticks better than isolated facts.

This strategy tends to work especially well for students whose brains are drawn to patterns and connections, and less well for those who find open-ended questions hard to pin down. If that's you, pair it with retrieval practice.

- Reading about a historical event: don't just memorize the date. Ask why it happened when it did, and what would have had to be different for it not to happen.
- Studying a concept in biology: don't just memorize the definition. Ask why it works this way, and what would happen if it didn't.
- After reading anything, ask "So what?" Why does this matter? How does it connect to what I already know?

Try it and noticePick one concept from a current class. Write three "why" or "how" questions about it and try to answer them. Notice whether the concept feels clearer or more confusing afterward. Both are useful information.

4 Interleaving: mix it up on purpose

Most students study one topic until it feels comfortable, then move to the next. That feels efficient, but research suggests that mixing different topics or problem types in one session leads to better long-term learning, even though it feels harder in the moment.

That difficulty is part of why it works. When you have to figure out which approach fits which problem, your brain does more work, and that work builds understanding that lasts.

- Instead of doing 20 math problems of the same type in a row, do 5 of one type, then 5 of another, then come back to the first. It will feel harder, and that's a sign it's working.
- When reviewing for a test that covers several chapters, shuffle the topics instead of going in order.

Try it and noticeIn your next study session for a class with several topics, switch between them every 15 to 20 minutes. Notice how it feels compared to sticking with one. Feeling unsure is normal. That's the learning happening.

What feels productive but isn't

These are the study habits students rely on most, and why the research isn't kind to them.

FEELS PRODUCTIVE

Rereading notes or the textbook. It builds familiarity, not learning. You recognize the material, but recognizing isn't recalling.

INSTEAD

Retrieval practice. Close the notes. Try to recall. Then check. The effort of recalling is what builds the memory.

FEELS PRODUCTIVE

Highlighting everything. It's passive and feels like engagement. If everything is highlighted, nothing is.

INSTEAD

Write questions in the margin. Next to the important parts, write a question. Later, try to answer it without looking.

FEELS PRODUCTIVE

Cramming the night before. It fades fast. You may pass the test and remember almost nothing two weeks later.

INSTEAD

Spaced practice. Three 20-minute sessions over three days usually beat one 60-minute session the night before.

None of these strategies works perfectly for every brain or every subject. When one doesn't work for you, that tells you something about how you learn. It doesn't mean the strategy failed. Try one, notice what happens, and adjust.

Lookout: Ask Your Success Coach



If you've changed how you study and a class still isn't going well, ask your instructor where you stand. Then talk with your Success Coach.

Your coach can connect you with tutoring at the Teaching & Learning Center and with Accessibility Services. Your coach can also help you figure out whether you can still raise the grade, and if not, whether withdrawing makes sense. Withdrawing can affect your financial aid, so talk with your coach **before** you decide.

Not sure who your coach is? Lesson 2.2 shows you how to find them.

Keep it going: write a SMART goal

Trying a strategy once is a start. Keeping it going is where it pays off. A **SMART goal** turns "I should study better" into something you can do, and check.

- S
  Specific. What exactly will you do? Name the strategy and the class.
- M
  Measurable. How will you know you did it? A number, a count, a checkmark.
- A
  Achievable. Is it realistic for your life right now, with your work, family, and energy?
- R

Relevant. Why this habit? Which class or goal does it help?

- T

  Time-bound. When, and how often? Give it a schedule and an end point.

NOT SMART

"I'm going to study more for biology."

SMART

"For the rest of the semester, I'll spend 10 minutes quizzing myself on my biology notes every Tuesday and Thursday after class, and check it off in my planner. I'll know it's working if I can answer most of my own questions before each exam."

> KEY TERM
>
> **SMART goal:** a goal that is Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound.

> LOOK AHEAD
>
> You'll write one in Mile Marker #4, Question 3.

Using AI as a study partner

AI Literacy BE Critical

AI tools can support the strategies in this lesson when you use them to think alongside you, not instead of you. For example:

- **Retrieval practice:** "Quiz me on [topic]. Ask me five questions and don't give me the answers until I try." Then ask yourself whether the questions match what you actually need to know.
- **Elaborative interrogation:** "Explain why [concept] works the way it does, in plain language." Ask follow-up questions until it makes sense, and check the explanation against your course materials.
- **Spaced practice:** "List the key points from [topic] so I can review them." Cover the list and try to recall the points before you read it.
- **Finding gaps:** "What are the most commonly misunderstood parts of [topic]?" Use the answer to test your own understanding, not to replace it.

Where to draw the line: using AI to quiz yourself is studying. Using AI to write your notes, your summaries, or your assignment answers is not, because it skips the work that builds your ability. You'll feel the difference when you sit down for the exam.

LESSON 4.3

SIFT: Stop Before You Scroll

Four moves for evaluating any information, including what AI tells you.

Every day you run into dozens of pieces of information: articles, posts, search results, AI answers, videos, and claims from people you trust.

Most of it looks credible, but some of it isn't, and the gap between "looks credible" and "is credible" has never been harder to spot.

SIFT is a practical method for closing that gap. It was developed by information literacy researcher Mike Caulfield, and it gives you four moves you can make quickly, in the moment, before you believe, share, or act on something. It works on news articles, social media, and AI-generated content, which may be where it matters most right now.

Before you start: consider this

You ask an AI tool, "What are the best study strategies for college students?" The answer is detailed, confident, and well organized. It mentions "research" and uses phrases like "studies show" and "experts recommend."

It sounds authoritative. It reads like something from a credible source. You take notes and plan to follow the advice.

The problem: AI tools sound authoritative whether or not they're accurate. There may be no actual study behind "studies show." The "expert" may not exist. The advice may be useful, or it may be a believable mix of things the AI was trained on. Without checking, you can't tell which. That's what SIFT is for.

The four moves

SStop

Before you read the article, **stop**. Before you share the video, **stop**. Before you act on a strong reaction to a headline or a convincing AI summary, **stop**.

This is the hardest move, not because it's complicated, but because the information around you is designed to keep you moving. Headlines are written to provoke a reaction. AI answers are formatted to feel complete and final. Social media rewards the fast share.

Stopping means pausing before your first reaction becomes your conclusion, not doubting everything. Ask yourself: *Do I know this source? Do I know its reputation? Am I reacting to how confident this sounds instead of*

whether it's accurate?

Applied to AIWhen an AI answer sounds complete and authoritative, stop. That confidence comes from how AI writes, not from evidence that the content is right, so pause before you use it.

Watch: Stop, with Mike Caulfield (YouTube) (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yBU2sDlUbp8)

IInvestigate the source

Before you read deeply, take a minute to find out what you're reading. Who made this? What's their purpose? What's the reputation of this person or organization? You're looking for context before you invest your attention, not reasons to dismiss it.

The key technique is **lateral reading**: instead of reading deeper into the source itself, open a new tab and search for what others say about it. Professional fact-checkers work this way, and it's far more effective than judging credibility from the inside.

- Search the name of the publication, website, or author along with words like "bias," "credibility," or "fact-check."
- Check Wikipedia for background on news organizations, think tanks, or advocacy groups, as a quick starting point, not a final authority.
- Look at the "About" page, but don't stop there. Anyone can write an impressive About page.

Applied to AIYou can't look up an AI's reputation, but you can check its claims. If an AI answer names a specific study, expert, or statistic, investigate that claim directly. Does the study exist? Does the expert? Where does the number come from?

Watch: Investigate the Source, with Mike Caulfield (YouTube) (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hB6qjIxKltA)

> **KEY TERM**
>
> **Lateral reading:** checking a source by leaving it and searching what other sources say about it.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
>
> Lateral reading takes less than two minutes and catches things deep reading misses. Open a new tab before you commit to a source. It's the single most effective habit in the whole method.

FFind better coverage

Sometimes the best move is to stop judging the source you have and find a better source for the same information. If a claim matters enough to act on, it's worth seeing whether other credible sources report it the same way.

Look for sources with a track record of accuracy, not sources that agree with you, and see how they handle the same claim.

- Search the specific claim, not the source, and see what several outlets say.
- For viral claims, use fact-checking sites like Snopes (https://www.snopes.com/), PolitiFact (https://www.politifact.com/), or AP Fact Check (https://apnews.com/hub/ap-fact-check).
- For academic topics, search the OCTC Library (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/current-students/student-resources/library/index.aspx) databases for peer-reviewed sources on the same question.
- When several independent, credible sources report a claim the same way, that means something.

Applied to AIWhen AI gives you information you plan to use for an assignment or a decision, find better coverage from a credible source before you rely on it. The AI answer is a starting point, not a destination.

Watch: Find Better Coverage, with Mike Caulfield (YouTube) (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wJG7kFmS0FE)

TTrace claims, quotes, and media to the original

A lot of misinformation starts with something real, taken out of context: a real statistic used to support a false conclusion, a real quote trimmed to mean something the speaker didn't say, a real study cited for a finding it never showed.

Tracing means following a claim back to where it started and asking: does the original actually say what this source claims it says?

- Click through links. Don't assume a linked source says what the article claims.
- When a statistic is cited, find the original study or report, not just the article about it.
- When a quote is used, find the full quote in its original setting. Speeches, interviews, and documents are usually findable.
- For images or videos, use a reverse image search to find where they first appeared.

Applied to AIAI tools sometimes produce citations that look real but don't exist. This is called a **hallucination**. If an AI answer cites a source, trace it. If you can't find it, don't use it. If you find it and it says something different from what the AI claimed, that's your answer.

Watch: Trace Claims, with Mike Caulfield (YouTube) (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tRZ-N3OvvUs)

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> Most misinformation uses real information in misleading ways rather than telling an outright lie. Tracing takes longer than the other moves, but it's the one that finds the biggest problems.

SIFT and AI: why it matters more than ever

AI Literacy BE Critical

Traditional misinformation often has tells: obvious bias, unknown sources, claims that seem too good to be true. AI output often has none of them. It's fluent, organized, confident, and often mostly correct, which makes the errors harder to spot and easier to act on.

The habit: treat AI output like a smart but unverified tip from a well-informed friend. It's worth listening to and following up on, but not worth acting on until you've checked.

> **SEE ALSO**
> SIFT is for sources. For checking an answer from AI, Before You Use AI's Answer (https://octc-instructional-design.github.io/Bb_Start_Here/ai-before-you-use-it.html#do) gives you four quick checks.

Practice it: Is This Legit?

In your course, you'll put SIFT to work. You'll read a short document, then talk it through with **Coach Pathfinder**, an AI coach who walks you through the four SIFT moves one at a time. Coach Pathfinder asks questions; it doesn't hand you answers. Your job is to do the evaluation, not to describe what you would do.

Read the document first, before you open the chat. You'll find it with this module's activities in Blackboard.

Keep it open in another tab the whole time. You'll need to refer back to it.

Give it 10 to 15 minutes of real attention. This isn't a quick task.

Don't rush a step because it feels done. Coach Pathfinder may push you to go deeper.

There are real things to find in this document. Some are obvious and some take digging, so take your time.

> **KEEP HANDY**
> Keep this page open for a refresher on the four moves while you chat.

SIFT method developed by Mike Caulfield. Parts of this lesson are adapted from Clark College Libraries (https://clark.libguides.com/evaluating-information/SIFT) and Hapgood (https://hapgood.us/2019/06/19/sift-the-four-moves/) under a CC BY 4.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/) license.

LESSON 4.4

AI Literacy: Beware of the Creep

Did you cross the line, and did you notice?

This happens to almost everyone, often without them noticing.

A student starts a paper by asking AI for a few topic ideas. That feels reasonable. Brainstorming is exactly what AI is good for. Then they ask for an outline. Still feels fine. Then they're stuck on the introduction, so they ask AI to write a sample one "just to see what it might look like." It sounds pretty good, so parts of it end up in the draft.

Later, worried the writing isn't polished enough, they ask AI to improve a paragraph. Then to make it sound more professional. Then to rewrite the conclusion.

By the time the paper is done, they honestly can't say how much of it is theirs and how much came from AI. They weren't trying to cheat. The line moved one small step at a time, and nobody was keeping track of where it ended up.

> **This is AI creep: AI's role in your work growing a little at a time, where each step feels small and reasonable, but the end result is very different from where you started.**

> KEY TERM
>
> **AI creep:** the gradual, often unnoticed growth of AI's role in your work.

The AI Creep Meter

Each stage on this scale means AI plays a bigger role in producing the actual content of your work.

The AI Creep Meter

1. Brainstorming
2. Outlining
3. Drafting
4. Revising
5. Rewriting
6. Submitting

Lower stakesHigher stakes

The farther AI moves into the creation of your work, the more important transparency becomes.

Brainstorming and outlining are usually lower stakes. You're still doing the thinking, and AI is helping you organize it. As AI moves into drafting, revising, and rewriting, it does more of the work *for* you, and the line between "my work" and "AI's work" gets harder to see.

That doesn't mean the right side of the meter is always off-limits. That depends on the assignment and your instructor. It means the farther right you go, the more important it is that you can explain what happened, and that you chose to go there on purpose.

> **LOOK BACK AT**
> Lesson 1.4: each assignment's AI use label tells you how far along the meter you're allowed to go.

Set your boundary before you start

The fix is deciding, before you open the chat, what role AI is allowed to play in *this* piece of work. Tools have jobs. A hammer is great for nails and useless for screws. AI is the same: useful for some jobs on a given assignment, the wrong tool for others.

Before you start, ask yourself:

What am I trying to learn from this assignment?

What parts of this work need to be mine, in my own words and my own thinking?

What role, if any, should AI play here?

Then tell the AI that role directly. A few examples:

- Tutor“Explain this concept in simple terms, but don't complete the assignment for me.”
- Brainstorming partner“Help me generate ideas and questions to explore. Don't write content I can submit.”
- Study coach“Ask me questions that help me think this through myself.”
- Editor“Give me feedback on clarity and organization, but don't rewrite my work.”

Setting the boundary up front does two things: it keeps AI in its lane, and it gives you something to point back to if you're asked how you used it.

Why this connects to BE Honest

AI Literacy BE Honest

BE Honest is less about getting caught than about whether your work is worthy of your name. AI creep makes that question hard to answer, even when you aren't hiding anything, because you've lost track yourself.

If an instructor asked you right now, "How did you use AI on this?", could you answer clearly? If the honest answer is "I'm not totally sure," notice that, because it tells you the boundary slipped.

What attribution actually looks like

"Be transparent about AI use" can feel vague until you see it written out. Attribution doesn't need to be long or formal. It needs to be specific enough that someone else could tell what AI did and didn't do.

Less creep, clearly credited

> "I used AI to brainstorm three possible topics and to help me build an outline. The writing, examples, and conclusions are my own."

More creep, still credited

> "I drafted this myself, then used AI to revise my conclusion paragraph for clarity. I reviewed the changes and adjusted the wording so it still sounds like me."

Both examples name *what* AI did (brainstorm, outline, revise one paragraph), and both are specific enough that the student could explain more if asked. Neither says "I used AI" and stops there. A vague disclosure is hard to act on, for you or your instructor. **A quick way to write your own:** name the stage or stages on the Creep Meter where AI was involved, then say what stayed yours.

> **LOOK BACK AT**
> Keep a trail in Lesson 1.4 makes attribution much easier.

Before you submit, ask yourself

- Can I explain my work and how AI helped me? (That's the third of the 3 Qs.)
- Could I show my process if asked?
- Does this still show my own learning and thinking?
- Would I be comfortable talking through my AI use with my instructor?

If any answer is no, that's the moment to pause, not after you've submitted.

In your own life

REFLECT

Think of a time you used AI for a task, for school or anything else. Where would that use land on the AI Creep Meter?

Has your AI use ever gone further than you planned, without you really deciding it should? What did that feel like once you noticed?

What would it look like to set a boundary with AI before your next assignment, and tell the AI what that boundary is?

LOOK AHEAD

The first question here is Question 4 in Mile Marker #4.

AI policies are still evolving, and they'll keep changing. What won't change: transparency, honesty, and ownership of your learning are yours to decide, every time.

The most important decision about AI use is the boundary you set at the beginning of a project, not anything you do at the end.

TRAIL TIP

Recording in the Classroom

Technology made recording easy. That doesn't make it automatic.

A few years ago, recording a class took equipment. Now it takes one tap on a phone.

AI note-taking apps can join an online class, transcribe everything, and summarize the discussion before you've closed your laptop. The technology is impressive, and the questions it raises are real.

KCTCS doesn't have one system-wide recording policy. That means the rules vary by instructor, by course, and by situation, and your judgment, your professionalism, and your respect for the people in the room matter more than a rulebook. This lesson is about building that judgment.

Three principles to guide your decisions

1 Respect the course: check the syllabus, and ask

Your syllabus is the contract for each course. Some instructors allow recording for personal study. Some don't allow it at all. Many don't mention it, and silence is not the same as permission.

The professional move, every time, is to ask before you record, not after you've already started.

- Check your syllabus first. The answer may already be there.
- If it isn't, ask your instructor directly, before class or by email.
- If an instructor says no, that's the answer. It isn't a negotiation.
- Permission in one class doesn't carry over to another. Ask each instructor.

How to ask: a simple script

> "Professor [Name], I sometimes have trouble capturing everything during lectures, and recordings help me review. Do you allow students to record class for personal study?"

The request is specific, professional, and honest about your reason. Most instructors appreciate being asked rather than finding out later that they were recorded.

PATHFINDER TIP

If recording is part of a documented accommodation, work through Accessibility Services (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/about/student-life/accessibility-services.aspx) to get it in writing. An official accommodation is different from informal permission, and it protects you.

2 Respect the people: your classmates and your instructor

A classroom is a shared space. When you record, you capture more than the instructor's voice. You capture your classmates' questions, comments, and discussion, and they didn't agree to be recorded.

This matters more than most students realize. A classmate who shares something personal, asks a question they feel unsure about, or says something they'd like to take back has a reasonable expectation that it stays in the room.

- An instructor's lectures may be their intellectual property. Sharing recordings without permission can be a serious violation.
- Recording classmates without their knowledge or consent raises real privacy concerns, even when it's technically easy.
- Posting or sharing recordings anywhere outside the class, like social media or group chats, is almost always inappropriate and may violate College policy.
- Even with permission, treat a recording as personal study material, not content to share.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
>
> The test is simple: would the people being recorded be comfortable knowing it, and knowing how the recording will be used? If the answer is anything but a clear yes, don't record, or ask first.

3 Respect your own learning: recording isn't learning

There's a real risk that recording replaces paying attention instead of supporting it. When you know a recording exists, your brain tends to relax, because "it's captured." But captured audio isn't understanding. Making sense of the material still takes work, and that work happens in real time, not during playback.

- Students who rely heavily on recordings often end up with hours of audio they never revisit.
- Taking notes as you go, even imperfect ones, helps you remember more than recording alone.
- If you record, use it alongside your notes, not instead of them. Go back to specific moments you marked as unclear. Don't relisten to the whole thing.
- Working to keep up in real time is part of learning. Don't hand that work off entirely.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
>
> If you're recording because you can't keep up, pay attention to that. Talk to your instructor, and ask the Teaching & Learning Center (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/current-students/academic-resources/teaching-and-learning-center.aspx) about note-taking strategies. The recording may be covering a gap worth addressing directly.

AI note-takers: a separate conversation

AI Literacy BE Safe BE Honest BE Responsible

Tools like Otter.ai, Fireflies, and similar apps go beyond basic recording. They upload audio to another company's servers, process it with outside AI systems, and store transcripts in ways you may not fully control.

Before you use any AI note-taker in a class or meeting, think through these questions:

- **Who has the data?** Uploading a recording sends your classmates' voices and your instructor's lecture to a company's servers. Read the privacy policy before you use it.
- **Did everyone agree?** Your classmates didn't sign up to have their voices processed by an AI company. That's a real privacy concern, not a technicality.
- **Does your instructor know what the tool does?** Many instructors don't realize that "I'm using an AI note-taker" means their lecture goes to an outside platform. That's a different conversation from asking to record on your phone.
- **Is the transcript accurate?** AI transcription makes mistakes, some small, some serious. One misheard term or date can send you studying the wrong thing. Check it against your course materials.
- **Are you still paying attention?** The same risk as recording applies here, maybe more. If the app is "handling it," your brain may check out completely.

The responsible move: treat an AI note-taker like any recording device. Ask permission, be upfront about what the tool does, and use what it produces with a critical eye. If an instructor allows recording but hasn't thought about AI note-takers, have that conversation specifically.
The habit to build here is a professional reflex: **when in doubt, ask.** It will serve you in every classroom, workplace, and meeting you'll ever be part of.

People who ask before acting build trust. People who act first and ask later, or never ask, wear it down. That's true whether the subject is recording a class, sharing information, or a hundred other situations you haven't met yet.

Build the habit now, while the stakes are low. It'll be there when they aren't.

MILE MARKER

Mile Marker #4: My Academic Toolkit

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

Every Pathfinder needs the right tools: the ones that actually work for how you learn.

This Mile Marker is about what works for you, in your real life, this semester. Not what worked for a classmate, and not what a study guide says.

What you'll do

1. **Before you start,** try one study strategy. Questions 1 and 2 are about how it went.
   - Lesson 4.2: Four strategies (pick one and use it in a real class this week)
2. **Answer four questions** in the form below.
3. **Save as PDF** and upload it to the **Mile Marker #4** assignment in Blackboard.

●○ AI use: AI-supported

You may use AI as a thinking partner to explore your ideas. Work with what it gives you, then write your responses in your own voice, including your answer to Question 4. Set your boundary first: Lesson 4.4 shows how. See the AI Course Policy in the syllabus and Lesson 1.4: AI use labels.

Optional prompt to try: "Ask me questions to help me reflect on a study strategy I tried this week and what I noticed about my learning." Use what's useful. Your final responses must be in your own words.

Your Mile Marker

Type your answers in the boxes. Your typing is saved in this browser as you go, so you can come back later on the same device. Nothing is sent anywhere until you upload it.

Your name (required) **Date**

QUESTION 1

The Strategy You Tried

"I studied more" isn't specific. "I tried reviewing my notes out loud the night before class" is.

A STRONG ANSWER

Names **one specific strategy, habit, or tool** and gives a **real reason** you chose it.

1. Name the study strategy, habit, or tool you focused on this week.

2. Explain why you chose it.

Look back at: Lesson 4.2: Four strategies; Trail Tip: Your Microsoft Office 365 Academic Toolkit

QUESTION 2

What You Noticed

Be honest about what happened, not what you hoped would happen.

To get you thinking (no separate answer needed)

- Did it help you understand, remember, or stay focused?
- Did anything surprise you, good or bad?

A STRONG ANSWER

Describes how you used it in **a real class or task** and at least **one specific thing you noticed** about your learning.

1. Describe how you used it in a real class or task.

2. Describe one thing you noticed about your learning.

Look back at: Lesson 4.2: the "Try it and notice" boxes

QUESTION 3

Your SMART Goal

Write one goal for keeping a study strategy or habit going for the rest of the semester. It doesn't need to be a perfect plan, just an honest one that fits where you are right now.

A STRONG ANSWER

Covers **all five parts**, names a **real class or goal**, and includes a **clear way to tell** whether you followed through.

1. Specific: What exactly will you do?

2. Measurable: How will you know you did it?

3. Achievable: Why is it realistic for your life right now?

4. Relevant: Why this habit, and which class or goal does it help?

5. Time-bound: When, and how often?

Look back at: Lesson 4.2: Write a SMART goal; My Week at a Glance (to find a spot for it)

QUESTION 4

Your AI Use

Think about any AI tool you used this week, for this course or any other. If you didn't use AI at all, that's a complete answer. Just say so.

> The AI Creep Meter
>
> 1. Brainstorming
> 2. Outlining
> 3. Drafting
> 4. Revising

5. Rewriting
6. Submitting

Lower stakesHigher stakes

The farther AI moves into the creation of your work, the more important transparency becomes.

A STRONG ANSWER

Says honestly **where your AI use landed** (or that you didn't use AI) and whether that was **where you meant to land**. Full credit doesn't depend on where you landed on the meter.

1. Choose where your AI use landed on the AI Creep Meter.
Circle one: Brainstorming / Outlining / Drafting / Revising / Rewriting / Submitting / I didn't use AI this week

2. Explain whether that was where you meant to land, or whether it shifted further than you planned. If you didn't use AI, write "No AI this week."

Look back at: Lesson 4.4: The AI Creep Meter

Submit it

Upload your PDF to the **Mile Marker #4** assignment in Blackboard. Check Blackboard for the due date.

In an in-person class? Your instructor may give you a printed copy. Fill it in by hand, then upload a photo or scan.

How it's scored: full credit means every prompt is answered, and each answer is about you, with at least one real detail. See How Mile Markers are scored.

WRAP UP

Module 4 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

You've reached the end of Module 4. These are the ideas to carry forward.

Key takeaways

You already have a toolkit. OneNote, OneDrive, Teams, and Copilot come with your KCTCS account. Know they're there so you can reach for the right one.

Study to make it stick, not to feel busy. Retrieval practice, spaced practice, asking why, and mixing it up beat rereading, highlighting, and cramming.

When in doubt about recording, ask. Check the syllabus, ask your instructor first, and respect your classmates' privacy, especially with AI note-takers.

SIFT before you trust. Stop, investigate the source, find better coverage, and trace claims, including everything AI tells you.

Set your AI boundary at the start. Decide what role AI plays before you open the chat, and be able to say honestly where on the Creep Meter your use landed.

REFLECT

Which one study strategy from this module will you use this week, and in which class? What's the first small step?

That's Module 4.

Head back to your course in Blackboard for this module's activities.

MODULE 5

Financial Planning with Purpose

Money touches everything. This module is about seeing it clearly, before trying to change anything.

10 ESSENTIAL SKILLS IN THIS MODULE


#3 Quantitative Reasoning


#6 Professionalism

Why this matters

Financial stress is one of the biggest, and least talked about, barriers to college success. It's uncomfortable, and it's also mentally expensive: your brain keeps working on money problems in the background, even when you're trying to focus on something else.

This module won't tell you to follow a strict budget or stop buying coffee. It will help you see your financial situation more clearly, and give your money a plan that fits your real life.

What you'll be able to do

By the end of this module:

A

I can build a realistic zero-based budget that assigns all available income to specific categories.

B

I can identify at least one pattern in my spending habits and describe one small change I want to make.

C

I can explain what financial wellness means and describe how it connects to my overall wellbeing.

D

I can use AI tools safely for budgeting exploration without sharing personal financial information.

AI Literacy: BE behaviors in this module

- BE Safe
- BE Responsible

Lessons in this module

Trail Tool: Dollar Tracker

Look back: where your money actually goes.

Trail Tool: Budget Builder

Look ahead: give every dollar a job.

5.1 Skill Spotlight: Quantitative Reasoning

Thinking clearly with numbers, which you already do every day.

5.2 What Is Financial Wellness?

A feeling of steadiness you can work toward from wherever you're starting.

5.3 Where Does My Money Go?

You can't manage what you can't see. Awareness comes first.

Trail Tip: Financial Aid at OCTC

The presentation, the steps to get and keep your aid, and who to ask.

Mile Marker: Mile Marker #5: Understanding My Money

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

Wrap Up: Module 5 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

TRAIL TOOL

Dollar Tracker

Look back: where your money actually goes.

Most people think they know where their money goes, until they actually look.

The Dollar Tracker is a reality check, not a budget. Write down where your money went, big and small, with no judging. Choose the option that fits your situation. Either one gives you a clearer picture of your spending patterns. Rough estimates are fine.

YOUR NUMBERS STAY WITH YOU

What you type is saved only in this browser, on this device. It isn't sent anywhere. Rounded or practice numbers work just as well as exact ones.

Look back: Dollar Tracker

A **reality check**. Write down where your money actually went, with no judging. Just notice.

Use it for: Mile Marker #5, Question 1

YOU ARE HERE

Look ahead: Budget Builder

A **plan**. Give every dollar coming in this month a job, until nothing is left unassigned.

Use it for: Mile Marker #5, Question 4

Open the Budget Builder

Fill in your tracker

Fill in Option A, Option B, or both. The totals add up as you type. When you're done, select **Save as PDF** to keep a copy.

LOOK AHEAD

Lesson 5.3 walks you through what to look for.

Your name (required)

Week of

OPTION A

Look back at the past 7 days

Where did your money go? Rename any category so it fits your life.

CategoryAmount

Estimated total spent $0

OPTION B

Track every purchase for the next 7 days

Write down every purchase this week, big or small. No judging.

Week total $0

LOOKING BACK

What did you notice?

What surprised you the most?

Which category took more than you expected?

Where did small purchases add up?

One thing you'd do differently next week, not because you have to, but because it would feel better

TRAIL TOOL

Budget Builder

Look ahead: give every dollar a job.

A zero-based budget gives every dollar coming in this month a job, until there are zero dollars left without one.

Saving, paying down debt, and fun are all jobs. The point is to decide on purpose, before the money is gone, instead of wondering at the end of the month where it went.

YOUR NUMBERS STAY WITH YOU

What you type is saved only in this browser, on this device. It isn't sent anywhere. Rounded or practice numbers work just as well as exact ones.

LOOK BACK AT

Lesson 5.3: Give every dollar a job has a worked example.

Look back: Dollar Tracker

A **reality check**. Write down where your money actually went, with no judging. Just notice.

Use it for: Mile Marker #5, Question 1

Open the Dollar Tracker

Look ahead: Budget Builder

A **plan**. Give every dollar coming in this month a job, until nothing is left unassigned.

Use it for: Mile Marker #5, Question 4

YOU ARE HERE

Build your budget for one month

Enter the money coming in, then assign it to categories until **Left to assign** reaches $0. Rename any category so it fits your life. Select **Save as PDF** to keep a copy.

PATHFINDER TIP

If your income changes month to month, plan on the lowest amount you can count on. If more comes in, give the extra a job then.

Your name (required)

Month of

STEP 1

Money coming in this month

Total coming in $0

STEP 2

Give every dollar a job

Start with your Musts, like housing, food, and getting to school and work. Then the rest.

CategoryAmount

Total assigned $0

Left to assign $0

Start by entering the money coming in this month.

STEP 3

Why these jobs?

Why did you choose these categories, and what did giving every dollar a job show you?

LESSON 5.1

Skill Spotlight: Quantitative Reasoning

Thinking clearly with numbers, which you already do every day.



10 Essential Skills · #3

Quantitative Reasoning

First, let's name the thing

If your stomach dropped a little when you read "Quantitative Reasoning," you're not alone.

A lot of people carry math anxiety from years of feeling like numbers weren't for them. Maybe a teacher made you feel slow. Maybe a test went badly. Maybe at some point you decided you were a "words person, not a numbers person."

Quantitative Reasoning, as Kentucky defines it, has little to do with solving equations or memorizing formulas. It means using numbers to understand the world around you and to make better decisions. You already do that, probably without noticing.

> **Quantitative Reasoning is thinking with numbers, and you already do it.**

You already do this

Every time you work with numbers in a real situation, outside of a test, you're practicing Quantitative Reasoning.

AT THE GAS STATION

"Gas is $3.49 a gallon and I need about half a tank, so roughly $25." That's estimating with real data.

CHECKING YOUR GRADE

"I have an 82, and there's one more assignment worth 20%. What do I need to pass?" That's percentages applied to a real decision.

READING A PAYCHECK

"I worked 23 hours at $12.50. Why does my check say $215?" That's understanding taxes, deductions, and gross versus take-home pay.

TRACKING SPENDING

"I spent $180 on food this week, and my food budget is $200 a month. That's already 90% gone." That's using numbers to describe what's happening.

READING THE NEWS

"The article says crime is up 40%. But 40% of what? Starting from how many?" That's questioning the assumptions behind data.

MAKING A DECISION

"Is it cheaper to drive or take a rideshare? Let me actually figure out the cost." That's using numbers to choose the best option.

Where you're headed

Below, in plain terms, is the difference between where most students start and where you're headed.

SEE ALSO

Lesson 1.2 explains Benchmark, Milestone, and Capstone.

Benchmark Where you're starting

- You can pick out key information from graphs, tables, and equations.
- You can do basic arithmetic and calculate percentages and simple statistics.
- You can tell when numbers are relevant to a problem.

Milestone

YOUR TARGET

- You show real-life data in ways that make its meaning clear, not just read it.
- You use percentages and statistics to describe what's actually happening in a real situation.
- You use numbers to state your assumptions and work through problems: not just calculating, but reasoning.

The shift from Benchmark to Milestone is the shift from working with numbers to thinking with them: from calculating to reasoning.

Where it shows up in this module

Module 5 is where Quantitative Reasoning gets personal. Every part of it works with numbers in a real setting: your spending, your patterns, your decisions.

The Dollar Tracker. Recording what you actually spent, by category, over time, turns numbers into a picture of your real life.

Reading your spending patterns. Noticing "food delivery is about 30% of what I spend" is using statistics to describe what's really happening.

The Budget Builder. Giving every dollar a job until nothing is left is reasoning with numbers to make a plan, and checking that it adds up.

Questioning the data. When a statistic sounds surprising, like "the average student spends $X on food," asking "compared to what? Which students?" is Quantitative Reasoning. Numbers only mean something in context.

A note on math anxiety

If numbers have felt threatening in the past, you're allowed to say so. Math anxiety is real, it's common, and it doesn't mean you can't build this skill. It usually means something went wrong in how you were taught, not that you're incapable.

Quantitative Reasoning at this level doesn't require algebra or calculus. It takes attention, honesty, and a willingness to look at numbers without flinching. You have all of those.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> If a number task makes the anxiety kick in, pause, breathe, and ask: "What is this number actually telling me?" That question is the heart of the skill.

In your own life

REFLECT

Think of a recent decision that involved numbers, even a small one. What information did you use? What did you estimate or calculate?

Is there a number in your life right now, like a bill, a grade, or a balance, that you've been avoiding? What would it take to look at it honestly?

When you hear a statistic in the news or on social media, what's your first instinct: believe it, question it, or ignore it? What would Quantitative Reasoning tell you to do?

Skill definition and Milestone indicators are based on the Kentucky Council on Postsecondary Education's Kentucky Graduate Profile (https://cpe.ky.gov/ourwork/kygradprofile.html).

LESSON 5.2

What Is Financial Wellness?

A feeling of steadiness you can work toward from wherever you're starting.

Money touches everything: your stress level, your schedule, your ability to say yes to an opportunity or no to something that doesn't work for you.

When your financial life feels out of control, even a little, it creates a low hum of anxiety under everything else you're trying to do. Financial wellness doesn't depend on having a certain amount of money. It comes from having enough awareness and intention around money that you feel steady, or at least less reactive. You can work toward that no matter what's in your bank account right now.

> **Financial wellness is a direction, not a destination.**

KEY TERM

Financial wellness: feeling steady and in some control of your money, because you know where it goes and make choices on purpose.

What financial wellness is, and isn't

The term gets used a lot of different ways, so it helps to be clear about what it is and isn't.

Financial wellness is

- Knowing roughly where your money goes
- Feeling some control, even if it's limited
- Handling a small unexpected expense without a crisis
- Making intentional choices about money, even small ones
- Knowing what resources are available to you
- Worrying less about money over time

Financial wellness isn't

- Having a lot of money
- Never struggling financially
- Following a perfect budget every month
- Having no debt
- Saving a fixed percentage of every paycheck
- Doing everything "right" by someone else's standard

If money is tight right now, because you're supporting family, managing debt, or working more than one job, financial wellness still applies to you. It just looks different at different income levels. The goal is to feel more in control of your own picture, not to match someone else's.

Where it fits: the eight dimensions of wellness

Financial wellness doesn't stand alone. It's one of eight dimensions of overall wellness, and when one is out of balance, the others feel it. Think of a wheel: if one section is flat, the whole ride gets bumpy.

> **LOOK BACK AT**
> Some of these overlap with the five batteries from Lesson 3.5.

- Emotional
- Physical
- Social
- Financial You are here
- Occupational
- Intellectual
- Environmental
- Spiritual

Notice how many of the other seven feel it when money is stressful: sleep, relationships, focus, even your sense of purpose.

Optional: check your own wellness wheel

University of New Hampshire Extension offers a free interactive Wellness Wheel that gives you a snapshot across all eight dimensions in about 10 minutes. It isn't graded or submitted. It's just a clearer picture, if you want one.

Try the UNH Wellness Wheel (https://unhextension.datahubs.org/)

Money stress and school

Financial stress is one of the biggest, and least talked about, barriers to finishing college. It's uncomfortable, and it's also mentally expensive. When you're worried about money, your brain keeps working on that problem in the background, even when you're trying to focus on something else.

Research consistently links financial stress to trouble with concentration, memory, decision-making, and planning ahead, which are exactly the skills college asks for. Students under financial stress are more likely to cut back their classes, step away, or leave college entirely. They could do the work, but the weight of money worries made it hard to focus on anything else. **That's a real mental load, not a character flaw, and it deserves to be taken seriously.**

> **LOOK BACK AT**
> Your Success Coach is a good first call when money is getting in the way of school.

Money help at OCTC and beyond

If money is making it hard to focus on school right now, reach out. There may be help you don't know about yet. The Trail Tip Financial Aid at OCTC walks through the steps.

- Affording College at OCTC (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/affording-college/index.aspx): financial aid, scholarships, grants, payment plans, and work study
- FAFSA (https://studentaid.gov/h/apply-for-aid/fafsa): the federal application for grants, work study, and loans
- KHEAA (https://www.kheaa.com/web/home.faces): Kentucky's state financial aid agency, with state grants, scholarships, and planning help
- OCTC Student Support Services (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/about/student-life/student-support-services.aspx): support services and referrals, including help when life gets in the way

You're somewhere on the financial wellness spectrum right now. Everyone is. This module doesn't ask "Are you doing it right?" It asks "Do you know what's happening, and is there one small thing you can do to feel a little more in control?"

The next lesson, Where Does My Money Go?, helps you answer that, starting with awareness before strategy and clarity before action.

LESSON 5.3

Where Does My Money Go?

You can't manage what you can't see. Awareness comes first.

Most people think they know where their money goes, until they actually look.

College makes spending even harder to track: gas, groceries, random fees, subscriptions you forgot you had, late-night delivery, "just one thing" from the store. It adds up faster than it should, and usually in ways you didn't see coming.

This lesson won't judge your spending. It will help you see it clearly, and then give your money a plan. Clarity is the real starting point for any financial decision, at any income, in any life situation.

> **Before you fix anything, you need to see it clearly.**

Why this matters, for everyone

Money stress shows up differently depending on where you're starting.

"I live with my parents and have some money from work, but I never know where it goes by the end of the month."

"I'm working full-time, paying rent, and trying to make it all stretch."

"I have financial aid money right now, but I know it won't last the whole semester."

"I'm supporting my family. There's not much wiggle room, and I'm stressed about it constantly."

All four of those students could be in this course, and all four benefit from the same first move: knowing what's actually happening with their money before trying to change it.

Three steps to seeing clearly

1 Look at the last week or two

You don't need bank statements, though you can use them if you have them. Start by asking: where did my money go in the last week or two? Rough estimates are fine. You want a general picture, not an audit.

Common student spending categories:

- **Food:** groceries, snacks, eating out, delivery
- **Transportation:** gas, rideshare, parking
- **School:** textbooks, supplies, fees, printing
- **Subscriptions:** streaming, music, apps, cloud storage
- **Personal:** toiletries, clothing, household
- **Social:** going out, gifts, splitting bills
- **Bills:** phone, rent, utilities, insurance
- **Random:** convenience stores, online orders, impulse buys

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> Use the Dollar Tracker to make this concrete. Option A looks back at the past week. Option B tracks the next week as it happens. Pick the one that fits where you are.

2 Notice what surprises you

Most people find at least one thing they didn't expect, and that surprise is where awareness starts doing its work.

- "I eat out way more than I thought."
- "Small purchases, $5 here and $8 there, add up to a lot."
- "I didn't plan for school fees until they hit."

You don't have to fix anything yet. Noticing is worth more than it sounds.

3 Find your money leaks

A **money leak** is spending that doesn't line up with what you actually value or need. What counts is spending *you* recognize as out of line with your own priorities, not spending someone else thinks is unnecessary.

- Delivery fees when you already have food at home
- Subscriptions you forgot about and don't use
- Convenience buys that happen because you didn't plan ahead
- Impulse buys you regret within a day or two
- Social spending that felt like an obligation instead of a choice

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> A money leak isn't the same as spending on something you enjoy. If eating out truly matters to you, that's a priority, not a leak. The leak is spending that leaves you wondering where your money went.

Give every dollar a job

Once you know where your money goes, you can decide where it *should* go. The approach that works best for most students is a **zero-based budget**: when money comes in, you give every dollar a job until there are zero dollars left without one.

Zero doesn't mean you spend it all. Savings, paying down debt, and fun are all jobs too. The difference is that you decide on purpose, when the money arrives, instead of trying to figure out at the end of the month what happened.

> KEY TERM
>
> **Zero-based budget:** a plan that gives every dollar coming in a job (spending, saving, or paying debt) until money in minus money assigned equals zero.

1. ### List what's coming in this month

   Paychecks, financial aid, help from family, anything else. If your income changes, plan on the lowest amount you can count on. If a financial aid refund has to last the whole semester, divide it across the months it needs to cover.

2. ### List every place it needs to go

   Start with your Musts: housing, food, getting to school and work, bills. Then the rest: savings, school costs, personal, fun.

3. ### Assign until you reach $0

   Give each category an amount until money in minus money assigned equals zero. If you run out before you run out of categories, trim something. If money is left over, give it a job, even if the job is savings.

4. ### Adjust as the month happens

   Real life will change the plan. When you overspend in one category, move money from another. That's how the budget is supposed to work.

Example: one student's zero-based month

Coming in	Amount
Paychecks (part-time job)	$1,400
Help from family	$200
Total coming in	$1,600
Every dollar's job	**Amount**
Total assigned	$1,600

Every dollar's job	Amount
Share of rent	$550
Groceries	$260
Gas and car	$180
Utilities and phone	$120
Car insurance	$110
Fun and social	$90
Emergency fund	$80
Personal and household	$70
School costs	$60
Giving or family	$40
Subscriptions	$40
Total assigned	$1,600

$1,600 coming in − $1,600 assigned = **$0 left to assign**. Every dollar has a job.

Try it: the Budget Builder

Build your own zero-based budget for one month. It adds up as you type and shows what's left to assign. Real, rounded, or practice numbers all work, and nothing you type leaves your device.

Open the Budget Builder

Tools worth knowing about

You don't need an app to do any of this. A notes app or a simple list works just as well, because the habit matters more than the tool. If you want one, these support the give-every-dollar-a-job approach:

- YNAB (You Need A Budget)Built around giving every dollar a job before you spend it. Free for college students for one year. ynab.com (https://www.ynab.com/college)
- Copilot MoneyA separate company from Microsoft, with no connection to your Microsoft Office 365 account. Automatic spending tracking. Paid subscription. copilot.money (https://www.copilot.money/)
- Your bank's appMost banks have built-in spending tracking and category views. Free, and already connected to your accounts.
- A spreadsheetExcel, free with your KCTCS Microsoft Office 365 account, or Google Sheets. Flexible and completely private.

AI as a money thinking partner

AI Literacy BE Safe BE Responsible

Microsoft Copilot, available with your KCTCS account, can be a useful thinking partner for money questions. It isn't a budgeting app, and it doesn't connect to your bank. Use it to explore ideas and come up with questions, not to manage your money.

- **Understanding ideas:** "Explain what an emergency fund is and why it matters." "What's the difference in risk between a debit card and a credit card?"
- **Finding questions to ask:** "What questions should I ask the financial aid office about when my aid arrives?"
- **Thinking through categories:** "What spending categories should a college student track?" Use general examples, not your actual numbers.
- **Exploring options:** "What are some free ways to track spending without an app?"

Never share personal financial information with an AI tool: account numbers, Social Security numbers, income, debt amounts, or anything you wouldn't post publicly. Use general descriptions and practice numbers only. "I spend a lot on food," not "I spend $347 a month on groceries." Then check its suggestions against your real situation before you act on them.

Financial wellness doesn't start with a perfect budget. It starts with seeing clearly: what comes in, what goes out, and where the gaps are between what you spend and what you value. Then you give your money a plan.

One honest look, and one plan that adds up to zero, is a real step forward.

TRAIL TIP

Financial Aid at OCTC

The presentation, the steps to get and keep your aid, and who to ask.

Financial aid is money to help you pay for college. It's worth knowing how it works, because it can change what you can afford and how many classes you can take.

This Trail Tip gathers OCTC's financial aid information in one place: the presentation from the Financial Aid office, the steps to get and keep your aid, and where to go with questions.

The Financial Aid presentation

OCTC's Financial Aid office has a presentation for FYE 100 students. It explains the kinds of aid, how to apply, and what to do after you're awarded.

Find it in Blackboard

Check this module in Blackboard for the Financial Aid presentation. Watch or read it before you work on your budget, so you know what aid you can count on.

Getting and keeping your aid

These steps follow OCTC's Financial Aid Checklist. If you've already done some of them, start where you are.

1. **Create your StudentAid.gov account**

   This account, also called an FSA ID, is how you sign in to the FAFSA and sign it.

2. **Complete the FAFSA**

   The FAFSA is the free federal application for grants, work study, and loans. You fill it out again for each school year, so put it on your calendar.

3. **Apply for scholarships**

   OCTC has its own scholarships, and there are many outside ones. Scholarships are money you don't pay back.

4. **Check your tasks in Student Self-Service**

If Financial Aid needs a document from you, it shows up as a task. Missing tasks can hold up your aid, so check often.

5. **Choose how you'll get your refund**

   If your aid is more than your bill, the extra comes to you as a refund. OCTC sends refunds through BankMobile, and you choose how you want to receive yours.

6. **Check your bill**

   Look at your account statement to make sure your aid covers what you owe. If it doesn't, ask about a payment plan.

7. **Keep your aid in place**

   Stay enrolled, keep your grades up, and finish the classes you start. The next section has the two numbers to watch.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> A refund often has to last the whole semester. Lesson 5.3 shows how to divide it across the months it needs to cover.

OCTC Financial Aid Checklist

The full checklist, with links for each step.

Open the Financial Aid Checklist (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/affording-college/financial-aid-checklist.aspx)

Two numbers that protect your aid

To keep getting financial aid, you have to show you're making progress toward your credential. Colleges call this **Satisfactory Academic Progress**, or SAP. It's checked at the end of every semester, and two numbers cause most of the trouble.

Your GPA: 2.0 or higher

Your cumulative GPA, which covers all your classes so far, has to stay at 2.0 or above. That's a C average.

Your completion rate: 67% or higher

You have to pass at least two-thirds of the credit hours you sign up for. If you sign up for 12 credit hours and pass 6, your rate is 50%.

KEY TERM

Completion rate: the credit hours you've passed, divided by the credit hours you've attempted.

LOOK BACK AT

How your GPA is calculated

A W STILL COUNTS AGAINST YOU

A class you withdraw from (W), fail (E), or leave incomplete (I) counts as attempted but not passed. A W doesn't lower your GPA, but it does lower your completion rate. Withdrawing from two classes in one semester can be enough to put your aid at risk.

There's also a limit on total credit hours: aid covers up to 150% of the credits your program requires. Changing programs several times or repeating many classes can use that up.

If you fall below

The first time, you're placed on warning and can still receive aid for one more semester. If you're still below after that, your aid is suspended. You can appeal a suspension through Student Self-Service, and Financial Aid can explain how.

Notices about your status go to your KCTCS email shortly after the semester ends, so keep checking it over the break.

- KCTCS Satisfactory Academic Progress policy (https://kctcs.edu/affording-college/satisfactory-academic-progress/): the full rules, including warning, suspension, and appeals
- Satisfactory Academic Progress at OCTC (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/affording-college/satisfactory-academic-progress/index.aspx): OCTC's summary and how to appeal

Ask before you change your schedule

Dropping a class, withdrawing, or taking fewer credit hours can change your aid. Sometimes it means paying money back. Talk to Financial Aid **before** you make the change, so you know what it will cost.

Good questions to bring:

- How many credit hours do I need to keep my aid?
- If I drop this class, what happens to my aid this semester and next?
- When will my aid arrive, and when would a refund come?
- Are there scholarships or grants I haven't applied for?

> **SEE ALSO**
> Lesson 6.4: how your course load connects to your aid

Where to find more

Paying for college at OCTC

- Grants (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/affording-college/paying-for-college/grants.aspx): money you don't pay back, usually based on need
- Scholarships (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/affording-college/paying-for-college/scholarships.aspx): money you don't pay back, with an application
- Work Study (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/affording-college/paying-for-college/work-study.aspx): a part-time job, often on campus, that helps pay for school
- Loans (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/affording-college/paying-for-college/loans.aspx): money you borrow and pay back
- Payment Plans (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/affording-college/paying-for-college/payment-plans.aspx): a way to spread out what you owe
- Terms to Know (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/affording-college/paying-for-college/terms-to-know.aspx): plain definitions of financial aid words
- FAFSA (https://studentaid.gov/h/apply-for-aid/fafsa): the federal application

Contact Financial Aid

Email octc.financialaid@kctcs.edu or call 270-686-4520. The Financial Aid contact page (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/affording-college/contact-us.aspx) has the current details.

Asking Financial Aid a question is free, and it can save you real money. When you're not sure, ask.

MILE MARKER

Mile Marker #5: Understanding My Money

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

The point is to know yourself a little better when it comes to money. Nobody needs a perfect budget.

Leave this module with one honest insight and one realistic intention. There are no right or wrong financial situations here, and you never need to share a dollar amount.

What you'll do

1. **Before you start,** finish these two Trail Tools. You never have to share them.
   - Dollar Tracker (your spending, for Question 1)
   - Budget Builder (your zero-based budget, for Question 4)
2. **Answer five questions** in the form below.
3. **Save as PDF** and upload it to the **Mile Marker #5** assignment in Blackboard.

●○ AI use: AI-supported

You may use AI as a thinking partner to explore your ideas. Work with what it gives you, then write your responses in your own voice. Never share real account numbers, income, debt, or other personal financial details with an AI tool. Use general descriptions only: "I spend a lot on food," not "I spend $347 a month on groceries." See the AI Course Policy in the syllabus and Lesson 1.4: AI use labels.

Optional prompt to try: "Ask me questions to help me understand my spending patterns and identify one realistic change I could make, without sharing any personal financial details." Use what's useful. Your final responses must be in your own words.

Your Mile Marker

Type your answers in the boxes. Your typing is saved in this browser as you go, so you can come back later on the same device. Nothing is sent anywhere until you upload it.

Your name (required) **Date**

QUESTION 1

What You Noticed

Look at your Dollar Tracker.

To get you thinking (no separate answer needed)

- What surprised you, or confirmed something you already suspected?
- Which category took more than you expected? Where did small purchases add up?

> **A STRONG ANSWER**
>
> Names **one real pattern** from your tracker, like a category or a kind of small purchase, and says what it shows about your **actual priorities**.

1. Name one pattern you noticed in your spending.

---

2. Explain what it shows about your priorities right now, even if they're different from what you'd say out loud.

Look back at: Dollar Tracker; Lesson 5.3: Three steps to seeing clearly

QUESTION 2

Your Financial Reality

Describe your situation honestly, not for judgment but for clarity. No numbers needed.

> **A STRONG ANSWER**
>
> Describes your situation **honestly without numbers**, names your **biggest pressure and one support**, and explains **financial wellness in your own words**, connected to your schoolwork or another part of your wellness.

1. Choose the word that fits your financial life right now.

Circle one: Tight / Manageable / Comfortable / Complicated / Somewhere in between

2. Name your biggest financial pressure this semester, and one resource, habit, or support that's helping.

---

3. Explain what financial wellness means to you, and how money affects your schoolwork or another part of your wellness.

Look back at: Lesson 5.2: The eight dimensions of wellness; Money help at OCTC

QUESTION 3

One Realistic Next Step

It doesn't have to be dramatic. It just has to be honest and doable for your life right now.

> **A STRONG ANSWER**
>
> Names **one specific step**, connects it to **something you noticed**, and explains why it's **realistic** for your life right now.

1. Name one small thing you'll do differently, or keep doing, with money.

2. Explain why it's the right next step for where you are.

Look back at: Lesson 5.3: Find your money leaks

QUESTION 4

Your Zero-Based Budget

Look at the budget you built in the Budget Builder. No dollar amounts needed.

> **A STRONG ANSWER**
>
> Explains **why you chose your categories**, says whether your budget **balances to zero** (and what you'll adjust if it doesn't), and names **one thing** building it showed you.

1. Explain why you chose the categories you gave jobs to.

2. Did every dollar get a job? If not, say what you'll adjust.

3. Name one thing that giving every dollar a job showed you.

Look back at: Budget Builder; Lesson 5.3: Give every dollar a job

QUESTION 5

Keeping It Private

If you didn't use AI for this module, that's a complete answer. Just say so.

A STRONG ANSWER

Names **what you kept out** of your prompts and **how you worded things instead**, or says plainly that you didn't use AI.

1. If you used AI, describe what you left out of your prompts and how you described your situation instead. If you didn't, write "No AI this module."

Look back at: Lesson 5.3: AI as a money thinking partner

Submit it

Upload your PDF to the **Mile Marker #5** assignment in Blackboard. Check Blackboard for the due date.

In an in-person class? Your instructor may give you a printed copy. Fill it in by hand, then upload a photo or scan.

Optional: attach your tracker or budget too. That's your choice.

How it's scored: full credit means every prompt is answered, and each answer is about you, with at least one real detail. See How Mile Markers are scored.

WRAP UP

Module 5 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

You've reached the end of Module 5. These are the ideas to carry forward.

Key takeaways

You already reason with numbers. Quantitative Reasoning is thinking clearly with numbers in real life, not doing math for a test.

Financial wellness is a direction, not a dollar amount. It means feeling steadier because you know where your money goes, at any income.

Money stress is real mental load. It affects focus, memory, and planning. If it's getting in the way of school, reach out for help.

See it before you change it. Track where your money actually goes, notice what surprises you, and find the leaks that don't match what you value.

Give every dollar a job. A zero-based budget assigns all the money coming in, including savings, until nothing is left without a plan.

Keep your numbers private with AI. Use AI to think and ask questions, never with real account numbers, income, or debt amounts.

REFLECT

The next time money comes in, what's the first job you'll give it, and why that one?

That's Module 5.

Head back to your course in Blackboard for this module's activities.

MODULE 6

Map Your Path — Academic Planning

Your plan doesn't have to be final. It has to be specific enough to start a real conversation.

10 ESSENTIAL SKILLS IN THIS MODULE


#1 Communication


#6 Professionalism


#9 Knowledge Application


#10 Information Literacy

Why this matters

Most students walk into advising appointments without a plan, and walk out with a generic schedule that may or may not fit their actual goals.

This module helps you explore programs that might fit, understand how credentials stack at OCTC, and build the specific questions that turn a routine appointment into a useful one.

What you'll be able to do

By the end of this module:

A

I can interpret my Career Coach or O*NET Interest Profiler results and connect them to at least one program or career direction at OCTC.

B

I can describe the difference between certificates, diplomas, AAS degrees, and transfer pathways at OCTC.

C

I can draft a realistic course load for next semester based on my goals, schedule, and program requirements.

D

I can write five specific questions to bring to my Success Coach advising appointment.

E

I can use AI responsibly to explore academic pathways without sharing personal identifying information.

AI Literacy: BE behaviors in this module

- BE Responsible
- BE Reflective

Lessons in this module

Trail Tool: Academic Planner

Look ahead: sketch your next semesters and the questions to bring.

6.1 Skill Spotlight: Knowledge Application

Turning what you know into real decisions.

6.2 Explore Your Interests with Career Coach

Take the assessment, read your results, and see what they point toward.

6.3 Programs & Pathways at OCTC

How credentials stack, and how your results connect to real programs.

6.4 Build a Simple Academic Plan

A map, not a rigid schedule.

Trail Tip: Wait... How Is My Grade Actually Calculated?

Most students don't know. Now you will.

Mile Marker: Mile Marker #6: My Academic Plan

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

Wrap Up: Module 6 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

TRAIL TOOL

Academic Planner

Look ahead: sketch your next semesters and the questions to bring.

An academic plan is a rough map of where you're headed and what has to happen in what order.

Start rough and revise it with your Success Coach. Fill in your program of interest, the things to know before you plan, and your next semester plus a couple more. Then bring it, and your questions, to your advising appointment.

> LOOK AHEAD
>
> Lesson 6.4: Build a Simple Academic Plan walks you through how to think about each part.

Fill in your plan

Your plan saves in this browser as you go. Credit hours add up for each semester. Select **Save as PDF** to print it or bring it to your appointment. You may attach it to Mile Marker #6 if you like, but you don't have to.

> PATHFINDER TIP
>
> Look up exact course names and requirements in the KCTCS catalog (https://catalog.kctcs.edu/). Rough is fine for now. Your Success Coach will help you fill in the gaps.

Your name (required)

Date

Program of interest

Credential goal (certificate, diploma, AAS, or AA/AS)

BEFORE YOU PLAN

Things to know first

Prerequisites I need to finish, and when

Application deadlines or entrance exams to know about

Courses only offered certain semesters (ask your advisor)

My realistic credit load per semester, and why

Next Semester

Which semester?

CourseCredit hours

Estimated credit hours 0

The semester after

Which semester?

CourseCredit hours

Estimated credit hours 0

One more semester

Which semester?

CourseCredit hours

Estimated credit hours 0

BRING THESE

Questions for my Success Coach

Question 1

Question 2

Question 3

Question 4

Question 5

Before your advising appointment

- Bring your Career Coach results
- Know your program of interest, or your top two
- Have specific questions written out
- Know your work and family schedule for next semester
- Ask about application deadlines and entrance exams
- Ask which courses are only offered certain semesters

LESSON 6.1

Skill Spotlight: Knowledge Application

Turning what you know into real decisions.



10 Essential Skills · #9

Knowledge Application

What this skill is

Knowing things is the starting point. Applying what you know to real decisions is the skill.

Knowledge Application is the bridge between learning and doing. Knowing your interests, your strengths, and what programs exist at OCTC is a start. The skill is connecting that knowledge to real decisions about your academic path, your career direction, and your life, in ways that are thoughtful, specific, and honest about your actual situation.

It may be the most important skill in college, because it's the one that makes everything else useful. Without it, you collect information but don't go anywhere with it. With it, what you learn becomes a tool for moving forward.

> **Knowledge Application turns "I know that" into "I did something with it."**

Where you're headed

Below, in plain terms, is the difference between where most students start and where you're headed.

> SEE ALSO
>
> Lesson 1.2 explains Benchmark, Milestone, and Capstone.

Benchmark Where you're starting

- You can name the kind of work you're interested in and how it connects to career opportunities.
- You can describe the basic knowledge, skills, and abilities your career direction requires.
- You explore careers with your strengths, interests, values, and goals in mind.

Milestone

YOUR TARGET

- You use what you've learned to solve basic problems related to your career path.
- You can explain the ideas behind putting knowledge, skills, and abilities to work in your field.
- You reflect on your experiences to judge how well a career fits you, and can explain your reasons.

The shift from Benchmark to Milestone is the shift from exploring possibilities to making informed, reasoned choices, and being able to explain why.

Where it shows up in this module

Module 6 is where Knowledge Application gets concrete. Along with learning about programs, you'll connect what you know about yourself to real academic decisions with real deadlines.

Interpreting your Career Coach results. Taking an interest assessment is a start. Working out what the results mean, and how your interest types connect to real programs, is Knowledge Application.

Connecting interests to programs. Knowing programs exist is different from knowing which one fits your situation, goals, and timeline. Making that connection is the skill.

Planning strategically. Knowing that a math course comes before biology, that a program has an application deadline, and that prerequisites come in sequence, and planning around it, is this skill in action.

Preparing smart advisor questions. "What classes should I take?" is a Benchmark question. "I'm interested in nursing. What do I need to finish this semester to stay on track for the next application deadline?" is Milestone. The specifics come from applying what you know.

In your own life

REFLECT

Think of a recent decision, about school, work, or life, where you used something you'd learned to figure out what to do. What did you know, and how did you apply it?

What do you know right now about your academic direction? What do you still need to find out, and where would you go to find it?

What would it mean to walk into your Success Coach appointment with a specific plan and specific questions, instead of "I'm not sure what to take next"?

How it shows up later

Knowledge Application is one of the three assigned skills for your STAR(T) Stories at the end of the course, and it's the skill this course assesses through them. You'll write or record one story that shows it in action.

The planning you're doing right now is possible material. A moment when you connected what you know about yourself, like your interests, strengths, and goals, to a real academic or career decision is exactly the kind of specific, honest story the capstone is looking for. Start noticing those moments, because they're happening whether you're paying attention or not. The STAR(T) Stories Guide at the back of this book walks you through the whole capstone, with a practice guide for each story.

Skill definition and Milestone indicators are based on the Kentucky Council on Postsecondary Education's Kentucky Graduate Profile (https://cpe.ky.gov/ourwork/kygradprofile.html).

LESSON 6.2

Explore Your Interests with Career Coach

Take the assessment, read your results, and see what they point toward.

Most students arrive at college with either a very specific idea ("I want to be a nurse") or no idea at all ("I just know I need a degree").

Both are fine starting points, and both benefit from the same thing: a clearer picture of what actually interests you, and how that connects to real programs and real careers.

Career Coach is OCTC's career exploration tool, and it does something most interest assessments don't: it connects your results directly to OCTC programs and to regional job information. In this lesson, you'll take the interest assessment, read your results, and start thinking about what they mean for your direction.

Open OCTC Career Coach

Take the career assessment, see your matches, and find the OCTC programs connected to them. Your results feed into Mile Marker #6.

Go to Career Coach (https://owensboro.lightcastcc.com/)
Or start from OCTC's Career Coach page (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/education-training/career-coaching/index.aspx).

ANOTHER OPTION

The free O*NET Interest Profiler (https://onetinterestprofiler.org/) uses the same six interest types. It's a good second opinion, but it doesn't link to OCTC programs.

What it measures: the six interest types

Career Coach uses the **RIASEC** model, a widely used framework developed by psychologist John Holland, to sort interests into six types. Most people have a mix of two or three strong types. Knowing your mix helps you see which work environments and career directions tend to fit people like you.

KEY TERM

RIASEC: six interest types (Realistic, Investigative, Artistic, Social, Enterprising, Conventional) used to match people with work they're likely to enjoy.

- R

Realistic

Doers who like working with their hands, tools, machines, or the outdoors. Practical and results-focused.

- I

Investigative

Thinkers who love working through problems, research, and ideas. Curious and analytical.

- A

Artistic

Creators who value self-expression, imagination, and freedom. Drawn to design, writing, and music.

- S

Social

Helpers who enjoy working with and for people. Drawn to education, healthcare, and community work.

- E

Enterprising

Leaders who like persuading and driving results. Drawn to business, sales, and management.

- C

Conventional

Organizers who thrive with structure and systems. Detail-focused, drawn to data, finance, and process.

Your top two or three types together tell a more useful story than any one type alone. A Social-Investigative mix points somewhere different than a Social-Enterprising one, even though both include Social. Pay attention to the combination, not only the highest score.

How to take the assessment

1. ### Open Career Coach and make an account

   Create a free account with your KCTCS email, not a personal one. That saves your results so you can come back to them, in Module 8 and beyond.

2. ### Choose the Detailed Assessment

   Career Coach offers a Quick (6 questions), Detailed (30 questions), and Comprehensive (60 questions) version. The Detailed version gives you enough to work with without taking too long. Answer based on what

truly interests you, not what sounds practical or what you think you should like. If you're unsure, go with your gut.

3. ### Review all of your results

   Look at your interest profile, your top career matches, and the OCTC programs connected to them. Scan past the #1 match to see what patterns show up. Open a few careers that interest you to see pay, education level, and program connections. Then save or download your results for Mile Marker #6.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> You can retake the assessment anytime. Your interests can shift as you learn more about yourself.

What to do with your results

Results are a starting point, not a verdict. A few ways to use them well:

Notice what fits. Does your top type sound like you? Do the matches feel right, surprising, or completely off? Your reaction is information too.

Notice what doesn't. If your top match is something you have zero interest in, don't throw out the whole profile. Look at the traits underneath the job title.

Connect to programs. Use the OCTC program links in your results to find one or two programs worth exploring. You don't have to commit. Look for what's worth learning more about.

Write down your questions. Good results raise questions. What does this program actually require? What's the difference between the diploma and the AAS? Those questions are for your Success Coach.

Using AI to go deeper on your results

AI Literacy BE Responsible BE Reflective

AI can be a useful thinking partner for exploring what your results mean, with one big limit: it doesn't know OCTC's programs, current requirements, or your situation. Use it to think, not to decide.

- **Understanding your profile:** "My top interest types are Social, Conventional, and Artistic. What work environments and career directions tend to fit this mix?"
- **Exploring a match:** "What does a typical day look like for a [career from your results]? What skills does it usually take?"

- **Finding advisor questions:** "Based on my interest in [program or career area], what are five specific questions I should ask my academic advisor before registering for next semester?"
- **Thinking through fit:** "Help me think through whether [career area] might fit someone who [a short description of your interests and working style]."

Keep it general: don't share your student ID, birth date, or other personal identifying details. And anything AI says about specific courses, sequences, or requirements needs to be checked with your Success Coach or the KCTCS catalog (https://catalog.kctcs.edu/). Use AI to think, and use your advisor to decide.
Think of your results as a mirror more than a map: a reflection of what interests you right now, at this point in your life. That's useful even if it raises more questions than it answers.

Bring your results to the next lesson, Programs & Pathways at OCTC, where you'll connect them to your real options.

LESSON 6.3

Programs & Pathways at OCTC

How credentials stack, and how your results connect to real programs.

Picking a program means choosing a credential, a timeline, and a direction, along with a subject you like.

Those choices shape what you take, when you can finish, and where you can go next. Most students never get a clear explanation of how this works before they register for their first class. This lesson fixes that: how credentials stack at OCTC, how your Career Coach results connect to programs, and what to bring to your Success Coach.

How credentials stack

At OCTC, many credentials are designed to build on each other. Courses are packaged into certificates, certificates can stack into diplomas, and diplomas can stack into degrees. Transfer degrees lead to four-year universities. You don't always have to start at the bottom, and you don't have to stop at the top.

> KEY TERM
>
> **Stackable credential:** a credential whose courses also count toward the next, bigger credential.

How credentials build on each other

1. CoursesIndividual classes, packaged into credentials
2. CertificateA focused set of courses around one skill area. The shortest path to a credential.
3. DiplomaDeeper than a certificate, often technical or career-focused
4. AAS degree Associate in Applied ScienceThe full career-ready degree for technical and professional programs

Or take a different path:

1. AA or AS degree Associate in Arts or Associate in ScienceDesigned to transfer to a four-year university

Certificate, diploma, AAS: toward the workforceAA, AS: toward a four-year university

What each credential means

Credit hours and length vary by program, so check the specific program in the KCTCS catalog (https://catalog.kctcs.edu/).

Certificate

- The fastest path to a specific skill or entry-level credential
- Often stackable: the credits count toward a diploma or AAS
- Good for getting into the workforce quickly or adding a skill
- Some can be finished in a semester or two

Diploma

- More in-depth preparation than a certificate
- Common in technical and health programs
- Credits often apply toward an AAS if you keep going
- Usually about one to two years of full-time study

AAS degree

- The full career-ready credential for technical and professional programs
- Usually about two years of full-time study
- Includes general education courses alongside your major courses
- Some programs have transfer agreements. Ask your Success Coach.

AA or AS degree

- Designed to transfer to Kentucky's four-year universities
- Associate in Arts (AA) for humanities, social sciences, and similar fields
- Associate in Science (AS) for science and math fields
- Built to count toward a bachelor's degree, protecting the work you've already done

An AAS isn't a dead end. It's designed for the workforce, and many AAS graduates go on to a four-year university by taking additional general education courses, and some universities have agreements with KCTCS colleges that make the path clearer. If you might want a bachelor's degree someday, ask your Success Coach about transfer options before you assume it isn't possible.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> In a technical program, ask your advisor: "Does this certificate stack toward a diploma or AAS?" You may be closer to the next credential than you think, and able to earn something with job value before you finish.

Connecting your results to programs

Use your interest types as a starting point for which program areas might fit. Think of it as a direction finder, not a definitive list. Program offerings change, so look up what OCTC currently offers in the OCTC Program Finder (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/education-training/program-finder/index.aspx). Each program's page has a Job Outlook section that shows where that program can lead.

If your top types include	Program areas worth exploring
Social (S)	Education, early childhood, human services, health care, nursing, medical assisting
Investigative (I)	Medical laboratory work, science transfer pathways, engineering technology, health information
Artistic (A)	Digital media, design, communication, liberal arts transfer pathways
Enterprising (E)	Business, management, marketing, entrepreneurship
Realistic (R)	Welding, automotive, advanced manufacturing, HVAC, construction
Conventional (C)	Accounting, office systems, information technology, business

> **LOOK BACK AT**
> Lesson 6.2: remember, the combination of your types matters more than any single one.

What to bring to your Success Coach

Your Success Coach is your academic GPS. Registration for next semester comes up fast, and the most valuable thing you can do before that appointment is arrive with something specific to talk about.

Your Career Coach results: your interest types and top matches. Your coach can help you read them in light of OCTC's actual programs.

One or two programs you want to know more about. This is a starting point, not a final decision.

Specific questions. "What should I take?" versus "I'm interested in nursing. What do I need to finish this semester to stay on track for the next application deadline?" is the difference between a routine appointment and a useful one.

Mile Marker #6 asks you to write those questions. Don't wait until you're sitting across from your advisor to figure out what you need to know.

> **LOOK BACK AT**
>
> Not sure who your Success Coach is? Lesson 2.2 shows how to find out.

You don't need everything figured out before you talk to your Success Coach. You do need enough self-knowledge and enough specific questions to make the conversation useful.

The next lesson, Build a Simple Academic Plan, helps you think about sequence and timeline before that appointment.

LESSON 6.4

Build a Simple Academic Plan

A map, not a rigid schedule.

Think of an academic plan as a map, not a rigid schedule: a rough picture of where you're headed and what needs to happen, in what order, to get there.

Having one, even a simple, imperfect one, means you walk into your Success Coach appointment with something to react to instead of nothing to start from. This lesson helps you plan strategically, so you're choosing courses that move you toward something, not only classes that fit your schedule.

> **A plan that changes is still better than no plan, because it gives you something to revise.**

Think like a strategist, not just a scheduler

Most students treat registration like a puzzle: find classes that don't overlap with work and family. That's necessary, but strategic planning asks a few more questions before you open the schedule.

1 Know what has to happen first

Most programs have **prerequisites**, courses you must finish before you can take the next one. In some programs, getting the order wrong costs a whole semester. In others, missing an application or entrance exam deadline can push your start back a full year.

- **Math prerequisites** are the most common bottleneck. Many health, science, and business programs need college-level math before you can move ahead. Find out what math your program requires, and when.
- **Application deadlines** exist for competitive programs, like many health programs. Missing one can mean waiting a year to start.
- **Entrance exams.** Some programs require an entrance exam that takes time to prepare for and schedule. Nursing programs, for example, often use one. Find out now, not after two semesters of prerequisites.

KEY TERM

Prerequisite: a course you must finish before you're allowed to take another course.

PATHFINDER TIP

Ask your Success Coach: "Are there any deadlines, entrance exams, or application windows I need to know about for this program?" That one question can save you a semester or more.

2 Be realistic about your load

Full-time is usually 12 credit hours a semester, but 12 isn't right for everyone. Students who work full time, care for family, or are coming back after time away often find that a lighter load done well serves them better than a full load done poorly.

- **A rough rule:** for every credit hour, expect 2 to 3 hours of work outside class each week. A 12-credit load can mean 24 to 36 hours of studying on top of class time.
- **Your first semesters are for learning how college works** for you: what your time really looks like and how demanding your courses are. Starting lighter and doing well is a stronger foundation than overloading and struggling.
- **Part-time is a real option.** It takes longer, but finishing at your own pace beats not finishing at all.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> Financial aid often requires a minimum number of credit hours. Before you choose a lighter semester, check with Financial Aid about what keeps your aid in place.

> **LOOK BACK AT**
> Your time log from Module 3 shows how many hours you really have.

3 Look more than one semester ahead

You don't need a perfect multi-year plan. But looking past next semester, even roughly, shows whether you're on track, whether your prerequisites will be done in time, and whether your finish date is realistic.

The Academic Planner gives you room for next semester and two more. Start with next semester. Looking ahead, even imperfectly, is what matters.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> Not every course is offered every semester. Some are offered only once a year. Missing one can delay you significantly, so ask your advisor which courses have limited offerings.

4 Keep it flexible

Life happens and programs change. You might discover you dislike something you thought you'd love, or love something you didn't expect. A good plan absorbs change without falling apart.

- General education courses often count toward several programs. Taking them early protects you if you change direction.

- A certificate in one area doesn't lock you out of another program. Stackable credentials let you pivot without starting over.
- Review your plan with your advisor every semester, not only once.

What strategic planning looks like

The same thinking plays out differently depending on where you're headed.

Interested in nursing

Nursing programs typically have a competitive application with a deadline, prerequisite courses in areas like anatomy and math, and often an entrance exam.

Strategic move: Find out the application timeline now and work backward to plan your prerequisites.

Planning to transfer

Transfer works best when you know your likely university and major, since schools differ in what they accept for a given major.

Strategic move: Name one or two universities you're considering, and ask your advisor which courses fit their requirements.

Exploring a technical program

Many technical programs, like welding, HVAC, and automotive, offer certificates that stack into diplomas and AAS degrees.

Strategic move: Map the full credential ladder so you earn something meaningful at each step, not just at the end.

Still deciding

You're not stuck. General education courses like English, math, and social sciences are required in almost every program and transfer widely.

Strategic move: Start with general education while you explore. It builds a foundation that works wherever you land.

Questions to bring to your Success Coach

Mile Marker #6 asks you to write five of your own, in priority order. These examples get you started. Yours should fit your actual program interest and situation.

What are the prerequisites for [program], and are any of them offered only in certain semesters?

For [program], are there application deadlines, entrance exams, or competitive admission steps I need to know about now?

Based on my plan, what's a realistic timeline for finishing my credential?

Which courses could I take early that count toward more than one program, in case I change direction?

If I might transfer someday, what should I be doing differently now?

What credit load do you recommend for my situation, and how does it affect my financial aid?

Try it: the Academic Planner

Sketch your next semester and two more, note what to know before you plan, and write your questions. It adds up your credit hours as you go. Print it or save it as a PDF to bring to your appointment.

Open the Academic Planner

Using AI to explore your plan

AI Literacy BE Responsible BE Reflective

AI can help you think through planning questions, but it doesn't know OCTC's programs, current prerequisites, course schedules, or deadlines.

- **Finding questions:** "I'm interested in a health program at a community college. What should I ask my advisor about prerequisites and application timelines?"
- **Weighing a decision:** "Help me think through the pros and cons of starting with a certificate versus going straight for an AAS in [field]."
- **Understanding ideas:** "What does it mean for credits to transfer? What should I ask to make sure mine will?"

- **A rough first draft:** "What kinds of courses are usually required in the first year of [general field]?" Then compare it with OCTC's actual program requirements.

Keep personal identifying details out of it. And check every specific requirement, sequence, and deadline with your Success Coach or the KCTCS catalog (https://catalog.kctcs.edu/). When the AI's answer doesn't match, notice that. AI gives you a way to think, and your advisor gives you the facts.
You don't need a perfect plan before you talk to your Success Coach. You need enough of one to have a real conversation, where you're reacting to something specific instead of starting from zero.

Your planner, your Career Coach results, and your questions are that starting point, so bring them.

TRAIL TIP

Wait… How Is My Grade Actually Calculated?

Most students don't know. Now you will.

At some point, you're going to check your grade and feel confused because the number doesn't match what you expected.

You'll wonder what's being counted, how much each assignment matters, and whether you can still turn things around. This Trail Tip answers those questions before you need them. There are two things to understand: how your grade works inside a single class, and how that grade feeds into your overall GPA. Both are simpler than they look, once someone explains them.

How your grade works in a class

Most courses use one of two grading approaches. Knowing which one your instructor uses changes how you think about every assignment.

Points-based grading

Every assignment is worth a set number of points. Your grade is your total earned points divided by the total possible points.

Assignment	Earned	Possible
Reflection 1	4	4
Reflection 2	3	4
Discussion	1	1
Quick check	0.5	1
Total	8.5	10

8.5 ÷ 10 = **85%, a B**

Weighted grading

Different categories of work count for different percentages of your grade. How you do in each category matters more than the points on any single assignment.

Category	Weight	Your score	Counts as
Exams	50%	78%	39.0
Assignments	30%	92%	27.6
Participation	20%	85%	17.0
	Final grade		83.6%

39.0 + 27.6 + 17.0 = **83.6%, a B**

In weighted grading, a strong exam score matters more than a perfect homework record.

Which one does your course use?

Check each course's syllabus. It tells you whether the course is points-based or weighted, and how the work breaks down. Your syllabus is the contract for the course, so it's the place to look first, including for this one.

DON'T FALL INTO THIS TRAP

It's easy to look at a small assignment and think, "That's basically nothing." But small assignments add up. A handful of low-point activities can make up a real share of your final grade, and skipping them is one of the most common ways a B turns into a C. There are no throwaway assignments.

How your class grade feeds your GPA

Your GPA, or grade point average, summarizes your academic performance across all your courses, and it's simple math once you see how it works.

KEY TERM

Quality points: a course's grade points multiplied by its credit hours.

1 Know the grade scale

Letter grades convert to grade points on a 4.0 scale.

- A4.0
- B3.0
- C2.0
- D1.0
- E0.0

At KCTCS colleges, the failing grade is an **E**, not an F. That's because F has its own job: it's used only in pass-fail courses, where you earn either a P (pass) or an F (fail). In a regular graded course, an E earns no credit and 0 grade points, and it still counts in your GPA.

A D isn't always enough. A D earns credit at KCTCS, but some courses require a C or better to pass or to count toward your program. FYE 100 is one of them: you need at least a C to pass. Check each syllabus, and ask your Success Coach which courses in your program have a C-or-better rule.

> **GOOD TO KNOW**
>
> You may see other grades on your record. A **W** (withdrawal), **I** (incomplete), or **P** (pass in a pass-fail course) doesn't count in your GPA. See the KCTCS catalog (https://catalog.kctcs.edu/academic-services/academic-policies-rules/) for the full list.

2 Weigh each grade by its credit hours

Each course counts toward your GPA based on its credit hours. A 4-credit course has more impact than a 1-credit course, even if you earn the same grade in both. Multiply each course's grade points by its credit hours to get its quality points. Then divide the total quality points by the total credit hours.

Course	Credits	Grade	Grade points	Quality points
ENG 101	3	A	4.0	12.0
MAT 150	3	B	3.0	9.0
BIO 112	4	C	2.0	8.0
FYE 100	1	A	4.0	4.0
Totals	11			33.0

GPA = 33 ÷ 11 = **3.0**

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
>
> Credit hours matter as much as grades. A C in a 4-credit course pulls your GPA down more than a C in a 1-credit course. When you're deciding where to put your study time, heavier courses deserve more of it.

> **LOOK BACK AT**
>
> Lesson 5.1: Quantitative Reasoning. This is that skill, applied to your grades.

Try it

Work each problem on your own first, on paper or in your head. Then open the answer to check yourself.

Problem 1: Points-based

You've earned 76 out of 100 possible points in a course so far. What's your grade percentage, and what letter grade is that?

▶ Show the answer

Problem 2: GPA

You take HIS 101 (3 credits) and earn a B, PSY 110 (3 credits) and earn an A, and MAT 110 (4 credits) and earn a C. What's your GPA?

▶ Show the answer

Problem 3: Weighted

A course weights exams at 60% and assignments at 40%. You score 70% on exams and 95% on assignments. What's your final grade?

▶ Show the answer

Problem 4: What if?

You have a 2.5 GPA after 20 credit hours. Next semester you take 12 credits and earn straight A's. Why does a higher-credit semester have more impact on your GPA than a lighter one?

▶ Show the answer

You don't have to wait until midterm to find out where you stand. Check your grades in Blackboard, read each syllabus, and do the math. If the numbers don't make sense, ask your instructor, who can walk you through it.

MILE MARKER

Mile Marker #6: My Academic Plan

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

Not a final decision. A starting point for the conversation with your Success Coach.

You don't have to have everything figured out. Four things are enough to walk into an advising appointment and have a real conversation: what your interest results told you, one direction worth exploring, what you need to ask, and what your next semester could realistically look like.

What you'll do

1. **Before you start,** take the Career Coach assessment, and sketch your next semester in the Academic Planner.
   - Lesson 6.2: Take the Career Coach assessment (your results, for Question 1)
   - Academic Planner (your next semester, for Question 4)
2. **Answer four questions** in the form below.
3. **Save as PDF** and upload it to the **Mile Marker #6** assignment in Blackboard.

●○ AI use: AI-supported

You may use AI as a thinking partner to explore your ideas. Work with what it gives you, then write your responses in your own voice. Keep personal identifying details, like your student ID or birth date, out of it. AI doesn't know OCTC's programs, prerequisites, schedules, or deadlines, so check anything it tells you about requirements with your Success Coach or the KCTCS catalog. See the AI Course Policy in the syllabus and Lesson 1.4: AI use labels.

Optional prompt to try: "Based on my interest in [program or career area], what are five specific questions I should ask my academic advisor before registering for next semester?" Use what's useful. Your final responses must be in your own words.

Your Mile Marker

Type your answers in the boxes. Your typing is saved in this browser as you go, so you can come back later on the same device. Nothing is sent anywhere until you upload it.

Your name (required) | **Date**

QUESTION 1

Your Interest Results

Look at your Career Coach results (or the O*NET Interest Profiler).

To get you thinking (no separate answer needed)

- What did the results suggest about the kind of work, or the people, you might thrive with?

> **A STRONG ANSWER**
>
> Names your **top interest types**, says honestly **whether they fit you**, and connects your results to **at least one career direction**.

1. Name your top two or three interest types, and say whether they feel accurate.

---

2. Name one career match that surprised you, confirmed something, or made you curious.

Look back at: Lesson 6.2: The six interest types; What to do with your results

QUESTION 2

One Direction Worth Exploring

Based on your results and your own instincts, choose one program or pathway at OCTC to learn more about.

> **A STRONG ANSWER**
>
> Names **one real OCTC program**, explains why that **credential type** fits your goals and how it differs from the other options, and is honest about **what you still need to find out**.

1. Name one OCTC program you want to know more about, and why.

---

2. Choose the credential that fits your goals right now.

Circle one: Certificate / Diploma / AAS (career degree) / AA or AS (transfer degree) / Not sure yet

3. Explain why that credential fits, and how it differs from the other options.

4. Name one thing you still need to find out about it.

Look back at: Lesson 6.3: What each credential means; Connecting your results to programs

QUESTION 3

Your Questions for Your Success Coach

Write five specific questions to bring to your advising appointment, most important first. Make them about your situation, your program interest, and your timeline. Include at least one about transfer, financial aid, or the order of your courses.

> **A STRONG ANSWER**
>
> Lists **five real, specific questions** in **priority order**, with at least one about transfer, financial aid, or course order.

1. Your most important question

2. Your second question

3. Your third question

4. Your fourth question

5. Your fifth question

Look back at: Lesson 6.4: Questions to bring to your Success Coach

QUESTION 4

Your Next Semester

Sketch a realistic course load. It's a draft, and your Success Coach will help you finalize it.

A STRONG ANSWER

Names **specific courses** and an **approximate credit load**, explains why it's **realistic for your life**, and mentions one thing about **prerequisites or course order**.

1. List the courses you're thinking about, and about how many credit hours that would be.

2. Explain why that load is realistic with your work, family, and other commitments.

3. Name one thing you learned about prerequisites or course order.

Look back at: Lesson 6.4: Think like a strategist; Academic Planner

Submit it

Upload your PDF to the **Mile Marker #6** assignment in Blackboard. Check Blackboard for the due date.

In an in-person class? Your instructor may give you a printed copy. Fill it in by hand, then upload a photo or scan.

Optional: attach your Academic Planner too. That's your choice.

How it's scored: full credit means every prompt is answered, and each answer is about you, with at least one real detail. See How Mile Markers are scored.

WRAP UP

Module 6 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

You've reached the end of Module 6. These are the ideas to carry forward.

Key takeaways

Knowledge Application turns "I know that" into "I did something with it." Connecting what you know about yourself to real academic decisions is the skill.

Your interest results are a mirror, not a map. Look at your mix of interest types, not just the top one, and use it to find programs worth exploring.

Credentials stack. Certificates can build into diplomas and AAS degrees. AA and AS degrees are built to transfer. Knowing the difference shapes your path.

Plan like a strategist. Prerequisites, application deadlines, limited course offerings, and a realistic load matter as much as a schedule that fits.

Specific questions make better appointments. Bring your results, a direction, and your questions to your Success Coach.

Know how your grades work. Check each syllabus for points-based or weighted grading, and remember that credit hours weigh your GPA.

Use AI to think, your advisor to decide. Keep personal details out, and check every requirement with your Success Coach or the catalog.

REFLECT

What's the one question you most need answered before you register, and who will you ask?

That's Module 6.

Head back to your course in Blackboard for this module's activities.

MODULE 7

Knowing Your Strengths & Values

Not what you're doing. Who you are, and what you bring to everything you do.

10 ESSENTIAL SKILLS IN THIS MODULE

#5 Adaptability & Leadership

#9 Knowledge Application

Why this matters

You've spent the last several modules building awareness of your time, your money, and your academic direction. This module turns the focus inward, from what you're doing to who you are.

Your strengths and values shape how you learn, how you work with others, what drains you, and what energizes you. Understanding them is one of the most useful things you can do for the rest of this semester, and beyond.



Merit reminder: Merit Activity #2 is due with this module

Find an activity, then submit your reflection to the Merit Activity #2 submission portal in Blackboard. Check Blackboard for the due date. The Merit Guide has your options, what proof to include, and how to write your reflection.

What you'll be able to do

By the end of this module:

A

I can identify my Top 5 HIGH5 strengths and explain what they mean for how I learn and work.

B

I can identify my Top 5 personal values and describe how they shape my decisions and priorities.

C

I can connect my strengths and values to my academic habits, career direction, and how I work with others.

D

I can recognize one blind spot that comes with my strengths and describe what to watch for.

AI Literacy: BE behaviors in this module

- BE Reflective

Lessons in this module

Trail Tool: My Values Snapshot

Your Top 5 values, why they matter, and where they show up.

Trail Tool: My HIGH5 Results

Your baseline before HIGH5, your Top 5 after, and what lined up.

7.1 Skill Spotlight: Adaptability & Leadership

Not a title. How you show up, especially when things change.

7.2 Why Your Personal Values Matter

Interests tell you what you enjoy. Values tell you who you are.

7.3 What Are Strengths, and Why Do They Matter?

Not just what you're good at. What feels like you at your best.

Mile Marker: Mile Marker #7: My Strengths Snapshot

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

Wrap Up: Module 7 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

TRAIL TOOL

My Values Snapshot

Your Top 5 values, why they matter, and where they show up.

Your Top 5 values, why they made the cut, and where they show up (or don't) in how you actually live right now.

Do the Values Card Sort first, then fill this in. There are no right answers. Honest beats impressive.

Go to the Values Card Sort (https://www.valuescardsort.com/)

> **LOOK AHEAD**
>
> Lesson 7.2: The Values Card Sort walks you through it.

Fill in your snapshot

Your answers save in this browser as you go. Select **Save as PDF** to keep a copy. Use it for this module's journal (online sections) or class discussion (in-person sections), and bring it to Mile Marker #7 and Module 8.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
>
> Nothing here is sent anywhere. It stays on this device until you choose to share it.

Your name (required)

Date

STEP 1

My Top 5 values, and why each one made the cut

Be personal and specific. Not "family is important," but why it's important to you right now.

1

Value 1

Why it's in my top five

2

Value 2

Why it's in my top five

3

Value 3

Why it's in my top five

4

Value 4

Why it's in my top five

5

Value 5

Why it's in my top five

STEP 2

Where my values show up

One place my actions match my values

One place there's a gap between my values and my choices

What do my five have in common? (optional)

TRAIL TOOL

My HIGH5 Results

Your baseline before HIGH5, your Top 5 after, and what lined up.

What you think your strengths are, what HIGH5 says they are, and what lines up.

Fill in Step 1 before you take the assessment. Then take HIGH5 and come back for Steps 2 and 3. There are no right answers. Your instincts about yourself are information too.

Go to HIGH5 (https://high5test.com/)

> **LOOK AHEAD**
> Lesson 7.3: Take the HIGH5 assessment walks you through it.

Fill in your results

Your answers save in this browser as you go. Select **Save as PDF** to keep a copy. Use it for Mile Marker #7, and bring it to Module 8 and your STAR(T) Stories.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> Nothing here is sent anywhere. It stays on this device until you choose to share it.

Your name (required) **Date**

STEP 1

Before you take HIGH5: my baseline

A sentence or two for each is enough. Go with what comes to mind first.

What do people often compliment me on, even things that feel so natural I barely notice them?

What tasks feel easier for me than they seem to be for others?

When do I feel most like myself: most energized, most engaged?

What activities make time disappear?

My guess: the strengths I think will show up

STEP 2

After HIGH5: my Top 5, exactly as reported

Copy them in order, with the same spelling and capitalization. Do this before you close the HIGH5 page.

1

Strength 1

2

Strength 2

3

Strength 3

4

Strength 4

5

Strength 5

STEP 3

Compare

What matched my guess

What surprised me, or felt off

One result I want to understand better (optional)

LESSON 7.1

Skill Spotlight: Adaptability & Leadership

Not a title. How you show up, especially when things change.



10 Essential Skills · #5

Adaptability & Leadership

What this skill is

Leadership has less to do with a title than with how you show up, especially when things change.

Adaptability & Leadership sounds like it belongs to people with corner offices and formal authority, but at the level this course focuses on, it's something much more immediate: contributing to a shared goal, adjusting when circumstances shift, and helping others stay on track when things get hard.

You probably already do versions of all three. This module helps you see where and how.

> **Leadership is a pattern of behavior more than a position, and you've been practicing it longer than you think.**

Where you're headed

Below, in plain terms, is the difference between where most students start and where you're headed.

SEE ALSO

Lesson 1.2 explains Benchmark, Milestone, and Capstone.

Benchmark Where you're starting

- You can describe how people cooperate to reach a common goal.
- You can explain how new situations may require doing things differently.
- You recognize how people motivate others to reach a goal.

Milestone

YOUR TARGET

- You contribute toward reaching a common goal.
- You adjust to new situations by doing things differently and keeping a positive mindset.
- You encourage others to keep going toward their goals as situations change.

The shift from Benchmark to Milestone is the shift from understanding how these things work to actually doing them, in real situations, with real people, under real pressure.

What leadership actually looks like

Most students hear "leadership" and think of student government, team captains, or supervisors. The Milestone level doesn't require any of that. What it asks for is showing up: contributing, adjusting, and encouraging, in whatever setting you're already in.

What people assume it means

- Being in charge of a group
- Having a title or formal role
- Being the loudest or most confident person
- Making all the decisions
- Never struggling or needing help

What it actually looks like

- Showing up consistently and following through
- Adjusting your approach when something isn't working
- Helping a teammate who's stuck, without being asked
- Staying steady when a plan falls apart
- Contributing your strengths to something shared

Where it shows up in this module

This module's self-assessment work connects directly to Adaptability & Leadership, which is why it's the featured skill here.

Strengths: how you adapt

Your strengths say a lot about how you naturally respond to change and challenge. A student who leads through relationships adapts differently than one who leads through analysis. Neither is wrong, but knowing which one you are helps you use it on purpose instead of stumbling into it.

Values: why you lead

Your values are the reason you show up for things, the "why" behind your choices and commitments. When circumstances change and motivation gets harder, values are what anchor you. They're also what makes your leadership real rather than a performance.

Blind spots: where to watch

Every strength has an overuse pattern, and an overused strength can get in the way of adapting. The student who leads through decisiveness may struggle to adjust when the first plan fails. Naming your blind spot is the first step to managing it when things get hard.

Self-knowledge: better leadership

It's hard to lead others well if you don't understand yourself. The HIGH5 assessment and the Values Card Sort are leadership groundwork as well as personal reflection, and what you learn about yourself applies directly to how you show up for others.

In your own life

REFLECT

Think of a time, this semester or before college, when something changed unexpectedly and you had to find a different approach. What did you do? What does that tell you about how you adapt?

Is there someone in your life, at work, at home, or in a group, whom you quietly help stay on track or keep going? That's leadership. What strengths make you that person for them?

When things get hard, what do you fall back on? A value, a habit, a person? Watch for where that anchor shows up in your results in this module.

How it shows up later

Adaptability & Leadership is one of the three assigned skills for your STAR(T) Stories at the end of the course. You'll write or record one story about a specific time you adapted, contributed, or helped others keep going through change.

The self-knowledge you build in this module is the foundation of that story. It doesn't have to be dramatic. A moment when you kept going when you wanted to quit, and your persistence helped someone else keep going too, is a Milestone-level story. Start small and honest, and start noticing those moments now. The STAR(T) Stories Guide at the back of this book walks you through the whole capstone, with a practice guide for each story.

Skill definition and Milestone indicators are based on the Kentucky Council on Postsecondary Education's Kentucky Graduate Profile (https://cpe.ky.gov/ourwork/kygradprofile.html).

LESSON 7.2

Why Your Personal Values Matter

Interests tell you what you enjoy. Values tell you who you are.

We make decisions every day, some big, some small. But most of us rarely stop to ask why we choose what we choose.

Behind every real decision sits something deeper than preference or convenience: your personal values. Values are the principles and beliefs that guide how you live, often without your noticing. They shape what you prioritize, what you say yes or no to, how you react under pressure, and the people and places you're drawn to.

When your actions line up with your values, life tends to feel more meaningful and less stressful. When they don't, something feels off, even if you can't name exactly why.

> **Interests tell you what you enjoy. Values tell you who you are.**

What values actually shape

Your values are working in the background of almost every important choice you make. They show up most clearly in these places.

Your priorities

What you actually spend time and energy on. Not what you say matters, but what you act like matters.

Your boundaries

What you'll say no to, even when it's inconvenient or disappoints someone.

Your goals

What you're working toward, and whether those goals feel like yours or borrowed from someone else.

Your reactions

Why some situations energize you and others drain you. Often it comes down to whether your values are being honored.

Your relationships

Who you're drawn to and who you clash with. Shared or clashing values explain a lot of both.

Your career fit

Whether a job or field feels sustainable over time, which often has as much to do with values as with interest.

Interests and values aren't the same thing

Many career tools, like the interest assessment you took in Module 6, focus on interests: what you enjoy, what you're curious about, what keeps you engaged. Interests matter, but they're only part of the picture.

LOOK BACK AT

Lesson 6.2: The six interest types

Interests

- What you enjoy or find engaging right now
- Can shift as you try new things and meet new people
- Often shaped by what you've been exposed to so far
- May not carry you when the work gets hard
- Useful for exploring directions

Values

- What matters to you at a deeper level
- Tend to stay steadier across time and situations
- Often show up under pressure, when choices get hard
- Give meaning even when the work isn't exciting
- A more reliable compass for long-term decisions

What the research says

Research on values at work finds that when people's work fits their personal values, they tend to be more satisfied and more committed to it. Researchers also find that interests and values are related but measure different things. You can be very interested in something that clashes with your values, or committed to work that isn't exciting but feels deeply meaningful.

Sources: Schwartz (1992); Sagiv & Schwartz (1995); Dobson et al. (2014); Arieli, Sagiv, & Roccas (2020).

If your interests keep shifting

Some people move easily between interests, drawn to many subjects, fields, and activities over time. If that's you, following your interests from one thing to the next can feel exciting but directionless. Each interest feels real in the moment, but "What do I actually want to do?" stays unanswered.

For people like this, values are often the more useful compass. They connect the dots between pursuits that look unrelated. Someone who values *creativity, connection, and impact* might find those values showing up in education, health care, design, or community work: very different fields, with the same underlying why.

If your interests feel too varied to point anywhere, ask yourself: what do the things I keep coming back to have in common? The answer is usually a value, not an interest.

Values can shift too, and that's normal

Values tend to be steadier than interests, but they aren't fixed forever. What mattered most to you at 16 may look different at 20, 30, or 40. Big life experiences can clarify or shift what you prioritize. That's growth, not inconsistency.

Looking at your values now gives you a clearer picture of who is actually showing up to college today, rather than who you were or who you think you should be.

The Values Card Sort

The Values Card Sort helps you find your Top 5 core values, not by answering questions about yourself, but by choosing between values that all feel important. The sorting and narrowing is where the real reflection happens.

1. **Sort the cards**

   Place each of 30 value cards into one of three piles: most important to you, somewhat important, and least important. Go with your gut.

2. **Narrow to five**

   Keep narrowing until you have the five values that matter most to you right now. This is the hard part, and it's supposed to be.

3. **Save your results**

   Save your Top 5 as a PDF or write them down before you close the page. You'll use them in the My Values Snapshot and in this module's journal or class discussion.

PATHFINDER TIP

When two values feel equally important and you have to pick one, the one you keep coming back to is usually the more central value. Trust the pull, not the logic.

Do the Values Card Sort

Free, no account needed, and the site doesn't store your choices. Your instructor may also do a card sort in class.

Go to the Values Card Sort (https://www.valuescardsort.com/)

How to use your results

Notice what's there

Read each of your Top 5 and sit with it. Does it feel accurate? Does it surprise you? The values that were hardest to choose, or felt uncomfortable to claim, are often the most revealing.

Look for the pattern

Do your five cluster around a theme, like connection, achievement, freedom, or service? The pattern often says more than any single value about what drives you.

Notice the gaps

Is there a part of your life, like school, work, or relationships, where your values aren't being honored? That gap is often the source of a low-level dissatisfaction that's hard to name.

Connect to decisions

Think about a recent choice: a program, a job, a relationship. Does it line up with your values? If it does, it probably feels right even when it's hard. If it doesn't, that friction has a name now.

Try it: My Values Snapshot

Record your Top 5, why each one made the cut, one place your actions match your values, and one place there's a gap. Save it as a PDF and use it for this module's journal or class discussion.

Open My Values Snapshot

Knowing your values won't mean you have everything figured out, but it gives you a more honest picture of what matters to you right now, in this season of your life.

That picture helps with the decisions ahead: which direction to explore, what kind of work might fit, and what you want college to be about. Your values will come up again in Mile Marker #7, in your career exploration in Module 8, and in your STAR(T) Stories.

LESSON 7.3

What Are Strengths, and Why Do They Matter?

Not just what you're good at. What feels like you at your best.

Most of us were taught to focus on what we're not good at: fix the weaknesses, fill the gaps, bring everything up to average.

Strengths-based thinking flips that. Instead of asking "What's wrong with me?" it asks "What's already working, and how do I use more of it?"

Strengths are the patterns of thinking, behaving, and interacting that come naturally to you. They feel energizing rather than draining, and they show up again and again in different situations. They're expressions of who you are, not only skills you've built.

> **Strengths work is about using what already works, not fixing what doesn't.**

What strengths look like in real life

Strengths aren't always obvious, especially to the person who has them. What feels easy to you often looks remarkable to someone else. Day to day, strengths can look like this:

- Staying calm when things go wrong
- Coming up with ideas quickly
- Helping others understand hard things
- Turning chaos into a workable plan
- Motivating people who are stuck
- Noticing details others miss
- Building trust quickly with strangers
- Asking questions that open things up
- Following through when others give up

Everyone has strengths, even if you haven't named them yet. The HIGH5 assessment gives you words for what's already there.

Before you take it: a quick baseline

Before you see your results, take two minutes to think about what you already know. Your instincts about yourself are information too, and comparing them with your results is often the most interesting part.

REFLECT

What do people often compliment you on, even things that feel so natural you barely notice them?

What tasks feel easier for you than they seem to be for others?

When do you feel most like yourself: most energized, most engaged?

What activities make time disappear?

Try it: My HIGH5 Results

Write down your baseline before you take HIGH5. Afterward, come back to add your Top 5 and compare them with your guess. Save it as a PDF and use it for Mile Marker #7.

Open My HIGH5 Results

Take the HIGH5 Strengths Assessment

HIGH5 is a free strengths assessment. You'll respond to 120 short statements, which takes about 15 to 20 minutes, with no time limit. Your Top 5 strengths are free. You don't need to buy the full report.

Answer honestly, not how you think you should. The results are only as useful as your answers are true. There are no right or wrong results.

If it asks you to sign up, use your KCTCS email so you can find your results again.

Save your Top 5 in My HIGH5 Results, or take a screenshot, before you close the page. You'll need them, exactly as reported, for Mile Marker #7.

Take the HIGH5 assessment

Find your Top 5 strengths. Your results feed into Mile Marker #7.

Go to HIGH5 (https://high5test.com/)

What your results actually mean

Your Top 5 strengths describe patterns, not boxes, and they don't lock you into a personality type. Think of them as a starting point for understanding how you naturally operate. They're most useful in four places.

LOOK BACK AT

Lesson 7.1: Where Adaptability & Leadership shows up

Learning

Knowing your strengths helps you choose study strategies that work with how you think, not against it.

A Thinker needs processing time before a discussion. A Deliverer thrives with clear checklists and deadlines. An Empathizer often learns best alongside other people.

Working with others

Your strengths shape how you collaborate, communicate, and show up in groups.

A Coach is often the natural encourager in group work. A Catalyst pushes projects forward, sometimes faster than others can follow. A Thinker brings insight but may pull back when overwhelmed.

Career direction

Strengths give you clues about the settings and roles where you'll feel most alive, not just competent. You don't need to choose a major today. Notice what already fits.

Empathizers are often drawn to helping professions, health care, advising, and education. Analysts to data, research, and problem-solving. Catalysts to leading and coordinating.

Adapting to change

This module's skill, Adaptability & Leadership, is closely tied to strengths. Knowing how you naturally respond to change lets you use that on purpose instead of just reacting.

Under pressure, a Deliverer tends to get to work. An Optimist tends to reframe. Neither is wrong, but knowing which you are changes how you lead yourself and others.

Every strength has a blind spot

Strengths are real and valuable, and every one of them has an overuse pattern. That's the nature of any real tendency: taken too far, or used in the wrong setting, even your best qualities can work against you.

KEY TERM

Blind spot: the overuse side of a strength, which is easy for you to miss and often easy for others to see.

- ### Deliverer

  May take on too much and burn out, or frustrate others by moving faster than they're ready.

- ### Analyst

  May overthink decisions or get stuck researching when it's time to act.

- ### Empathizer

  May struggle with boundaries or take on other people's stress.

- ### Catalyst

  May move faster than others can follow, or start things without finishing them.

- ### Thinker

  May pull back when overwhelmed, or get lost in ideas and miss the deadline.

- ### Optimist

  May avoid hard conversations or underestimate real risks.

A blind spot is the shadow side of a real strength. Knowing yours lets you manage it instead of letting it manage you. The most useful move is simple: decide ahead of time what you'll do when you notice it showing up.

PATHFINDER TIP

The blind spot question in Mile Marker #7 asks you to be honest, not hard on yourself. "I know I do this, and here's what it looks like" is a strength in itself.

Using AI to understand your results

AI Literacy BE Reflective

AI can explain what a strength usually means and suggest ways to use it. What it can't do is tell you whether that description actually fits you. Only you can check it against your real life.

- **Plain language:** "Explain the HIGH5 strength Strategist in simple, everyday words."
- **Putting it to work:** "What are three study habits that fit someone whose top strengths include Deliverer and Empathizer?"

- **Blind spots:** "What does it look like when someone overuses the Catalyst strength, and what can they do about it?"

You can share your strength names. Leave out your name and other personal details. Then ask yourself: does this sound like me? Where does it miss?
By the end of this lesson and the HIGH5 assessment, you'll have a clearer picture of what you naturally bring to your learning, your relationships, and the direction you're heading. Mile Marker #7 asks you to put that picture into your own words.

Your strengths have been working for you all along. Now you get to name them.

MILE MARKER

Mile Marker #7: My Strengths Snapshot

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

Who you are at your best, and what that means for where you're headed.

This Mile Marker asks you to do something with your HIGH5 and Values Card Sort results: reflect on what they mean for how you learn, how you work with others, and where you might be headed. There are no good or bad strengths, only honest reflection.

What you'll do

1. **Before you start,** take both assessments. The rest of this Mile Marker uses your results.
   - Lesson 7.3: Take HIGH5 (your Top 5, saved in My HIGH5 Results)
   - Lesson 7.2: The Values Card Sort (your values, saved in My Values Snapshot)
2. **Answer six questions** in the form below.
3. **Save as PDF** and upload it to the **Mile Marker #7** assignment in Blackboard.

●○ AI use: AI-supported

You may use AI as a thinking partner to explore your results. Work with what it gives you, then write your responses in your own voice. You can share your strength names, but not your name, where you live, or other personal details. AI doesn't know you. You do. See the AI Course Policy in the syllabus and Lesson 1.4: AI use labels.

Optional prompt to try: "Help me understand my HIGH5 strengths for a college reflection. My Top 5 strengths are: [paste your list]. Explain each one in everyday language, then ask me questions, one at a time, about where I have seen them in my own life." Use what's useful. Your final responses must be in your own words.

Your Mile Marker

Type your answers in the boxes. Your typing is saved in this browser as you go, so you can come back later on the same device. Nothing is sent anywhere until you upload it.

Your name (required)

Date

QUESTION 1

Your Top 5 HIGH5 Strengths

List them exactly as the assessment reports them, spelling and capitalization included.

> **A STRONG ANSWER**
>
> Lists **all five**, **in order**, **exactly as reported**.

1. List your Top 5 strengths, in order.

Look back at: My HIGH5 Results (your Top 5)

QUESTION 2

Accuracy Reflection

What do your results say about how you think, feel, or work?

To get you thinking (no separate answer needed)

- In your own everyday words, what does each strength mean for how you think and work?
- Which result do you want to understand better?

> **A STRONG ANSWER**
>
> Explains your strengths in **plain language**, names the one that **fits best and why**, and is honest about **what surprised you**.

1. Name the strength that feels most accurate, and explain why it fits.

---

2. Describe one result that surprised you or felt off, and what you make of it.

Look back at: What your results actually mean; My HIGH5 Results (your baseline)

QUESTION 3

Strengths in Action: Academics

Be concrete: not "study more," but how your particular strengths change how you approach studying, class, or assignments.

A STRONG ANSWER

Names **three concrete ways**, each tied to a **specific strength**, and describes how **one strength shows up with others**.

1. Describe three specific ways your strengths can support your learning this semester, each tied to a strength.

2. Pick one strength, and describe how it shows up when you work with classmates or on a team.

Look back at: Lesson 4.2: Study strategies that work

QUESTION 4

Strengths and Values in Action: Career Direction

How might your strengths and values connect to a future field, role, or work environment?

A STRONG ANSWER

Names **one or two work environments** that fit your strengths and connects **at least one of your values** to the direction you're exploring.

1. Name one or two work environments, roles, or fields where your strengths would be a natural fit.

2. Explain how one of your top values connects to the direction you're exploring.

Look back at: My Values Snapshot (your values); Mile Marker #6: the direction you named

QUESTION 5

One Blind Spot Worth Watching

Every strength has an overuse pattern, something that works against you when it goes too far. Be honest, not hard on yourself.

A STRONG ANSWER

Names **one real blind spot**, describes **what it looks like in your life**, and gives **one strategy** for managing it.

1. Name one blind spot connected to your strengths, and what it looks like when it shows up.

2. Name one situation to watch for this semester, and what you'll do when you notice it.

Look back at: Lesson 7.3: Every strength has a blind spot

QUESTION 6

Strengths-Based Goal

A STRONG ANSWER

Is **specific**, **names a strength**, and describes something you could **actually do** in the next few weeks.

1. Complete this sentence: "One way I will use my strengths in the next few weeks is..."

Submit it

Upload your PDF to the **Mile Marker #7** assignment in Blackboard. Check Blackboard for the due date.

In an in-person class? Your instructor may give you a printed copy. Fill it in by hand, then upload a photo or scan.

How it's scored: full credit means every prompt is answered, and each answer is about you, with at least one real detail. See How Mile Markers are scored.

WRAP UP

Module 7 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

You've reached the end of Module 7. These are the ideas to carry forward.

Key takeaways

Leadership is a pattern, not a position. Contributing, adjusting, and encouraging others through change is Adaptability & Leadership at the Milestone level.

Values tell you who you are. Interests can shift. Values tend to stay steadier and make a more reliable compass for big decisions.

Notice the matches and the gaps. Where your choices line up with your values, things feel right even when they're hard. Where they don't, that friction has a name.

Strengths are what already works. Use them on purpose in how you study, how you work with others, and the direction you explore.

Every strength has a blind spot. Name yours and decide ahead of time what you'll do when it shows up.

AI can describe a strength. Only you can say if it fits. Check what it tells you against your real life.

REFLECT

Which one of your strengths or values do you most want to use on purpose in the next few weeks, and where?

That's Module 7.

Head back to your course in Blackboard for this module's activities, including your Merit activity.

MODULE 8

Explore Your Career Options

Not the career you're supposed to want. The one that actually fits who you are.

10 ESSENTIAL SKILLS IN THIS MODULE


#1 Communication


#2 Critical & Creative Thinking


#6 Professionalism


#10 Information Literacy

Why this matters

A good career fit takes more than choosing something that "sounds cool" or "pays well." It means finding work that lines up with who you are, what you value, what you're good at, and how you actually want to live.

In this module you'll use real research tools to explore one career in depth, and honestly assess whether it fits. You'll also set up your Handshake profile and get ready to register for next semester.

What you'll be able to do

By the end of this module:

A

I can research one career using Career Coach and O*NET, including regional salary, job outlook, education requirements, and typical work environment.

B

I can evaluate a career for personal fit by connecting my research findings to my strengths, values, work style, and pressure tolerance.

C

I can articulate one clear question I still have about this career direction.

AI Literacy: BE behaviors in this module

- BE Critical
- BE Responsible

Lessons in this module

Trail Tool: Career Research Guide

One career, researched well, and an honest look at the fit.

8.1 Skill Spotlight: Communication

Showing up in the conversation as someone worth listening to.

8.2 Research Your Career

What fits, what doesn't, and how to find out.

Trail Tip: Set Up Your Handshake Profile

Your professional home base, starting now.

Trail Tip: Register Early for Next Semester

Early gets the classes you need. Late gets what's left.

Mile Marker: Mile Marker #8: My Career Snapshot

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

Wrap Up: Module 8 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

TRAIL TOOL

Career Research Guide

One career, researched well, and an honest look at the fit.

One career, researched well. Then an honest look at whether it fits you.

Work through the five sections in order. The first three are research: what the job is, what the numbers say, and what the work is really like. The last two are where it gets personal. When you're done, save it as a PDF and upload it with Mile Marker #8.

> **LOOK AHEAD**
> Lesson 8.2: Research Your Career shows you how to use Career Coach and O*NET for each section.

Fill in your research

Your answers save in this browser as you go. Select **Save as PDF** when you're finished, then upload the PDF to the Mile Marker #8 assignment in Blackboard.

Research sources

- Career Coach (https://owensboro.lightcastcc.com/): regional salary, job outlook, and OCTC programs
- O*NET OnLine (https://www.onetonline.org/): tasks, skills, work styles, and work context
- OCTC Program Finder (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/education-training/program-finder/index.aspx): the Job Outlook section on each OCTC program page
- Occupational Outlook Handbook (https://www.bls.gov/ooh/): national pay and outlook
- Job postings on Handshake, Indeed, or Glassdoor: what employers are actually asking for

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> In an in-person class? Your instructor may give you a printed copy of the Mile Marker #8 handout, which includes this guide. Fill it in by hand, then upload a photo or scan.

Your name (required) _____ **Date** _____

SECTION 1

The basics

Be specific. "Health care" isn't a career. "Registered Nurse" is.

Job title

Industry or field

Education and training required. Which program at OCTC, or elsewhere, gets you there?

Specific skills needed: technical skills, software, certifications, or licenses

Sources I used

SECTION 2

The numbers

Use Career Coach for regional numbers and the Occupational Outlook Handbook for national ones.

Salary range in our region

National median salary

Job outlook

Circle one: Growing / Stable / Declining

What's driving the outlook? (For example: technology, an aging population, policy, automation)

SECTION 3

The reality of the work

This is what most career research skips: what the work actually looks and feels like day to day.

Typical work environment. Office, outdoors, clinical, remote, school, warehouse, lab, traveling?

Typical schedule and hours (days, nights, weekends, on call, flexible?)

Dress code (scrubs, uniform, business casual, casual?)

People load

Circle one: Mostly solo work / Small team or colleagues / Heavy public, patient, or client contact / Varies

Pace and pressure

Circle one: High pressure, fast-paced / Steady and predictable / Highly variable

Physical demands. Sitting, on your feet, lifting, driving, traveling?

SECTION 4

The fit analysis

Connect what you found to what you know about yourself from Modules 3, 6, and 7.

Strengths: where do your HIGH5 strengths show up in the demands of this career? Be specific. Don't just list your strengths.

Values: where my values are honored

Values: where there may be friction

Work environment: how does the setting fit how you work best?

Pressure: how does this career's pace and pressure compare with how much pressure you handle well?

Academic path: how does the education this career requires connect to the direction you explored in Module 6?

Life management: how do the schedule, pace, and physical demands fit how you manage your time and energy now?

Overall fit

Circle one: Strong fit / Mostly fits, with some friction / Mixed, needs more exploration / Probably not right for me

SECTION 5

Your honest assessment

Why this career pulls you. Mile Marker #8, Question 3 asks for the rest: one alignment, one friction, and the question you still have.

Three reasons this career interests you. Go deeper than "it pays well." Reason 1

Reason 2

Reason 3

BEFORE YOU WRITE

Synthesis

In two or three sentences: what do you know now that you didn't before, and what does it change about how you're thinking about your direction?

LESSON 8.1

Skill Spotlight: Communication

Showing up in the conversation as someone worth listening to.



10 Essential Skills · #1

Communication

What this skill is

Communication means more than talking or writing. It means showing up in the conversation as someone worth listening to.

Communication shows up everywhere, but most people don't think about it until something goes wrong. A missed appointment because you didn't follow up. An instructor who didn't know you were struggling until it was too late. An advising session that felt generic because you didn't come with real questions. The conversations in this module, with your Success Coach, your instructors, and people in careers you're curious about, call for Milestone-level Communication: showing up as an active participant, not waiting to be told what to do.

> **Benchmark communication gets you by. Milestone communication gets you what you need.**

Where you're headed

Below, in plain terms, is the difference between where most students start and where you're headed.

> **SEE ALSO**
>
> Lesson 1.2 explains Benchmark, Milestone, and Capstone.

Benchmark Where you're starting

- You ask questions to clarify your understanding.
- You express thoughts and ideas in writing.
- You share information in one-on-one and small-group conversations.

Milestone

YOUR TARGET

- You give focused attention, ask clarifying questions, and notice nonverbal signals.
- You write formally and informally with logical structure, complete sentences, standard grammar, and correct punctuation.
- You take part in formal conversations with peers and professionals by offering information and ideas.

The shift from Benchmark to Milestone is the shift from reacting to engaging: from answering when asked to showing up with something to contribute.

The three Milestone behaviors, up close

1 Listen with focus, and ask clarifying questions

Listening at the Milestone level is active. It means giving your full attention, not half-listening while you wait for your turn, noticing what's communicated beyond the words, and asking questions that show you processed what you heard.

A basic question checks a box: "When is the deadline?" A clarifying question shows real engagement: "I want to make sure I understand. Does the prerequisite need to be done before I apply to the program, or just before I start it?"

In an advising appointment, instead of nodding and hoping you understood, ask: "So just to confirm, if I take this course in the spring, I'm still on track to start the program in the fall?"

2 Write with structure and care

Professional writing should be clear, organized, and respectful of the reader's time, without being stiff. At the Milestone level, you adjust to the situation: a text to a classmate looks different from an email to an instructor, which looks different from a message to an employer.

Where this breaks down most often for college students is email. A one-line message with no greeting, no context, and no clear ask puts the work on the reader. An email that introduces you, explains your situation, and asks a clear question gets a faster, more useful reply.

"hey when is the test" is Benchmark. The email example below is Milestone.

3 Come to professional conversations with something to offer

This is the behavior most students underestimate. You don't need a script. You need to show up as a participant rather than a recipient: you bring your research, your questions, your thinking, and your goals.

A student who says "I don't know what I want to take" is at Benchmark. A student who arrives with a draft schedule, two specific questions about course order, and a sense of their program direction is at Milestone, and gets a completely different kind of appointment.

The same goes for career conversations and any time you talk with someone in a professional role. Come with something. Leave with something.

Where it shows up in this module

This module puts you in the situations where the gap between Benchmark and Milestone is easiest to see.

Your advising appointment

Benchmark: You show up and wait to be told what to take.

Milestone: You bring your Academic Planner, your Career Coach results, and specific questions about course order, prerequisites, or program requirements. You offer your thinking and refine it with your coach.

A check-in with an instructor

Benchmark: You avoid the conversation and hope things improve.

Milestone: You send a clear, professional email that names the concern, says what you've tried, and asks a clear question. You make it easy for your instructor to help.

Career conversations

Benchmark: You ask "What do you do?" and listen.

Milestone: You ask questions based on your research: about the day-to-day reality, the career path, what surprised them about the field. You share your own thinking and leave with something concrete.

Group work

Benchmark: You wait to be given a role and do your part.

Milestone: You offer your strengths, notice when someone is struggling, ask clarifying questions about the task, and speak up when something isn't working, before it becomes a problem.

What a Milestone email looks like

Email is one of the most common ways you'll communicate professionally in college. Below is a Milestone-level email for a real situation.

> Example: a check-in email to an instructor
> **To:** Professor [Last Name]
> **Subject:** Question about my progress in [Course Name]
>
> Good afternoon, Professor [Last Name],
>
> My name is [First Name], and I'm in your [Course Name] class, section [number]. I'm writing because I'm concerned about my scores on the last two assignments and want to make sure I'm on track to finish the course well.
>
> I've reviewed your feedback, and I think I'm struggling most with [specific area]. I tried [something specific you did], which helped a little, but I'm still not confident I understand [specific concept].
>
> Would you have time for a short meeting or office hours this week? I want to understand what to do differently before the next assignment.
>
> Thank you for your time.
>
> [First and Last Name]
> [Course and section]

What makes it Milestone: it introduces the student, states the situation specifically, names what they've already tried, asks a clear question, and sounds professional without being stiff. It makes it easy for the instructor to say yes.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> Before you send any professional email, read it once as the person receiving it. Does it give them enough context to help? Is the ask clear? Would you want to answer it? If not, revise before you send.

In your own life

REFLECT

Think of a conversation that went better because you came prepared. What did you bring to it?

Is there an email or conversation you've been putting off? What would a clear, specific version of it sound like?

When someone explains something important to you, what helps you really listen, and what pulls your attention away?

How it shows up later

Communication is the skill underneath every other skill in this course. You need it to speak up for yourself in advising, to ask for help before it's too late, to present yourself to employers, and to tell your STAR(T) Stories in a way that's clear, specific, and worth listening to.

Every conversation, email, and appointment in this module is practice, so you're doing Communication, not only learning about it.

Skill definition and Milestone indicators are based on the Kentucky Council on Postsecondary Education's Kentucky Graduate Profile (https://cpe.ky.gov/ourwork/kygradprofile.html).

LESSON 8.2

Research Your Career

What fits, what doesn't, and how to find out.

A good career fit takes more than choosing something that "sounds cool" or "pays well."

It means finding work that lines up with who you are: your values, strengths, interests, and how you actually want to live. In this lesson you'll use Career Coach and O*NET to explore options, then choose one career to research in depth with the Career Research Guide.

What career fit actually means

Career fit happens when several parts of your life line up with what a career actually asks of you. You've already gathered most of this in earlier modules, and now you'll put it to work.

> KEY TERM
>
> **Career fit:** how well a career's real demands match who you are and how you want to live.

Interests

What you naturally enjoy doing or learning about.

Module 6: your interest results

Strengths

What comes naturally: the patterns that energize you rather than drain you.

Module 7: your HIGH5 strengths

Values

What matters most to you in work: stability, creativity, impact, independence, balance.

Module 7: your Values Snapshot

Work environment

Fast or steady? Hands-on or thinking-based? Independent or on a team? Remote or in person?

Research Guide, Section 3

Life management

Schedule, pace, physical demands, how much time with people. Does the daily reality fit how you manage your time and energy?

Module 3: your time and energy

Education fit

What credential are you willing and able to pursue, and does the path match your academic direction?

Module 6: your Academic Planner

Myth-buster

You don't need to pick a career today. Many students start college without a set career, and plenty of people who do have one change direction along the way. This module is about exploring possibilities, not locking in a lifetime decision. Think less "What job am I going to do forever?" and more "What direction do I want to explore next?"

Think in directions, not job titles

Instead of hunting for the one perfect job, start with a career cluster: a group of related roles that share similar settings, skills, and values. A cluster gives you options and room to change course.

- Health care
- Business and finance
- IT and technology
- Human services
- Skilled trades
- Education
- Arts and design
- Public safety

- Engineering and STEM
- Manufacturing

You don't need to choose the job yet, just a direction worth exploring. The tools below help you narrow it from there.

Before you research: start with the life you want

Most career conversations start with "What do you want to do?" A better starting place: what kind of life do you want to build? Financial security, time with people you love, creative work, community impact, where you live, what your mornings look like. The career is the tool. The life is the point.

IN YOUR COURSE

The AI Chat with Coach Pathfinder in Blackboard, "What Future Do You Want Your Career to Make Possible?", is a short conversation about exactly this question.

REFLECT

What matters most to me in a career: helping others, creativity, job security, flexibility, leadership, steady hours, teamwork?

What kind of work setting fits me best: fast-paced, quiet, collaborative, hands-on, structured, flexible?

Are there fields I've always been curious about, even if I've never said so out loud?

What's one deal-breaker for me: rotating night shifts, high-pressure sales, sitting all day, working alone?

Your two research tools

Use both, because they give you different information that fits together.

Career Coach: start here

OCTC's Career Coach uses regional labor market data and connects careers directly to OCTC programs and local job postings.

- Regional salary ranges
- Job outlook: growing, stable, or declining
- Education and credentials
- Skills and typical tasks
- Related OCTC programs
- Local job postings

Go to Career Coach (https://owensboro.lightcastcc.com/)

O*NET OnLine: go deeper

O*NET OnLine, from the U.S. Department of Labor, describes nearly every occupation in detail at the national level. Use it to go deeper than Career Coach and to double-check what you found.

- Detailed tasks and work activities
- Knowledge, skills, and abilities
- Work context: setting, pace, schedule, people contact
- Work styles and work values
- National wages and outlook
- Related occupations

Go to O*NET OnLine (https://www.onetonline.org/)

Not the same as the Interest Profiler. In Module 6 you may have used the O*NET Interest Profiler, which asks what might interest you. O*NET OnLine answers a different question: what is this specific job actually like?

PATHFINDER TIP

Use Career Coach for the local picture: pay, outlook, OCTC programs. Use O*NET for what the work actually requires day to day. For national numbers, the Occupational Outlook Handbook (https://www.bls.gov/ooh/) is another good source. To see the job outlook for a specific OCTC program, check the Job Outlook section on its page in the OCTC Program Finder (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/education-training/program-finder/index.aspx).

How to research, step by step

1. ### Go back to your Career Coach results

   You took the interest assessment in Module 6. Log back in to see your matches. If you want a fresh look, you can retake it anytime.

2. ### Look through your top matches

   Open several that catch your attention, including ones that surprise you. For each, check the regional pay, job outlook, education needed, skills, typical tasks, and connected OCTC programs. Which ones feel like a natural fit? Which spark real curiosity?

3. ### Choose one career to research in depth

   Pick the one that interests you most, not the one that sounds most impressive. It can be the direction you named in Mile Marker #6, or something new.

4. ### Look it up in O*NET OnLine

   Search for the job title. Read the Tasks, Work Context, and Work Styles sections to see what the day-to-day really looks like. Note anything that matches or clashes with what Career Coach showed you.

5. ### Fill in the Career Research Guide

   Record what you found, then work through the fit analysis. Save it as a PDF. It goes with your Mile Marker #8 submission.

> **LOOK BACK AT**
> Mile Marker #6: the direction you named

Open the Career Research Guide

Five sections, from the basics to your honest assessment. It saves as you go and prints as a PDF for Mile Marker #8.

Open the Career Research Guide

Using AI in career research

AI Literacy BE Critical BE Responsible

AI can help you think about a career, but it's a poor source for facts about one. Its pay and outlook numbers may be out of date, national rather than regional, or simply wrong.

- **Good uses:** "What questions should I ask someone who works as a [career]?" or "What are the hardest parts of working as a [career] that people don't talk about?"
- **Poor uses:** asking AI for the salary, outlook, or education requirements and copying the answer into your guide.

Get your numbers and requirements from Career Coach, O*NET, and the Occupational Outlook Handbook. If AI tells you something that doesn't match, trust the source and notice the difference.
Research first, then decide what it means for you. The Career Research Guide is where you gather the facts, and Mile Marker #8 is where you make sense of them.

TRAIL TIP

Set Up Your Handshake Profile

Your professional home base, starting now.

Handshake is your professional home base while you're in college.

It's the career platform OCTC uses to connect students with local and regional employers: part-time and full-time jobs, internships, career fairs, and hiring events. Most students don't set it up until they're actively job hunting. The ones who set it up early, and actually look around, have a head start when that moment comes.

Set up your profile

Sign in with your KCTCS username and password. You don't need a separate account.

Sign in to Handshake

OCTC's Handshake site, using your KCTCS credentials.

Go to Handshake (https://octc.joinhandshake.com/login)

1. **Open your profile**

   After you sign in, find your profile from the menu.

2. **Fill in the essentials**

   Add your major or program and your education information, including your expected graduation date.

3. **Add your interests**

   Choose the job types, locations, and career areas you're interested in. Handshake uses these to shape what it shows you. The career you researched in this module is a good place to start.

4. **Add a short bio and a photo**

   Both are recommended. A sentence or two about what you're studying and what you're looking for is plenty. A clear, friendly photo taken with your phone works fine and makes your profile feel real to employers.

5. **Copy your profile link**

   On your profile page, copy the web address from your browser. You'll submit it in Blackboard.

PATHFINDER TIP

Before you submit, paste your link into a new browser tab to make sure it opens your profile.

Worth exploring once you're set up

Once your profile is done, Handshake has more to offer. None of this is required, but all of it is worth knowing about.

Jobs and internships

- Filter by part-time, full-time, internship, or on-campus
- Look for roles that don't require experience
- Save jobs to come back to later
- Set up job alerts for fields you're curious about

Your resume

- Upload a resume if you have one
- Don't have one yet? OCTC Career Services (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/current-students/experiential-learning-center/index.aspx) offers resume and interview help
- Having it in Handshake makes applying faster

Employers and industries

- Follow companies and fields you're curious about
- Your feed changes based on what you follow
- See what local employers are actually hiring for

Events

- Career fairs and employer information sessions
- Resume and career workshops
- Networking events

Follow a few employers in the field you researched in this module and see what they're hiring for. That's real-world career knowledge, and it takes five minutes.

TRAIL TIP

Register Early for Next Semester

Early gets the classes you need. Late gets what's left.

Students who register early get the classes they need. Students who wait get what's left.

Classes fill faster than most first-year students expect, especially general education courses and courses your program requires. You've explored careers and built an academic plan. Now it's time to act on it.

Know when registration opens

Registration for the next semester opens well before the current one ends. Look up the date on the OCTC academic calendar and put it in your calendar now, with a reminder a week ahead.

OCTC academic calendar

Registration dates, deadlines, holidays, and the start and end of each semester.

See the academic calendar (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/education-training/academic-calendar/index.aspx)

Meet with your Success Coach first

Your Success Coach is your best resource for a schedule that works for your program and your life. Book an appointment well before registration opens, not the week of. Together you can:

- Finalize your academic plan and confirm your program requirements
- Choose the right courses for next semester, in the right order
- Look at summer options if you want to get ahead
- Build a schedule that fits your goals, your commitments, and your life

LOOK BACK AT

Lesson 2.2: how to find your Success Coach

Bring these with you

- Your Academic Planner
- Your five questions from Mile Marker #6
- Your Career Coach results and your Career Research Guide
- Your work and family schedule for next semester

Lookout: Ask Your Success Coach



Your coach can help after you register, too. If something changes once classes start, such as a new work schedule, talk with your coach **before** you drop or withdraw from a course.

Sometimes a shorter bi-term course can replace the hours you lose. Your coach can help you understand how any change affects your plan and your financial aid.

Not sure who your coach is? Lesson 2.2 shows you how to find them.

Why early matters

- You get the classes you need before they fill up.
- You avoid waitlists and last-minute scrambling.

- You stay on track toward finishing your credential.
- You head into the break, and the next semester, with less to worry about.

Your future self will thank you for doing this now.

MILE MARKER

Mile Marker #8: My Career Snapshot

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

One career. Honest research. Your real assessment of the fit.

You've done the research. This Mile Marker asks you to make sense of it: not repeat it, but honestly assess what you found and what it means for you.

It's also how the college assesses Professionalism (#6), one of the course's focus skills. That doesn't mean it needs to sound polished. It needs to sound like you, and be specific and honest.

What you'll do

1. **Part 1: The Career Research.** Complete the Career Research Guide. You'll upload it with your answers, and a submission without it is incomplete.
   - Career Research Guide (Part 1: all five sections and the synthesis, saved as a PDF)
2. **Part 2: The Questions.** Answer three questions in the form below.
3. **Save as PDF** and upload it to the **Mile Marker #8** assignment in Blackboard.

●○ AI use: AI-supported

You may use AI as a thinking partner to question your assumptions about a career. Get your facts from your research sources, not from AI: salary, outlook, and education requirements come from Career Coach, O*NET, and the Occupational Outlook Handbook. Leave your name and other personal details out of the prompt. See the AI Course Policy in the syllabus and Lesson 1.4: AI use labels.

Optional prompt to try: "I'm a college student exploring a career as a [career]. My top strengths include [two or three strengths], and I value [two or three values]. Ask me three hard questions that would help me test whether this career really fits me. Don't answer them for me." Use what's useful. Your final responses must be in your own words.

Part 2: The Questions

Type your answers in the boxes. Your typing is saved in this browser as you go, so you can come back later on the same device. Nothing is sent anywhere until you upload it.

Your name (required) **Date**

QUESTION 1

What Did You Find?

Keep it brief. The guide has the detail. This is the headline version.

> **A STRONG ANSWER**
>
> Covers **all four**: education, regional salary, outlook, and work environment, **in your own words**.

1. Name the career you researched.

2. Summarize it in your own words: education required, regional salary, job outlook, and typical work environment.

Look back at: Your guide, Sections 1 to 3

QUESTION 2

Does It Fit?

Connect your research to what you know about yourself from Modules 6 and 7.

> **A STRONG ANSWER**
>
> Connects **specific research findings** to your **strengths**, your **values**, **how you work best**, and your **pressure tolerance**. Not just a list of your results.

1. Where do your strengths show up in this career?

2. Where are your values honored, and where is there friction?

3. How does the work setting fit how you work best?

4. How does the career's pace and pressure compare with how much pressure you handle well?

5. How does the day-to-day reality fit your life?

Look back at: Your guide, Section 4; Mile Marker #7 and your Values Snapshot

QUESTION 3

What's Your Honest Take?

A STRONG ANSWER

Names **one alignment** and **one friction**, asks **one specific question**, and names a **person or resource** that could help answer it.

1. Name one clear area of alignment.

2. Name one area of friction or uncertainty.

3. Name the one question you still need answered before you could commit more seriously to this direction.

4. Name who or what could help you answer it.

Look back at: Your guide, Section 4 and the Synthesis

Submit it

Upload your PDF to the **Mile Marker #8** assignment in Blackboard. Check Blackboard for the due date.

In an in-person class? Your instructor may give you a printed copy. Fill it in by hand, then upload a photo or scan.

Upload your Career Research Guide in the same assignment. Both parts are needed for full credit.

How it's scored: full credit means every prompt is answered, and each answer is about you, with at least one real detail. See How Mile Markers are scored.

WRAP UP

Module 8 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

You've reached the end of Module 8. These are the ideas to carry forward.

Key takeaways

Come with something. Leave with something. Milestone Communication means listening closely, writing clearly, and bringing your own thinking to professional conversations.

Career fit has many parts. Interests, strengths, values, work environment, life management, and education all count, not just pay or how a job sounds.

Start with the life you want. The career is the tool. The life is the point.

Use the right tool for the job. Career Coach for the local picture, O*NET OnLine for what the work actually involves.

Honest beats impressive. Naming friction and open questions is part of a good fit analysis, not a sign you chose wrong.

Get your facts from sources, not AI. Use AI to question your thinking. Check every number against your research.

Register early. Meet with your Success Coach and register as soon as your registration window opens.

REFLECT

Who is one person you could talk to about the career you researched, and what's the first question you'd ask them?

That's Module 8.

Head back to your course in Blackboard for this module's activities.

MODULE 9

Think It Through — Critical Thinking + STAR(T) Introduction

The 4C Check, your thinking patterns, and your first STAR(T) draft.

10 ESSENTIAL SKILLS IN THIS MODULE


#1 Communication


#2 Critical & Creative Thinking


#9 Knowledge Application

Why this matters

This module is about thinking on purpose: noticing the assumptions and thought traps that get in your way, and using a simple tool, the 4C Check, to think more clearly.

The second half connects straight to your capstone. You'll write your first STAR(T) draft and use the same 4C Check to make it clearer, more honest, and more specific.

What you'll be able to do

By the end of this module:

A

I can identify one thinking habit that sometimes gets in my way and name a strategy for interrupting it.

B

I can apply the 4C Check (Clarity, Context, Credibility, Consequences) to evaluate a real situation or decision.

C

I can explain the STAR(T) framework and describe how each of the five steps works.

D

I can draft one practice STAR(T) response using a real experience and apply the 4C Check to strengthen it.

AI Literacy: BE behaviors in this module

- BE Critical
- BE Reflective

Lessons in this module

Trail Tool: 4C Check

Walk through any decision, one C at a time.

9.1 Skill Spotlight: Critical & Creative Thinking

Pausing on purpose before you react, decide, or assume.

9.2 What Is Critical Thinking, Really?

It's not overthinking. It's thinking with intention.

9.3 Spotting Assumptions, Biases & Thought Traps

Everyone falls into these patterns. The trick is noticing them.

9.4 The 4C Check: A Simple Tool for Better Decisions

Pause, get clear, and choose wisely.

9.5 Think It Through: Using Critical Thinking to Build Your STAR(T) Story

The thinking behind a good decision also makes a story worth telling.

Mile Marker: Mile Marker #9: Think It Through

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

Wrap Up: Module 9 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

TRAIL TOOL

4C Check

Walk through any decision, one C at a time.

Stuck on a decision? Walk through it one C at a time.

Use this for anything: a class, a job, a message you're not sure how to send, something AI told you. Fill in what you can. You don't have to use every box every time.

> **LOOK AHEAD**
> Lesson 9.4: The 4C Check explains each C with examples.

Work through your decision

Your answers save in this browser as you go. Select **Save as PDF** to keep a copy. Use **Clear my answers** to start a new decision.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> Nothing here is sent anywhere. It stays on this device.

Your name (required)

Date

The decision or situation

C1Clarity: What am I really deciding?

What feelings or quick assumptions are clouding this?

The exact question I'm deciding

C2Context: What matters most here?

My priorities, values, and limits

How might someone else see this?

C3Credibility: What do I know, and what am I assuming?

What I know for sure

What I'm assuming or have only heard

What I need to check, and where

C4Consequences: What might happen next?

Option 1, and what's likely to happen

Option 2, and what's likely to happen

My next step

LESSON 9.1

Skill Spotlight: Critical & Creative Thinking

Pausing on purpose before you react, decide, or assume.



10 Essential Skills · #2

Critical & Creative Thinking

What this skill is

Critical thinking means pausing on purpose before you react, decide, or assume. It has nothing to do with overthinking or arguing.

You make dozens of decisions every day, some small, some major. Much of the stress that comes with them is really confusion: not being sure what's actually going on, what matters most, or what's even true.

This module gives you a simple way to slow down, just for a moment, and think more clearly. That habit helps with more than schoolwork. It's the same thinking that builds an honest, specific STAR(T) story, and it's exactly the kind of thinking employers look for.

> **Benchmark thinking reacts. Milestone thinking pauses, checks, and decides.**

Where you're headed

Below, in plain terms, is the difference between where most students start and where you're headed.

SEE ALSO

Lesson 1.2 explains Benchmark, Milestone, and Capstone.

Benchmark Where you're starting

- You describe a problem in general terms, based on whatever information you happen to have.
- You acknowledge your own perspective, but don't always notice how it's shaping your thinking.
- You come up with possible solutions, even if they're only loosely connected to the real problem.

Milestone

YOUR TARGET

- You figure out what's really going on by finding and using relevant information, not just what's easiest to find.
- You seek out and consider other perspectives, not just your own first reaction.
- You name the patterns, relationships, and context that matter, and use them to reach a clear, informed conclusion.

The shift from Benchmark to Milestone is the shift from reacting to checking: from going with your first read of a situation to actually examining it before you decide.

The three Milestone behaviors, up close

1 Figure out what's really going on

At the Milestone level, you don't react to the first version of a problem you see. You pause long enough to ask, "What's actually happening here, and what do I need to know before I respond?"

This is the difference between assuming and checking. An assumption is something you treat as true without checking it. Milestone thinking notices the assumption and asks whether it's actually true, or just the first thing that came to mind.

Instead of "This assignment makes no sense," ask: "What is the professor actually asking me to do, and where can I check?"

2 Look for other perspectives

Your first take on a situation is shaped by your experiences, your mood, and your assumptions, and it isn't always the full picture. Milestone thinking means considering how someone else might see the same situation, especially before you decide something is "obviously" true.

The goal is to catch the moments when your read might be incomplete and ask what you might be missing, not to doubt yourself constantly.

Instead of assuming a coworker is ignoring you, ask: "Could they be busy or distracted? What else could explain this?"

3 Name what matters, and why

This is where critical thinking becomes a tool you can use. It means being able to name the real question, what matters most in the situation, which information is solid and which is shaky, and what's likely to happen

depending on what you choose. That's exactly what the 4C Check walks you through, and it's the same thinking that turns a vague STAR(T) story into one that's specific, honest, and worth telling.

"If I drop this class, what does that actually mean for my financial aid, my schedule next semester, and when I finish?" That's thinking through consequences, not guessing.

Where it shows up

Everyday decisions

Benchmark: You go with your gut and move on.

Milestone: You notice the thinking trap, ask what's actually true, and consider what matters most before deciding.

News and social media

Benchmark: If it sounds right, you accept it.

Milestone: You ask: Is this source credible? Is this fact, an ad, or someone's opinion?

Your STAR(T) story

Benchmark: You pick an experience because it sounds impressive and write something generic.

Milestone: You use the 4C Check to make sure your story is clear, accurate, and shows what you want it to show.

Using AI tools

Benchmark: Whatever AI gives you feels like an answer.

Milestone: You pause, check it against what you know, and decide whether it's useful before you use it.

In your own life

REFLECT

Think of a time you reacted fast and later wished you'd paused. What would one good question have changed?

Who in your life sees situations very differently than you do? What could you learn from how they'd read a problem?

What's one decision in front of you right now that deserves a slower, more careful look?

How it shows up later

Critical thinking is a habit you build with practice, not a personality trait. You don't have to feel like "a critical thinker" for this to work. You only have to practice the pause: stop, ask one good question, then decide.

It's one of the most consistently valued skills in any job, any relationship, and any decision you'll face. It's also a strong choice for the fourth skill in your STAR(T) Stories.

Skill definition and Milestone indicators are based on the Kentucky Council on Postsecondary Education's Kentucky Graduate Profile (https://cpe.ky.gov/ourwork/kygradprofile.html).

LESSON 9.2

What Is Critical Thinking, Really?

It's not overthinking. It's thinking with intention.

Critical thinking doesn't require being "smart," complicated, or argumentative.

It's the simple skill of pausing long enough to ask better questions **before** you react, decide, or assume something is true. It helps you make better decisions, avoid costly mistakes, stay calm instead of jumping to conclusions, understand instructions, evaluate information (especially online), solve problems with more confidence, and communicate more clearly.

> **Critical thinking is thinking on purpose.**

What it is, and isn't

Critical thinking means you

- **Slow down** long enough to consider what's really going on
- **Ask questions** instead of assuming
- **Look for evidence** instead of guessing
- **Make choices** based on clarity, not impulse or pressure

Critical thinking is not

- Overthinking
- Being negative
- Criticizing others
- Arguing for the sake of arguing
- Trying to "sound smart"
- Doing everything alone

It's intentional, not automatic: simply pausing to think clearly before you act.

Four habits of strong thinkers

These habits are small, but they're powerful. You don't need all of them all the time. Noticing even one in the moment can change how a situation plays out.

1. Curiosity

They ask, "What do I need to know?" or "What am I missing?"

2. Clarity

They make sure they understand the instructions, situation, or problem before moving forward.

3. Checking

They double-check sources, facts, and assumptions instead of taking the first answer at face value.

4. Calm decisions

They don't rush. They think it through, even when there's pressure to decide fast.

What it looks like in real life

Critical thinking shows up everywhere, not only in school. These examples show what happens when someone pauses long enough to ask a better question.

At school

Instead of "This assignment makes no sense," you ask: **"What is the professor actually asking me to do?"**

At work

Instead of assuming a coworker is ignoring you, you ask: **"Could they just be busy or distracted?"**

In your personal life

Instead of reacting right away to a text, you pause and ask: **"What's the most helpful way to respond?"**

In big decisions

Instead of choosing a major because "everyone else is," you ask: **"How does this fit my strengths, values, and goals?"**

You don't have to feel like "a critical thinker" for this to work. It's a habit, not a personality trait, and habits get stronger with practice.

The next lesson, Spotting Assumptions, Biases & Thought Traps, looks at what gets in the way of clear thinking.

> **LOOK BACK AT**
>
> Lesson 7.2: your values are a big part of "what matters to me."

LESSON 9.3

Spotting Assumptions, Biases & Thought Traps

Everyone falls into these patterns. The trick is noticing them.

You can't think clearly if you don't notice what's messing with your thinking.

Critical thinking also means noticing the invisible forces that shape your thinking without your realizing it. Everyone falls into these patterns sometimes, and doing so doesn't make you a bad thinker.

This lesson covers three of the biggest obstacles to clear thinking: **assumptions**, **biases**, and **thought traps**. Once you can recognize them, you can make better decisions, communicate more clearly, and avoid a lot of unnecessary stress.

Assumptions: the invisible fill-in-the-blank

Assumptions are things we treat as true without checking. They usually fill the gap when we don't have enough information.

- "The professor probably hates me."
- "There's no way I can afford college."
- "My advisor won't have time to help."
- "My friend is ignoring me on purpose."

Clear thinking starts with one question: **"Is that actually true, or is it something I'm assuming?"**

> KEY TERM
>
> **Assumption:** something you treat as true without checking it.

Biases: the lens that colors your thinking

A bias is a natural tendency to see things a certain way, usually shaped by your past experiences or preferences. Biases are mental shortcuts, and shortcuts aren't always bad, but in decisions they can lead you off track. Four common ones:

> KEY TERM
>
> **Bias:** a built-in tendency to see things a certain way, often without noticing.

- ### Confirmation bias

  Looking for information that supports what you already believe, and ignoring what doesn't.

  "I already think this class is going to be awful, so everything confirms it."

- ### Familiarity bias

  Choosing what feels familiar, even when it isn't the best choice.

  "I'll pick the same major my friends are in."

- ### Halo effect

  Letting one positive trait shape your whole opinion of someone or something.

  "They're confident, so they must be right."

- ### Negativity bias

  Paying more attention to negative experiences or feedback than to positive ones.

  "I messed up once, so I must be bad at this."

Thought traps: the quicksand of clear thinking

Thought traps are automatic, unhelpful shortcuts we all fall into. They *feel* true in the moment, but they're rarely accurate.

- ### Jumping to conclusions

  Deciding something with little or no evidence.

  "My instructor hasn't answered yet. They must be mad."

- ### All-or-nothing thinking

  Seeing things as only good or bad, success or failure.

  "If I mess up this exam, my future is over."

- ### Overgeneralizing

  Letting one experience define everything.

  "I struggled with math once, so I'll always struggle."

- ### Mind reading

  Deciding you know what someone else is thinking.

"They didn't smile at me. They must not like me."

- **Catastrophizing**

  Expecting the worst case by default.

  "If I change my major, I'll ruin my whole life."

Why this matters

Assumptions, biases, and thought traps can quietly affect:

- Assignment choices
- Test anxiety
- Academic planning
- Career decisions
- Relationships and group work
- Talking with instructors
- Your confidence

Noticing them gives you back control.

Quick practice: spot the trap

For each statement, name what's going wrong. Then open the answer to check yourself.

1. **"I didn't understand the first chapter, so I know I'll fail the class."**

   ▶ Show the answer

2. **"My advisor hasn't emailed me back yet. They probably don't care."**

   ▶ Show the answer

3. **"Everyone else seems to know what they're doing. I'm the only one struggling."**

   ▶ Show the answer

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> You won't get rid of these patterns completely, and you don't need to. The goal is to notice them in the moment, often enough that they stop running the show.

Next, the 4C Check gives you a simple tool to use instead.

LESSON 9.4

The 4C Check: A Simple Tool for Better Decisions

Pause, get clear, and choose wisely.

Most of the stress in a hard decision comes from confusion, not from the decision itself.

"What should I major in?" "Should I drop this class?" "Should I take that job?" "Should I bring this up or let it go?" Critical thinking gets easier when you have a simple tool to walk through a decision step by step, and the 4C Check is that tool.

The four Cs

1. C1

   ### Clarity: What am I really deciding?

   A lot of poor decisions come from being unclear about the actual question. Strong feelings and quick assumptions can blur it, so name them and set them aside for a moment.

   - "Do I hate this class, or am I just overwhelmed this week?"
   - "Am I unsure about the major, or just nervous about one course?"
   - "Is the relationship the problem, or the way we communicate?"

   Ask: What is the exact decision I'm trying to make?

2. C2

   ### Context: What matters most here?

   Name your priorities, values, and limits, and consider how the situation looks from someone else's point of view.

   - "My priority is finishing on time."
   - "I need flexibility because of childcare."
   - "I value honesty, even when it's awkward."
   - "How would my instructor see this?"

   Ask: What factors matter most for me right now, and whose view am I missing?

3. C3

   ### Credibility: What do I know, and what am I assuming?

Check the quality of your information. Separate what you know from what you're assuming or have only heard.

- **Solid:** your advisor, the catalog, the syllabus, official information. "MAT 150 is required for my program."
- **Shaky:** rumors, guesses, assumptions. "Someone said this instructor is impossible."

"AI told me this is the transfer requirement. Did I check it against the actual catalog?"

Ask: What do I know for sure, and what do I need to check?

4. C4

Consequences: What might happen next?

Name your realistic options and think one step ahead for each, not ten. Then choose the most reasonable next step.

- "If I drop this class, will it delay when I finish?"
- "If I send this message, will it help or make things worse?"
- "If I take this job, how will it affect my schedule?"

"If I let AI write my whole email to my instructor, how will I sound, and how will I answer if they write back with a question?"

Ask: What are my options, what's likely to happen with each, and what's my next step?

PATHFINDER TIP

You won't always need all four. Sometimes naming the real question (Clarity) or checking your information (Credibility) is enough to see things differently. Save the full check for decisions that feel bigger or stickier than they should.

LOOK BACK AT

Lesson 4.3: SIFT is Credibility for anything you read online.

Putting it together

Worked example: "Should I switch from full-time to part-time?"

Clarity

The real question: "Can I realistically handle my current schedule?"

Context

I work 25 hours a week and help care for two younger siblings. Finishing matters more to me than finishing fast.

Credibility
My advisor said full-time is doable but hard. My boss won't cut my hours. I'm assuming part-time would hurt my financial aid, so I need to check that.

Consequences
Full-time means faster progress but more stress. Part-time means slower progress but more stability. Next step: ask Financial Aid how a lighter load would affect my aid.

After the 4C Check: a part-time load may support long-term success better, once the aid question is answered.

Try it

Pick one of these small decisions, or one of your own, and run a quick 4C Check.

"Should I email my professor about this assignment?"

"Should I take an 8:00 a.m. class next semester?"

"Should I ask for help, or keep trying on my own?"

"Should I trust this AI summary, or check the source myself?"

Try it: the 4C Check tool

Walk through any decision, one C at a time, and save it as a PDF. Use it now, and any time a decision feels stuck.

Open the 4C Check tool

Practice it: Think It Through

In your course, you'll practice the 4C Check with **Coach Pathfinder**, an AI coach who walks you through each C one at a time. Coach Pathfinder asks questions rather than handing you answers. Your job is to think it through, not guess what the AI wants to hear.

You'll choose a scenario, or bring a real situation of your own:

- **The confusing assignment:** unclear instructions, with the deadline getting close.
- **The group project problem:** a teammate isn't responding, and the deadline is coming up.
- **The technology fail:** you submitted in Blackboard, but you aren't sure it uploaded.

Plan for about four to six exchanges and a short reflection at the end. Be honest. There's no "right" answer here, only real thinking.

> **KEEP HANDY**
>
> Keep this page open for a refresher on the four Cs while you chat.

The 4C Check is this course's tool. It's built on Richard Paul and Linda Elder's Elements of Reasoning and Intellectual Standards (https://www.criticalthinking.org/pages/the-elements-of-reasoning-and-the-intellectual-standards/480) (Foundation for Critical Thinking): Clarity draws on the question at issue and the standard of clarity, Context on purpose and point of view, Credibility on information, assumptions, and accuracy, and Consequences on implications and consequences.

Next, Lesson 9.5 puts the 4C Check to work on your STAR(T) story.

LESSON 9.5

Think It Through: Using Critical Thinking to Build Your STAR(T) Story

The thinking behind a good decision also makes a story worth telling.

The same thinking that helps you make a good decision also helps you tell a story worth telling.

This lesson puts the tools from this module, spotting thought traps and using the 4C Check, to work on your first STAR(T) story. You'll tell the same kind of story in a job interview, a scholarship application, or a conversation with a future employer. The clearer and more honest your thinking is now, the stronger that story will be when it counts.

STAR(T) in five steps

STAR(T) is the framework for your capstone: a short, true story about a time you showed a skill, told in five steps.

1. S**Situation:** What was going on? Set the scene.
2. T**Task:** What needed to happen, and what was your role?
3. A**Action:** What did *you* specifically do? Not the group. You.
4. R**Result:** What happened? What changed?
5. T**Transfer:** Why does it matter going forward, for your next class, a future job, or your life?

The focus is on "I" because the Action step is where the skill lives. If you describe what the group did, no one can see what *you* did. Transfer matters because it's where you show you learned something and know where you're taking it.

> **GO DEEPER**
>
> The STAR(T) Stories Guide covers each step in detail, with a full example and practice guides for your capstone stories.

Where thought traps sneak into STAR(T) drafts

The thought traps from Lesson 9.3 show up in STAR(T) stories all the time. They just look a little different.

"We" instead of "I"

It's tempting to describe the Action as something the group did, especially if it feels safer or more humble. But STAR(T) is about your role.

BeforeWe decided to split up the project and get it done.

AfterI noticed we were behind, so I suggested splitting the project and volunteered to take the research section.

All-or-nothing results

Results don't have to be dramatic to be real. All-or-nothing thinking pushes you to inflate a result or dismiss it, when the honest answer is somewhere in between.

BeforeEverything worked out perfectly in the end.

AfterWe finished on time and got good feedback, though I'd plan the timeline differently next time.

Picking a story because it sounds impressive

This is the "sounding smart" trap from Lesson 9.2. A story that sounds good but isn't quite true, or that you can't talk about in detail, won't hold up to a follow-up question.

InsteadPick a story you remember well enough to talk about for two more minutes if someone asked.

A vague Transfer

Overgeneralizing shows up as a Transfer that could fit any story at all.

BeforeThis experience taught me a lot and will help me in college and my career.

InsteadName the specific thing: what will you do differently, and in what kind of situation?
AI Literacy BE Reflective

If you use AI to help brainstorm your story, watch especially for the vague Transfer. AI-written Transfer statements often sound polished but generic. Make sure the final version sounds like you and says something specific to your experience.

A note on choosing your story

Don't avoid a story just because things didn't go the way you wanted. A story where something went wrong, and you can honestly name what you learned or would do differently, often shows clearer thinking than one where everything worked out.

"I made the wrong call, here's how I noticed, and here's what I'd do differently" shows judgment, honesty, and growth, and for many people it's the stronger story.

Run your draft through the 4C Check

Once you have a draft, the 4C Check is a fast way to find the soft spots: the places where your story could be clearer, more accurate, or more specific.

Example: a student is drafting a story about asking an instructor for an extension after falling behind because of a work schedule change.

1. C1

   ### Clarity: What story am I actually telling?

   BeforeI had a lot going on and emailed my professor about an assignment.

   AfterMy work hours changed with two days' notice, and the new schedule ran right into the deadline for a major paper.

2. C2

   ### Context: What mattered most here?

   The student realizes the real priority was keeping a good working relationship with the instructor while being honest about a real limit, not only getting an extension.

3. C3

   ### Credibility: Is this accurate, or did I round up?

   BeforeI handled it really well, and my professor was super impressed.

   AfterMy professor gave me a two-day extension and said they appreciated the early heads-up.

4. C4

   ### Consequences: So what? What does this mean going forward?

   BeforeThis taught me communication is important.

   AfterNow, when something unexpected comes up, I contact the person affected as soon as I know, not after I've already missed something.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> Don't aim for a perfect story. Aim for a true one you understand well enough to talk about. The 4C Check is there to make sure your story is clear, accurate, and actually says something, not to make it sound better.

Transfer is Consequences, and it's your interview answer

The Transfer step and the Consequences question do the same job: they ask "so what?" When you can answer that clearly, you're building the answer to one of the most common interview questions there is:

> **"Tell me about a time you faced a challenge, and what you learned from it."**

An interviewer asking this wants evidence that you can think about your own experience, not a perfect story. They want to see that you've already done the "so what" thinking instead of doing it for the first time in the interview chair. The 4C Check gives you practice doing that now, with a story you can keep revising until it's ready.

You're ready for Mile Marker #9.

MILE MARKER

Mile Marker #9: Think It Through

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

The thinking behind the thinking, and your first STAR(T) draft.

In this module you learned to spot thinking traps and use the 4C Check to slow down before reacting. You also saw how that same thinking makes a STAR(T) story more honest and specific. This Mile Marker has two parts: a look at your own thinking patterns, and your first STAR(T) draft, a real starting point for your capstone.

What you'll do

1. **Answer four questions** in the form below.
2. **Save as PDF** and upload it to the **Mile Marker #9** assignment in Blackboard.

●○ AI use: AI-supported

You may use AI as a thinking partner to ask you questions about your draft. It can't tell your story for you. Your responses must be in your own words and reflect your real experience. Leave out your full name, where you live, and other identifying details, including other people's names in your story. See the AI Course Policy in the syllabus and Lesson 1.4: AI use labels.

Optional prompt to try: "Help me think through a STAR(T) story for a college reflection assignment. Here's my draft: [paste]. Using the 4C Check (Clarity, Context, Credibility, Consequences), what's one part of my story that could be clearer, more specific, or more accurate? Ask me questions. Don't rewrite it for me." Use what's useful. Your final responses must be in your own words.

Your Mile Marker

Type your answers in the boxes. Your typing is saved in this browser as you go, so you can come back later on the same device. Nothing is sent anywhere until you upload it.

Your name (required) | **Date**

Part I: Know Your Pattern

QUESTION 1

Name Your Pattern and a Better Question

Which thinking trap or bias from this module feels most like you?

> **A STRONG ANSWER**
>
> Names **one pattern**, gives a **real example**, offers a **better question**, and names **one strategy** for slowing down.

1. Choose the pattern that feels most like you.

Circle one: Jumping to conclusions / All-or-nothing thinking / Overgeneralizing / Mind reading / Catastrophizing / Confirmation bias / Familiarity bias / Halo effect / Negativity bias / Something else (describe it in the example)

2. Give a real example of a time this pattern showed up in your life.

3. Write one question you could ask yourself instead, the next time it shows up.

4. Name one strategy that helps you slow down and think more clearly.

Look back at: Lesson 9.3: Biases; Thought traps

Part II: Your First STAR(T) Draft

QUESTION 2

Tell Your Story

Pick one real experience, from this semester or the recent past, and write it out using all five STAR(T) steps.

> **A STRONG ANSWER**
>
> Includes **all five steps**, uses **"I"** in the Action, and **sounds like you**.

1. Situation: What was going on?

2. Task: What needed to happen, and what was your role?

3. Action: What did you specifically do? Not the group. You.

4. Result: What happened?

5. Transfer: Why does this matter going forward, for your next class, a future job, or your life?

Look back at: Lesson 9.5: STAR(T) in five steps; Find Your Stories

QUESTION 3

Check It with the 4Cs

Reread your draft using the 4C Check and answer honestly. Then revise at least one part of your draft.

A STRONG ANSWER

Answers **honestly**, and shows a **real revision** to at least one step.

1. Clarity and Context: Is your Situation clear, or does it need more detail?

2. Credibility: Is everything in your Action and Result accurate, or did you round up?

3. Consequences: Does your Transfer say something specific, or could it apply to anyone?

4. Describe what you revised, and why.

Look back at: Lesson 9.5: Run your draft through the 4C Check

QUESTION 4

Name the Skill

You'll confirm your four capstone skills later, so for now, take your best guess.

A STRONG ANSWER

Names **one skill** and connects it to **something specific** in your story.

1. Name the Essential Skill this story connects to, and explain why.

Look back at: Your four capstone skills

Submit it

Upload your PDF to the **Mile Marker #9** assignment in Blackboard. Check Blackboard for the due date.

In an in-person class? Your instructor may give you a printed copy. Fill it in by hand, then upload a photo or scan.

How it's scored: full credit means every prompt is answered, and each answer is about you, with at least one real detail. See How Mile Markers are scored.

WRAP UP

Module 9 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

You've reached the end of Module 9. These are the ideas to carry forward.

Key takeaways

Critical thinking is thinking on purpose. Pause, ask one good question, then decide.

Notice what's shaping your thinking. Assumptions, biases, and thought traps feel true in the moment, but they're rarely accurate.

Use the 4C Check. Clarity: what am I really deciding? Context: what matters most? Credibility: what do I know, and what am I assuming? Consequences: what might happen next?

STAR(T) is a story about you. Use "I" in the Action, name a real Result, and make the Transfer specific.

The 4Cs make your story stronger. They catch vague setups, rounded-up results, and generic Transfers.

AI can ask the questions. You tell the story. Check what AI says, and keep your story in your own voice.

REFLECT

What's one decision coming up where you'll try the 4C Check, and which C do you think will matter most?

That's Module 9.

Head back to your course in Blackboard for this module's activities.

MODULE 10

Team Up — Collaboration & People Skills

How you work with others, and how to make it easier on everyone, including you.

10 ESSENTIAL SKILLS IN THIS MODULE

#1 Communication

#4 Interpersonal Relations

#8 Collaboration & Teamwork

Why this matters

Let's be honest: group work has a reputation, and not always a great one. This module won't pretend it's easy. It will help you figure out how *you* work best, so you can say so instead of hoping things go okay.

You'll take the 16Personalities assessment, look at your collaboration strengths and struggles, and pick up strategies that fit how you operate. All of it feeds straight into Mile Marker #10.



Merit reminder: Merit Activity #3 is due with this module

Find an activity, then submit your reflection to the Merit Activity #3 submission portal in Blackboard. Check Blackboard for the due date. The Merit Guide has your options, what proof to include, and how to write your

reflection.

What you'll be able to do

By the end of this module:

A

I can identify my natural collaboration tendencies using my 16Personalities results and explain how they show up in group work.

B

I can name two collaboration strengths and one or two challenges and explain why those challenges happen.

C

I can describe three specific strategies that help me work more effectively with others.

D

I can articulate in one clear sentence what I need from teammates to do my best work.

AI Literacy: BE behaviors in this module

- BE Honest
- BE Responsible

Lessons in this module

Trail Tool: Collaboration Snapshot

Your roles, type, strengths, struggles, and strategies in one place.

10.1 Skill Spotlight: Collaboration & Teamwork

Yes, the group work skill. Stay with us. This one's worth it.

10.2 Who Are You in a Group?

Before you can work well with others, you have to understand how you naturally show up.

10.3 Exploring Your Personality Type

Take the 16Personalities assessment and make sense of your results.

10.4 Strengths & Struggles in Collaboration

Every style has strengths and challenges. Knowing yours is power.

10.5 Collaborative Strategies That Actually Work

Choose strategies that match how you work.

Trail Tip: Divide & Conquer, AI-Style

Use AI to turn a group assignment into tasks, roles, and a timeline.

Mile Marker: Mile Marker #10: My Collaboration Profile

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

Wrap Up: Module 10 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

TRAIL TOOL

Collaboration Snapshot

Your roles, type, strengths, struggles, and strategies in one place.

Your group roles, your type, your strengths and struggles, and the strategies that fit you, all in one place.

Fill this in as you read. Each lesson points you to the step it goes with. By the end, you'll have everything you need for Mile Marker #10.

Go to 16Personalities (https://www.16personalities.com/free-personality-test)

LOOK AHEAD

Lesson 10.3 walks you through the 16Personalities assessment.

Fill in your snapshot

Your answers save in this browser as you go. Select **Save as PDF** to keep a copy.

PATHFINDER TIP

Nothing here is sent anywhere. It stays on this device until you choose to share it.

Your name (required) **Date**

STEP 1

The group roles that sound like me

From Lesson 10.2. Check all that fit.

The Starter

The Organizer

The Analyzer

The Doer

The Encourager

The Quiet Worker

The Big-Picture Thinker

Which one shows up when I'm stressed, and which one when things are going well?

STEP 2

My 16Personalities type

From Lesson 10.3.

My type (for example, ENFP-T)

My type in my own words (one short phrase)

What felt accurate? What didn't?

STEP 3

My strengths and struggles

From Lesson 10.4. Check all that fit, then circle back to the two that fit best.

Strengths I bring

Clear communicator

Supportive teammate

Creative problem-solver

Organized planner

Calm mediator

Detail-checker

Energizer or motivator

Deep thinker

Flexible adapter

Relationship-builder

Big-picture visionary

Dependable finisher

Struggles I recognize

Hard to get started

Taking on too much

Hard to speak up

Avoiding conflict

Coming across too blunt

Overwhelmed by chaos

Frustrated by unclear instructions

Perfectionism

Withdrawing under stress

Trouble reading tone

Over-controlling

Resisting schedules

STEP 4

Strategies that fit me

From Lesson 10.5. Check three.

Start with clear expectations

Communicate my style

Play to my strengths

Ask clarifying questions

Break tasks into pieces

Use tools wisely

Assume good intent

Know my stress signals

Use the 2-minute reset

A group experience where one of these would have helped (or did help)

STEP 5

What I need from a team

One sentence, simple and respectful

LESSON 10.1

Skill Spotlight: Collaboration & Teamwork

Yes, the group work skill. Stay with us. This one's worth it.



10 Essential Skills · #8

Collaboration & Teamwork

What this skill is

Yes, the group work skill. Stay with us. This one's worth it.

If you groaned a little when you saw this module's skill, you're not alone. Most people have at least one group project story that still makes them tense up: the partner who disappeared, the group member who took over everything, the project that fell apart two days before it was due.

Most students don't know that instructors often groan too. Group work has a reputation problem on both sides of the classroom.

So this module won't pretend group work is great. It will help you understand *why* it so often goes badly, starting with how you tend to operate, so you can do something about it next time.

> **Benchmark collaboration shows up. Milestone collaboration makes the group better.**

Where you're headed

Below, in plain terms, is the difference between where most students start and where you're headed.

SEE ALSO

Lesson 1.2 explains Benchmark, Milestone, and Capstone.

Benchmark Where you're starting

- You support team decisions by taking part in discussions.
- You respond promptly to messages and requests for information.
- You complete your tasks on time and see how your part affects the team.
- You recognize your own strengths and limits within a team.

Milestone

YOUR TARGET

- You contribute ideas that fit the team's actual goals, not just any idea.
- You address conflict constructively, saying what you expect and adjusting your own behavior based on feedback.
- You figure out what tasks are needed and learn your teammates' strengths, so roles get divided fairly.
- You adapt to changing plans and roles in ways that build trust and respect.

The shift from Benchmark to Milestone is the shift from "doing your part" to paying attention to how the team is working, and doing something about it when it isn't.

The four Milestone behaviors, up close

1 Contribute ideas that fit the actual goal

At the Benchmark level, "contributing" can mean almost anything: agreeing with whatever's already been decided, or tossing out an idea that's interesting but unrelated to what the team is trying to do. At the Milestone level, your contributions are tied to what the team is trying to accomplish. That means understanding the goal well enough to know whether an idea moves the team toward it, and being willing to say so, even if it means setting aside an idea you personally like.

Instead of "We should also add a section about X" (because it interests you), ask: "Does X help us do what the assignment is asking for?"

2 Address conflict constructively

This is probably the biggest gap between Benchmark and Milestone, and the source of most group work horror stories. At the Benchmark level, conflict tends to get avoided (hoping it fixes itself), absorbed (quietly doing extra work to make up for it), or escalated (going straight to the instructor without talking to the group first). At the Milestone level, conflict gets addressed directly: you say what you need or expect, and you're willing to adjust your own behavior based on feedback, not just wait for others to change.

Instead of silently redoing a teammate's section because it "wasn't right," try: "I noticed we have different ideas about how this section should look. Can we talk about what we're each picturing?"

3 Know the tasks, and know your team

A lot of group trouble starts before anyone does any work. Nobody spells out what the project needs, so roles land by accident: whoever speaks first, whoever cares most, or whoever feels guilty.

At the Milestone level, you help the group name the tasks, then match them to people's strengths. That's what makes the work fair, and it's why understanding your own style (and asking about other people's) matters so much in this module.

Instead of "I'll just do the slides because nobody else will," ask: "What does this project need, and who's strongest at what?"

> **SEE ALSO**
>
> Lesson 10.5, Strategy 3: Play to your strengths
>
> Trail Tip: Divide & Conquer, AI-Style

4 Adapt to change without losing trust

Group projects almost never go exactly as planned. Someone's role changes, a deadline moves, the assignment gets clarified halfway through. Benchmark collaboration treats these changes as disruptions. Milestone collaboration treats them as normal, and handles them in a way that keeps the group working well together.

This is where trust gets built or lost. A team that can absorb a change without anyone feeling blindsided, dismissed, or stuck with extra work is a team that's actually collaborating, not just dividing up tasks.

If a teammate has to step back because of a work or family emergency, Milestone collaboration means adjusting the plan together, not quietly resenting them or scrambling alone.

Where it shows up

This module gives you a tool, your 16Personalities results, to understand your own collaboration tendencies before you're in the middle of a group situation.

A group project forms
Benchmark: You wait to see what role you get assigned.
Milestone: You already know whether you tend to take charge, prefer to support, need structure, or work best with flexibility, and you say so early.

Someone goes quiet

Benchmark: You assume they don't care, and either pick up the slack silently or write them off.

Milestone: You see a moment for direct, low-drama communication, and you reach out before it becomes a bigger problem.

Two people disagree

Benchmark: You stay quiet and hope it resolves on its own, or pick a side privately.

Milestone: You treat the disagreement as information about priorities, working styles, or unclear expectations, not just a personality clash.

The plan changes

Benchmark: You feel thrown off and frustrated that the plan isn't the plan anymore.

Milestone: You expect it, and focus on how to adjust together rather than who's to blame.

PATHFINDER TIP

You don't have to become a different kind of person to be good at this. The goal is to know your own tendencies well enough to use them on purpose, not to turn introverts into extraverts or planners into improvisers, and to understand that other people's tendencies aren't wrong, just different.

In your own life

REFLECT

Think of your best group experience, at school, at work, in your community, or on a team. What made it work?

Think of one that went sideways. Which of the four behaviors was missing?

When conflict shows up in a group, do you tend to avoid it, absorb it, or escalate it?

How it shows up later

Collaboration isn't a "soft skill" in the sense of being optional or easy. In a recent national survey of employers, teamwork ranked second only to problem-solving among the skills they look for on a new graduate's resume. Almost nothing important gets built by one person alone.

In this module, you'll build a real profile of how *you* work with others, strengths, struggles, and all, that you can use. It's also a strong choice for the fourth skill in your STAR(T) Stories.

Employer data: National Association of Colleges and Employers (NACE), Job Outlook 2025 (https://www.naceweb.org/talent-acquisition/candidate-selection/what-are-employers-looking-for-when-reviewing-college-students-resumes). Skill definition and Milestone indicators are based on the Kentucky Council on Postsecondary Education's Kentucky Graduate Profile (https://cpe.ky.gov/ourwork/kygradprofile.html).

LESSON 10.2

Who Are You in a Group?

Before you can work well with others, you have to understand how you naturally show up.

Before you can work well with others, you have to understand how you naturally show up.

College, work, and life all ask you to collaborate: sometimes with people you like, sometimes with people you've just met, and sometimes with people who work very differently than you do. Collaboration is more than "group work." It's communicating clearly, handling different personalities, sharing responsibilities, working through disagreements, following through, respecting differences, and contributing your strengths. This lesson starts with the most overlooked piece of all: your own default tendencies.

How we tend to show up in groups

Most people have a "default mode" when working with others. You might recognize yourself in one of these, or in a mix of two or three.

- ### The Starter

  You jump in quickly, share ideas early, and get others moving.

- ### The Organizer

  You love timelines, steps, and lists, and making sure things get done.

- ### The Analyzer

  You ask questions, look at details, and make sure decisions make sense.

- ### The Doer

  You take action, handle tasks, and keep the project moving forward.

- ### The Encourager

  You support the group, check on everyone, and keep the mood positive.

- ### The Quiet Worker

  You prefer clear instructions, space to think, and tasks you can complete on your own.

- ### The Big-Picture Thinker

  You focus on goals, vision, where this is going, and creative solutions.

None of these is better or worse. All of them matter, and a strong group usually has several working together.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
>
> If you thought, "I'm a mix of three of these, depending on the situation," that's normal, and it's useful information. Notice which one shows up most when you're stressed, and which one shows up when things are going smoothly.

Where collaboration gets messy

Problems usually start when people don't recognize, or don't communicate, their own tendencies. It can look like this:

- **The Starter** feels frustrated that no one else jumps in.
- **The Quiet Worker** feels steamrolled by louder voices.
- **The Organizer** gets stressed when others don't follow the plan.
- **The Doer** takes on too much and burns out.
- **The Big-Picture Thinker** gets bored with the details.
- **The Analyzer** slows things down when others want speed.

> **These are style differences, not personal flaws.**

This module helps you figure out your own style, how to communicate it, and how to understand other people's, so these moments turn into conversations instead of resentment.

Why personality tools can help

Next, you'll take the 16Personalities assessment. Think of it as a tool for self-awareness and for understanding others, not a label. It can help you think about:

- How you prefer to communicate
- How you respond to stress
- How you take in information
- How you make decisions
- How you work in groups

Knowing your tendencies makes collaboration less stressful and more realistic, for you and for everyone you work with.

Start your snapshot

REFLECT

Which group role feels most like you?

What's one thing you know you do well when working with others?

What's one thing that tends to frustrate you in group work, and why?

Do you prefer leading, contributing, organizing, or supporting? Why?

Mark the roles that fit you in Step 1 of the Collaboration Snapshot. Then head to the next lesson to take the assessment. You'll likely see some of these roles in your results.

LESSON 10.3

Exploring Your Personality Type

Take the 16Personalities assessment and make sense of your results.

Understanding how you communicate, take in information, and work with others begins with understanding yourself.

Everyone interacts, learns, and collaborates differently, and that's a strength, not a flaw. Knowing your tendencies can help you communicate more clearly, avoid misunderstandings, work better with people who think differently than you, and understand why certain group situations feel easy and others feel hard.

In this lesson you'll take the free 16Personalities assessment and learn what your results mean. The point is **self-awareness**, the foundation of strong collaboration, not a label.

Take the assessment

1. **Go to 16personalities.com (https://www.16personalities.com/free-personality-test)**

   Start the free test. It takes about 10 minutes. The free results are all you need, so skip any paid upgrades.

2. **Answer honestly**

   There are no right or wrong answers. Go with your first instinct, and answer for how you usually are, not how you think you should be.

3. **Get your type**

   Your result is a four-letter type plus a fifth letter after a dash, like **ENFP-T** or **ISTJ-A**, along with a short description and a type name.

> **GOOD TO KNOW**
> 16Personalities uses the four-letter codes made famous by the Myers-Briggs Type Indicator, but it isn't the Myers-Briggs. It's its own model, built on the "Big Five" personality traits that psychology researchers use most.

Understand your letters

Each letter comes from a pair. Together they give clues about how you operate in groups, communicate, make decisions, and handle stress. Most people land somewhere between the two ends of each pair, so read your percentages too, not just the letter.

- ### Energy How you recharge

  I · Introverted

  Energized by quiet time. Tends to think things through first.

  E · Extraverted

  Energized by people. Tends to talk things out.

- ### Mind How you take in information

  S · Observant

  Practical and down-to-earth. Likes concrete details and clear steps.

  N · Intuitive

  Imaginative and curious. Likes patterns, big ideas, and possibilities.

- ### Nature How you make decisions

  T · Thinking

  Leads with logic and fairness.

  F · Feeling

  Leads with values, harmony, and how people are affected.

- ### Tactics How you approach plans

  J · Judging

  Likes plans, organization, and predictability.

  P · Prospecting

  Likes flexibility, improvising, and keeping options open.

- ### Identity How you handle pressure

  -A · Assertive

  Tends to feel steady and self-assured under stress.

  -T · Turbulent

  Tends to feel stress more and push hard to improve.

None of these is good or bad. They're different ways of being effective. A Turbulent result doesn't mean you're fragile, and an Assertive one doesn't mean you never worry.

How your type can show up in groups

Your tendencies might shape:

- **How you communicate.** Extraverts often talk it out; introverts often think first, then speak.

- **How you take on tasks.** Observant types want the details; Intuitive types want the big picture first.
- **How you make decisions.** Thinking types aim for logic; Feeling types weigh how people will be affected.
- **How you handle deadlines.** Judging types want a plan early; Prospecting types need room to adjust.
- **How conflict feels.** Feeling types may avoid it; Thinking types may take it head-on.

Your brain's wiring shapes collaboration too, whether or not you have a name for it. The next lesson looks at that, along with the strengths and struggles that come with each tendency.

> **LOOK BACK AT**
>
> Lesson 7.3: Strengths. Your HIGH5 results and your type are two different lenses on the same person.

A map, not a rulebook

Your personality type is **not** your identity, and it doesn't decide what you can or can't do. Personality tests describe tendencies, and your results can shift depending on your mood, your season of life, or how you read a question. Think of your type as a map of how you *tend* to operate, not a box you're stuck in.

If part of your result doesn't sound like you, trust yourself. Noticing what doesn't fit is just as useful as noticing what does.

Your first impressions

> **REFLECT**
>
> Which parts of your type feel accurate?
>
> What surprised you, or what do you disagree with?
>
> What described you well in group situations?
>
> What made you think, "Hmm, that explains a lot"?

Record your type and first impressions in Step 2 of the Collaboration Snapshot.

> **JUST FOR FUN**
>
> Once you know your type, look it up on Frank James's YouTube channel (https://www.youtube.com/@FrankJames/videos). His short videos about each type are funny, and often uncomfortably accurate. Take them as entertainment, not science.

LESSON 10.4

Strengths & Struggles in Collaboration

Every style has strengths and challenges. Knowing yours is power.

Every collaboration style has strengths and challenges, and knowing yours gives you more control.

Now that you've explored your 16Personalities results, it's time to connect them to **how you work with others**: what you bring to a team, what drains you, how you communicate, where misunderstandings happen, and what you need to do your best work. There are no good or bad personality types for collaboration, and the more you understand your tendencies, the easier it gets.

Your type and collaboration

Each tendency tends to bring a strength to a group, and a struggle to watch for. Find your letters.

Trait	Strength	Struggle to watch for
Extraverted (E)	Energizes the group, brings ideas forward	May talk over quieter members
Introverted (I)	Thoughtful insight, calm presence	May feel overshadowed or unheard
Observant (S)	Practical, detail-oriented, grounded	May get frustrated by vague or "too theoretical" plans
Intuitive (N)	Creative solutions, big-picture thinking	May skip steps or overlook details
Thinking (T)	Logic, clarity, fairness	May come across as blunt or detached
Feeling (F)	Empathy, harmony, connection	May avoid conflict, even when it's needed
Judging (J)	Organization, structure, follow-through	May get stressed when plans change
Prospecting (P)	Flexible, adaptable, spontaneous	May put things off or resist schedules

> **These are tendencies, not weaknesses, and every team needs all kinds.**

Different brains, different teammates

Not everyone's brain works the same way, and that's normal. Some students identify as neurodivergent (ADHD, autism, dyslexia, anxiety-related processing differences, and more). Others simply notice they think or work differently from the people around them. You do **not** need a diagnosis to recognize a pattern.

LOOK BACK AT

Divergent Minds: Your Brain, Your Way, the Module 3 bonus read, covers how these patterns show up in time and energy, too.

Strengths different brains may bring

- Deep focus on meaningful tasks
- Creativity and big-picture thinking
- Spotting patterns quickly
- Thinking outside the box
- Honesty, clarity, and directness
- Deep empathy or attention to detail

Challenges that may come up

- Overwhelm in noisy or chaotic groups
- Difficulty switching tasks
- Trouble with timing, planning, or transitions
- Missing social cues, or tone in texts
- Frustration with vague expectations
- Anxiety that affects speaking up
- Shutdown or overload moments in group settings

Knowing your patterns, whether they come from personality, experience, or how your brain is wired, helps you ask for what you need and choose strategies that work for you. Knowing that other people have patterns too helps you collaborate more respectfully and patiently.

What you share about yourself, and with whom, is always your choice. You can name what helps ("I work best with written deadlines") without explaining why.

Name your strengths

These are common collaboration strengths. Which ones fit you? You're probably strong in more than one.

- Clear communicator

- Supportive teammate
- Creative problem-solver
- Organized planner
- Calm mediator
- Detail-checker
- Energizer or motivator
- Deep thinker
- Flexible adapter
- Relationship-builder
- Big-picture visionary
- Dependable finisher

Check off yours, and the struggles you recognize, in Step 3 of the Collaboration Snapshot. The next lesson gives you strategies for working with both.

LESSON 10.5

Collaborative Strategies That Actually Work

Choose strategies that match how you work.

Once you understand how you work, you can choose strategies that help you work well with others.

Strong teamwork doesn't require being outgoing, loud, organized, or perfect. It comes from knowing how you operate, what you need, and how to say so respectfully.

Collaboration gets much easier when you use strategies that match your strengths and support your challenges. These nine work in classes, study groups, jobs, and everyday relationships, and you'll pick three of them for Mile Marker #10.

Nine strategies

1. ### Start with clear expectations

   A lot of group conflict comes from unclear roles and unclear goals. Early on, get answers to four questions:

   - What's the task?
   - What are the deadlines?
   - Who's doing what?
   - What does "done" look like?

   This lowers stress for everyone, especially people who like structure.

2. ### Communicate your style, respectfully

   Simple scripts work wonders:

   - "I work best when tasks are clearly divided."
   - "I can take the lead on organizing, but I need others to jump in with ideas."
   - "I like to think for a moment before I respond."
   - "Group chaos overwhelms me. Can we set a quick plan?"
   - "I do better with deadlines written down."
   - "I'm happy to help with research, but I don't love presenting."

   Saying it up front helps the group work smarter. It isn't making excuses.

3. ### Play to your strengths

   Use what you naturally do well, from the group roles in Lesson 10.2:

- **Organizer:** manage the timeline or checklist
- **Analyzer:** check accuracy and details
- **Starter:** open discussions or brainstorm
- **Encourager:** support morale and help settle conflict
- **Doer:** take on the task-heavy pieces
- **Quiet Worker:** tackle clear, independent tasks
- **Big-Picture Thinker:** propose creative solutions or direction

Let strengths lead, and let others cover what drains you.

4. ### Ask clarifying questions

   Clarifying questions prevent most miscommunication:

   - "What do you mean by that?"
   - "Can you give an example?"
   - "What's the top priority here?"
   - "What's our next step?"
   - "Where should this information go?"

   Clarifying is smart teamwork.

5. ### Break tasks into manageable pieces

   If the group is stuck, overwhelmed, or putting things off, try breaking the project into smaller tasks, giving each one a lead person, setting mini-deadlines, and meeting briefly to check in. It helps anyone who struggles to get started, and honestly, it helps everyone.

6. ### Use your tools wisely

   Tools that structure the work make collaboration easier: a shared Word document in OneDrive, Microsoft Teams, a group text or GroupMe, a shared checklist or task board, or an outline template everyone fills in.

7. ### Assume good intent, most of the time

   People usually aren't ignoring you; they're busy. They usually aren't trying to be rude; they're stressed. They usually aren't lazy; they're overwhelmed. Assuming good intent prevents a lot of unnecessary conflict.

   But "most of the time" matters. If you need clarity, ask. If something feels off, address it calmly. If you feel disrespected, set a boundary.

8. ### Know your stress signals

   Everyone has a collaboration stress mode. Some common signals:

   - Shutting down

- Over-controlling
- Withdrawing
- Doing everything yourself
- Procrastinating
- Avoiding meetings
- Getting rigid

Your stress signals are information, not failures. Use them as a cue to pause and choose a strategy that helps.

9. ### Use the 2-minute reset

   When tension rises: **pause**, **breathe**, then ask yourself three questions:

   - "What's actually the issue?"
   - "What matters most here?"
   - "What's the next best step?"

   It gives your brain a chance to respond instead of react.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
>
> If the 2-minute reset sounds familiar, it should. It's the same move as the 4C Check from Module 9: pause, get clear, then decide. The thinking tools in this course connect, and they show up everywhere, including in the middle of a group chat that's going sideways.

Choose your three

> **REFLECT**
>
> Which strategy describes how you already work best?
>
> Which one could help with a challenge you named in the last lesson?
>
> Think of a group experience that went sideways. Which strategy would have helped?
>
> Which one do you want to try in your next group assignment?

Pick your three in Step 4 of the Collaboration Snapshot. Then you're ready for Mile Marker #10.

TRAIL TIP

Divide & Conquer, AI-Style

Use AI to turn a group assignment into tasks, roles, and a timeline.

Using AI to turn "someone should probably..." into an actual plan.

Almost everyone in a group project has lived through this scene. The group agrees the project needs a topic, research, slides, and a presentation. Everyone nods. Nobody assigns anything. A week goes by, and now it's due Friday and somehow it's everyone's problem at once.

A lot of group tension has less to do with people being lazy or difficult than with one simple problem: **nobody wants to be the one who assigns tasks to other people.** It can feel bossy or awkward. So nothing gets assigned, and the group just hopes.

> **AI is great at being the "bad guy" who hands out the to-do list, so no one in your group has to be.**

This Trail Tip shows you how to use AI to break an assignment into tasks, suggest roles, and build a realistic timeline, fast. Your group still makes the real decisions. AI gets you past the awkward "okay... so... who's doing what?" silence.

How to do it

1. ### Check the AI rules first

   Look at the assignment's AI use label and the course AI policy. Planning with AI is usually fine even when the work itself has to be your own, but check.

2. ### Paste in the assignment instructions

   The more AI knows about what's required, the more useful the plan will be.

3. ### Add your group's roles and the due date

   Use "Member A, Member B" instead of names, or ask your group before you share their first names. Their information isn't yours to share.

4. ### Ask for tasks, roles, a timeline, and group norms

   Use the prompt below. All four together turn a vague assignment into something your group can act on today.

5. ### Bring the plan back to your group, and adjust it

AI doesn't know who's great at design or who works on Tuesdays. Use the plan as a first draft, not a final ruling.

TRY THIS PROMPT

"We're working on a group project for [class]. Here are the assignment instructions: [paste]. There are [number] of us, Member A through Member [letter], and the project is due [date]. Please build a simple group work plan with: 1) the main tasks, 2) suggested roles so everyone contributes, 3) a weekly timeline, 4) a few earlier check-in dates so we're not rushing at the end, and 5) four or five simple group norms for how we'll communicate and stay organized. Keep it simple, realistic, and student-friendly, with headings and bullet points."

What you'll get back

This condensed sample plan is for a four-person psychology presentation:

Sample AI-generated group plan (condensed)

Main tasks

Choose a topic · Research (3+ credible sources) · Build an outline · Build slides · Prepare and practice the presentation

Suggested roles

Member	Role	Focus
A	Project organizer	Tracks deadlines, coordinates the group
B	Research lead	Finds sources, shares notes
C	Slide designer	Builds and organizes slides
D	Presentation lead	Organizes speaking parts, leads practice

Weekly timeline

- **Week 1:** choose topic, assign roles, find 2+ sources
- **Week 2:** finish research, build outline, start slides
- **Week 3:** finish slides, assign speaking parts, practice

Group norms

- Respond to group messages within 24 hours
- Finish assigned tasks before meetings

- Speak up early if you're stuck or confused
- Respect each other's ideas and working styles

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
>
> This is Strategy 1, Start with clear expectations, on fast-forward. AI gives your group a first draft to react to, instead of a blank page to build from. Then use what you know about each other's strengths to adjust the roles.

AI Literacy BE Responsible BE Safe

The plan is the easy part

AI can generate a plan in seconds. **Following through on it is still on your group.** A plan nobody looks at again isn't more useful than no plan at all.

This is BE Responsible in action: using AI to handle an awkward, low-value task so your group has more time and energy for the parts that need your thinking. And it's BE Safe, too: keep your teammates' names and details out of the prompt unless they've said it's okay.

If your group divides the work with AI's help, the work itself still follows the assignment's AI use label. Planning with AI doesn't make AI a group member.

MILE MARKER

Mile Marker #10: My Collaboration Profile

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

How you work best with others, and how you plan to work even better.

This module you explored your 16Personalities results and what helps, and doesn't, when you're working with others. This Mile Marker asks you to put that into a short, honest profile. There's no "best" type for collaboration, only an honest answer and a vague one.

What you'll do

1. **Before you start,** take the 16Personalities assessment and fill in your Collaboration Snapshot.
   - Lesson 10.3: Take the 16Personalities assessment (your type, for Question 1)
   - Collaboration Snapshot (it has most of what you need)
2. **Answer three questions** in the form below.
3. **Save as PDF** and upload it to the **Mile Marker #10** assignment in Blackboard.

●○ AI use: AI-supported

You may use AI to help you organize your thoughts. Your final responses must be in your own words. AI doesn't know how you collaborate. You do. Leave out your full name and other identifying details. See the AI Course Policy in the syllabus and Lesson 1.4: AI use labels.

Optional prompt to try: "Help me organize a short Collaboration Profile for a college reflection assignment. My type, strengths, challenges, and what helps me are: [paste your notes]. Ask me one or two questions to make it more specific, then help me turn it into a clear summary." Use what's useful. Your final responses must be in your own words.

Your Mile Marker

Type your answers in the boxes. Your typing is saved in this browser as you go, so you can come back later on the same device. Nothing is sent anywhere until you upload it.

Your name (required) | **Date**

QUESTION 1

Your Type, Strengths & Challenges

Example: "INFJ-T: quiet planner who likes meaningful work. I'm an organized planner and a calm mediator, but I tend to avoid conflict and take on too much." **Strengths word bank:** clear communicator · supportive teammate · creative problem-solver · organized planner · calm mediator · detail-checker · energizer or motivator · deep thinker · flexible adapter · relationship-builder · big-picture visionary · dependable finisher. **Challenges word bank:** hard to get started · taking on too much · hard to speak up · avoiding conflict · coming across too blunt · overwhelmed by chaos · frustrated by unclear instructions · perfectionism · withdrawing under stress · trouble reading tone · over-controlling · resisting schedules.

A STRONG ANSWER

Gives your type **in your own words**, and names **two strengths** and **one or two challenges** that sound like you, not like a quiz summary.

1. Your 16Personalities type (for example, INFJ-T)

2. Describe your type in your own words, in one short phrase.

3. Name two collaboration strengths that fit you.

4. Name one or two challenges that fit you.

Look back at: Lesson 10.3: Your letters; Lesson 10.4: Strengths and struggles

QUESTION 2

Why, and What Helps

Think of your challenge as a tendency, not a flaw: needing structure, being introverted, processing fast or slow, group anxiety, or how your brain works. Sharing anything about neurodivergence is always optional. **Strategies word bank:** start with clear expectations · communicate my style · play to my strengths · ask clarifying questions · break tasks into pieces · use tools wisely · assume good intent · know my stress signals · use the 2-minute reset.

A STRONG ANSWER

Explains **the why** behind one challenge, names **three strategies** that fit you, and connects one to a **real experience**.

1. Pick one challenge, and explain why it happens for you.

2. Strategy 1

3. Strategy 2

4. Strategy 3

5. Describe a real group experience where one of these helped, or would have helped. Your discussion story may work.

Look back at: Lesson 10.4: Different brains; Lesson 10.5: Nine strategies

QUESTION 3

What You Need From Your Team

Examples: "I work best when tasks and deadlines are clearly divided." "I thrive when I can think before speaking."

A STRONG ANSWER

Is **one clear sentence** that's specific, respectful, and something you could **actually say** to a real team.

1. Write one simple, respectful sentence: what do you need from teammates to do your best work?

2. Optional: What does it look like when that need is met, and when it isn't?

Look back at: Strategy 2: Communicate your style

Submit it

Upload your PDF to the **Mile Marker #10** assignment in Blackboard. Check Blackboard for the due date.

In an in-person class? Your instructor may give you a printed copy. Fill it in by hand, then upload a photo or scan.

How it's scored: full credit means every prompt is answered, and each answer is about you, with at least one real detail. See How Mile Markers are scored.

WRAP UP

Module 10 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

You've reached the end of Module 10. These are the ideas to carry forward.

Key takeaways

Showing up isn't the same as collaborating. Milestone collaboration makes the group better: ideas that fit the goal, conflict handled directly, fair roles, and trust through change.

Know your default mode. Starter, Organizer, Analyzer, Doer, Encourager, Quiet Worker, Big-Picture Thinker. Most people are a mix.

Your type is a map, not a rulebook. Use it to understand your tendencies, not to box yourself in.

Every strength has a struggle to watch for. These are style differences, not flaws, and every team needs all kinds.

Say what you need. One clear, respectful sentence can prevent a week of frustration.

Let AI hand out the to-do list, not do the work. A plan only helps if your group follows through.

REFLECT

Where will you work with others next, in a class, at work, or somewhere else, and which strategy will you try first?

That's Module 10.

Head back to your course in Blackboard for this module's activities. Merit Activity #3 is due with this module.

MODULE 11

Making an Impact — Community, Values & Your Pathfinder Journey

Your community is closer than you think, and so is your next step on this trail.

10 ESSENTIAL SKILLS IN THIS MODULE


#4 Interpersonal Relations


#5 Adaptability & Leadership


#7 Civic Engagement


#9 Knowledge Application

Why this matters

"Civic engagement" can sound like something for other people: politicians, organizers, people with way more free time than you. This module starts somewhere different, with the communities you're already part of and the everyday skill of seeing how they actually work.

It's also your working time for your STAR(T) Stories. Everything you've learned about yourself this semester (strengths, values, interests, and now community) is exactly what those stories are made of.

What you'll be able to do

By the end of this module:

A

I can define community broadly and identify at least one community I already belong to and contribute to.

B

I can describe specific ways my everyday actions make a positive impact on the people around me.

C

I can connect my strengths and values to one intentional way I want to grow my community impact going forward.

D

I can select four experiences from my semester and match each one to an Essential Skill for my STAR(T) Story.

AI Literacy: BE behaviors in this module

- BE Responsible
- BE Reflective

Lessons in this module

Trail Tool: Community Snapshot

One community: how it works, what you bring, and where you're headed.

11.1 Skill Spotlight: Civic Engagement

Starting with the parts of "society" you're already standing in.

11.2 What Is Community, Really?

You're already in more communities than you think, and already shaping how they work.

11.3 Your Strengths, Your Community

Putting what you know about yourself to work.

Trail Tip: Start Your STAR(T) Stories

This module is your working time. Here's the short path.

Mile Marker: Mile Marker #11: My Community Impact

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

Wrap Up: Module 11 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

TRAIL TOOL

Community Snapshot

One community: how it works, what you bring, and where you're headed.

One community you're part of: how it works, what you bring to it, and how you want to show up next.

Fill this in as you read. Lessons 11.2 and 11.3 point you to each step. By the end, you'll have most of what you need for Mile Marker #11.

LOOK AHEAD

Lesson 11.2: Every community runs on a system

Fill in your snapshot

Your answers save in this browser as you go. Select **Save as PDF** to keep a copy.

PATHFINDER TIP

Nothing here is sent anywhere. Use first names or roles for the people in your community, not full names.

Your name (required)

Date

STEP 1

My community

A living situation, a job, a class, a team, a group chat, a faith or cultural group, an online space.

The community

My role in it

How I already show up or contribute, even in small ways

STEP 2

How it works

From Lesson 11.2.

People: who's involved, and what role each tends to play

Rules: one unwritten rule running the show

Influence: who really shapes what happens (it might be me)

Leverage point: one small action that might make something work better

STEP 3

My offer and my boundary

From Lesson 11.3.

The strengths and values I'm drawing on (from Module 7)

What I have to offer

What I'm not available for

How it would feel to say both out loud

STEP 4

Looking ahead

One way I want to show up more intentionally

One realistic first step

LESSON 11.1

Skill Spotlight: Civic Engagement

Starting with the parts of "society" you're already standing in.



10 Essential Skills · #7

Civic Engagement

What this skill is

Engaging in civic life to improve society, starting with the parts of "society" you're already standing in.

"Civic engagement" tends to bring certain images to mind: voting, city council meetings, protests, campaigns. Those are real examples. They can also feel intimidating if you're not there yet, and they can make this skill seem like something for *other people*, people older, more political, or more "into that kind of thing" than you.

Every one of those bigger examples is built on a smaller foundation: the everyday ability to engage with the people and systems around you, notice how things actually work, and help make a shared space better. You don't have to wait to build that. You're building it right now, in the communities you're already part of.

> **Benchmark civic engagement notices the conversation. Milestone civic engagement joins it, and helps move it somewhere.**

Where you're headed

Below is the difference between where most students start and where you're headed. This skill's official language talks about public policy and government, because that's where it's ultimately pointing. You'll build toward it in smaller spaces first.

SEE ALSO

Lesson 1.2 explains Benchmark, Milestone, and Capstone.

Benchmark Where you're starting

- You respectfully discuss basic ideas about public policy and the social good, sharing your own opinions and acknowledging others'.
- You can explain basic democratic principles, the U.S. Constitution, and how individual and community involvement has shaped American government, past and present.
- You can describe opportunities for people or groups to engage in civic life and bring about positive change.

Milestone

YOUR TARGET

- You engage with people who see public policy and the social good differently, through active listening, clear and responsive dialogue, and collaboration.
- You use what you know about how people's participation shapes public policy to plan for action.
- You make persuasive arguments that benefit society, based on your own experience, what you've observed, and outside knowledge or perspectives.

The shift from Benchmark to Milestone is the shift from describing how civic life works to taking part in it: engaging with people who see things differently, and using what you notice to help move something forward.

The three Milestone behaviors, up close

1 Engage across different perspectives

At the Benchmark level, this looks like respectful discussion: you share your view and acknowledge that others have theirs. At the Milestone level, it becomes active. You really listen to someone who sees a shared situation differently, respond to what they actually said (not what you assumed they'd say), and work *with* them rather than just alongside them.

This is less about debate and more about something quieter. Can you be in a room, a group chat, or a shared living space with someone whose perspective is different from yours, and still move toward something together?

Two roommates disagree about how guests should be handled. Benchmark: both state their position and move on. Milestone: each one listens to why the other cares, and they land on something neither started with, because they built it together.

2 Understand how participation shapes what happens

At the Benchmark level, this is knowledge: you can describe how people's involvement affects what happens in a system, whether that's a government or any other shared system. At the Milestone level, you use that knowledge. You look at a situation and ask, "Given how this works, what would actually make a difference here?"

This is where "civic" stops being a category of activity and becomes a way of looking at any shared space. Outcomes aren't fixed, and participation, yours and other people's, is part of what shapes them.

A student notices that group projects in their program keep falling apart the same way, semester after semester. Benchmark: they can describe why. Milestone: they use that understanding to plan something different, for their own group or by raising it with an instructor in a way that could change the pattern.

3 Make a case based on real reflection

At the Benchmark level, you know opportunities to make a difference exist. At the Milestone level, you can make an actual case for something, grounded in your own experience, what you've observed, and what you've learned from other perspectives. That goes beyond stating an opinion. You're building an argument someone else might find persuasive.

The key word is *reflection*. An argument grounded in real experience and honest analysis lands differently than a generic opinion, because it's specific, and it shows your thinking, not just your conclusion.

Instead of "The campus shuttle schedule doesn't work," try: "Here's specifically when and why it doesn't work for students like me, here's who else is affected, and here's what would solve it."

Where it shows up

You don't need an official "civic" occasion to build these behaviors. They show up in the ordinary spaces you're already part of.

A group disagrees about direction

Benchmark: You share your opinion and note that others have theirs.

Milestone: You listen to why others see it differently, and work toward something that reflects more than your own view.

A problem keeps coming back

Benchmark: You can describe the pattern and why it keeps happening.

Milestone: You use that understanding to plan a different approach, for yourself or the group.

Something isn't working

Benchmark: You know there are ways to raise concerns or suggest change.

Milestone: You build a specific case, grounded in what you've noticed, and bring it somewhere it can be heard.

You notice what others miss

Benchmark: You mention it in passing, if at all.

Milestone: You connect what you noticed to other knowledge and perspectives, and use it to make your point land.

PATHFINDER TIP

"Civic" doesn't have to mean "official." Every time you engage thoughtfully with people who see things differently, understand how a shared system works, and make a grounded case for something better, you're practicing civic engagement, whether or not anyone calls it that.

In your own life

REFLECT

When was the last time you really listened to someone who saw a shared situation differently than you did?

What's one problem in a space you share (home, work, class, online) that keeps coming back?

If you had to make a case for one small change there, what would you say?

How it shows up later

This module spends some time on what "community" actually means, and you may find it's broader, and closer to home, than you expected. The skills behind Civic Engagement are available to you now, in the rooms you're already in. Civic Engagement is also an option for the fourth skill in your STAR(T) Stories.

Skill definition and Benchmark and Milestone indicators are based on the Kentucky Council on Postsecondary Education's Kentucky Graduate Profile (https://cpe.ky.gov/ourwork/kygradprofile.html).

LESSON 11.2

What Is Community, Really?

You're already in more communities than you think, and already shaping how they work.

You're already in more communities than you might think, and you're already shaping how they work.

In the last lesson, you looked at Civic Engagement and the official language behind it. This lesson is where that language stops sounding official and starts sounding like your actual life.

You're already in community

When people hear "community," they often picture something big and a little distant: a city, a cause, an organization you'd have to go join. That's one kind of community, and honestly, not the most useful one to start with.

Think about the spaces you're already part of:

- The people you live with
- The people you work with
- Your classes
- A team, club, or group chat
- Your neighborhood
- Online spaces and interest groups

Each of these is a community. You're in several at once, and you're already shaping how they work, through what you do, what you don't do, and what you let slide.

> **You don't have to go find community. You're already standing in it.**

Every community runs on a system

What doesn't get said often enough is that every one of those spaces runs on a system. Nobody necessarily designed it on purpose, but it's there anyway. A system, in this sense, has four parts:

- **People**

  Who's involved, and what role each person tends to play.

- **Rules**

  The official ones, and the unwritten ones everyone just... knows.

- **Influence**

  Who actually shapes what happens. It isn't always the person with the title.

- **Leverage points**

  The small things that, if they changed, would change a lot else.

Once you start looking for these four things, you see them everywhere. That skill helps with more than civic life in some abstract sense. It helps you navigate any group you're part of, starting today.

Worked example: the shared kitchen

Four people share a kitchen. The dishes pile up. Everyone's annoyed, but nobody's said anything.

People
All four are in this system, but they play different roles. Maya does dishes constantly, out of habit or because the mess bothers her most. Jordan doesn't notice the mess until someone points it out. Sam notices but figures someone else will get it. Alex is rarely home.

Rules, written and unwritten
The written rule might be "clean up after yourself" on a chore chart nobody follows. The *unwritten* rule running the show is closer to: whoever's most bothered by the mess will eventually deal with it. Nobody agreed to it. It just emerged, and everyone's behavior keeps it going.

Influence
Nobody's formally in charge. The person with the most real influence over whether this changes is probably Maya, not because she has authority, but because she's the one absorbing the cost, and she's most likely to shift it if she chooses to.

Leverage point
The obvious fix might seem like a new chore chart, but chore charts often fail because they don't touch the unwritten rule. A smaller move might work better: Maya saying, once, "Hey, I've been doing most of the dishes. Can we figure out a system together?" That makes the unwritten rule visible and gives the group a chance to choose a different one.

No big confrontation, no complaint to anyone. The leverage point was naming the pattern out loud, to the people already in the room.

Why this counts as civic engagement

Remember the Milestone description from the last lesson: *engages with others who represent different perspectives, through active listening, clear and responsive dialogue, and collaboration.* That's official language, written for a statewide rubric. But it describes exactly what happened in the kitchen. Maya didn't do anything political. She paid attention to how the situation looked to everyone, said something clear and direct, and opened the door to figuring it out together.

Seeing the system, noticing who has influence (including yourself), finding the leverage point, and acting on it without making it bigger than it needs to be: those are the skills civic engagement is pointing at. They scale. The same skills that help in a shared kitchen help in a workplace, a student organization, a neighborhood association, and, eventually, civic life in the broadest sense.

> **LOOK BACK AT**
>
> The 4C Check. Seeing a system clearly is the same move as Clarity and Context: step back and see what's actually going on before you react.

Your turn

Pick one community you're part of right now: a living situation, a job, a class, a team, a group chat. Then work through four questions.

1. **People**

   Who's involved, and what role does each person tend to play?

2. **Rules**

   What's one *unwritten* rule running the show, something everyone seems to know even though nobody agreed to it out loud?

3. **Influence**

   Who has the most real influence over how this community works? It might not be who you'd expect, and it might be you.

4. **Leverage point**

   If you wanted one small thing to work better, what's one small action that might shift it?

You don't need to act on any of this yet. For now, notice it, and write it down in Steps 1 and 2 of the Community Snapshot. You'll use it for Mile Marker #11.

AI Literacy BE Responsible

If you want a thinking partner

Talking the four questions through with an AI tool can help you notice patterns you hadn't put into words. Try: *"I'm trying to think through a group I'm part of: [describe it briefly, no names]. Ask me questions that help me notice the unwritten rules and who has influence."*

It's a thinking tool, not a way to skip the noticing. AI has no way to know what's really going on in your kitchen, your job, or your group chat. The community you pick, and what you notice about it, has to come from you.

If this kind of thinking interests you

People, rules, influence, and leverage points are a small taste of **systems thinking**: a way of looking at almost anything, from a household to a workplace to a city or an ecosystem, and asking how its parts connect and influence each other. You don't need to study it further for this course, but if the kitchen example clicked, systems thinking is a real field with a lot more to explore, and it shows up in areas from environmental science to organizational design to public policy.

Next, you'll turn this lens on yourself: what you have to offer the communities you're part of, and on what terms.

LESSON 11.3

Your Strengths, Your Community

Putting what you know about yourself to work.

You already know more about yourself than you've had a chance to use. This lesson is about putting it to work.

Everything you've already figured out

This semester, you've built up a surprising amount of self-knowledge, usually one piece at a time, in different modules, for different reasons. Put together, it looks like this:

Career Coach (Module 6): the kinds of work and environments that interest you

HIGH5 (Module 7): your top strengths, what you're naturally good at and energized by

The Values Card Sort (Module 7): what actually matters to you, when you get specific

Your Collaboration Snapshot (Module 10): how you work with others, and what you need from a team

The last lesson: a lens for seeing how communities actually work

Most of the time these stay separate: a result here, a reflection there. This lesson puts them in the same room, because together they help you decide how *you* want to show up in your communities, on terms that fit who you are.

> LOOK BACK AT
>
> My Values Snapshot
>
> Mile Marker #7: My Strengths Snapshot

Why "I don't have time" is usually half the story

If you've ever been invited to get involved in something (a club, a volunteer opportunity, a cause you cared about) and said "I just don't have time," you're not alone, and you're probably not lying. But time is often the easy answer, because the real one is more complicated: *I don't know what I'd be walking into, I don't want to let people down, and I'm worried I'd end up doing something I'd dread.*

That's a normal reaction to stepping into a system you can't see yet, which is what the last lesson was about. And if not knowing the system is part of what makes it hard, having your own terms clear going in makes a real difference.

What I have to offer, and what I don't

Before you say yes, or no, to getting more involved in something, know two things about yourself:

What I have to offer

Based on your actual strengths, values, and interests. Not what you think you're "supposed" to offer.

What I'm not available for

At least for now, at least at first. A limit, a role you don't want, a kind of task that drains you.

Naming both *before* you're in the middle of something changes the whole experience. Instead of slowly discovering your limits, and maybe feeling guilty about them, you walk in with your terms already clear, to yourself and often to the people you're working with.

Worked example: Jordan and the community garden

Jordan has always liked the idea of a local community garden. A friend says the garden needs volunteers and invites Jordan to the next meeting.

The first reaction
"I don't really have time for a whole commitment right now." That's true; Jordan is busy. But sitting with it longer, Jordan notices something else: they're picturing being asked to run a whole section, show up every single week, or be the new person who has to figure out a system nobody explains. None of that has been asked. It's what Jordan is bracing for.

What Jordan has to offer
Jordan's Module 7 results include being a steady, reliable presence and someone who notices small details, and one of their top values is being outdoors and connected to something growing. So Jordan's honest offer: "I can show up every other Saturday morning. I'm good at consistent, hands-on tasks like weeding and watering."

What Jordan isn't available for
"I don't want an organizing or leadership role right now. I have too much going on this semester. I'd rather just show up and do the work."

> Jordan says something close to this at the meeting, as an honest starting point, not a list of demands. The garden needs exactly that: reliable people doing hands-on work on a predictable schedule. Jordan wouldn't have known it was a fit, or felt comfortable saying yes, without getting clear first.

Your turn

Go back to the community from the last lesson, or pick a different one, including something you'd like to get more involved in.

1. ### What I have to offer

   Based on your strengths, values, and interests, what's something real you could bring to this community? Not what you think you "should" offer, but something that fits you.

2. ### What I'm not available for

   What's one thing you'd want to be upfront about, rather than discovering it later?

3. ### Saying it out loud

   How would it feel to say both of these before getting more involved?

Write your answers in Step 3 of the Community Snapshot.

> **ONLINE SECTIONS**
> The Getting the Call journal in Blackboard lets you try this on a new scenario: a group connected to something you care about reaches out to *you*.

AI Literacy BE Reflective

If you want a thinking partner

Try: *"Here's what I know about my strengths and values: [list them]. I'm thinking about getting more involved in [describe the group, no names]. Help me think through what I could genuinely offer, and what I might want to be upfront about not being available for."*

Then check what comes back against what you know about yourself. Does it sound like you? The mix of strengths, values, and limits that's true for you has to come from you.

Your stories are already here

The rest of this module is your working time for your STAR(T) Stories. Everything you've pulled together here (strengths, values, interests, and how you see your communities and your place in them) is exactly what those stories are made of. The next Trail Tip shows you where to start.

TRAIL TIP

Start Your STAR(T) Stories

This module is your working time. Here's the short path.

This module is your working time for your STAR(T) Stories. The best time to start is now.

You'll tell four STAR(T) Stories for your capstone. The earlier you get one done, the easier the rest get, because you'll already know what the process feels like. Everything you need is in the STAR(T) Stories Guide. This is the short path through it.

Three steps to start

1. ### Gather your Mile Markers

   Your best stories are probably already written down. Find the Mile Markers you submitted in Blackboard, or the PDFs you saved. Forms in this book only save in the browser on the device you used, so if you switched devices, Blackboard has your copies.

2. ### Choose your four skills

   Three are assigned: Adaptability & Leadership, Professionalism, and Knowledge Application. The fourth is your choice. Prompts for every skill will help you find the moment that fits each one. You'll name all four in Question 4 of Mile Marker #11.

3. ### Draft one story, then say it out loud

   Pick the story you feel surest about and work through its practice guide. Then read it out loud once. When you're ready, Tell It Out Loud walks you through recording in Blackboard.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> Recording is strongly encouraged, because "Tell me about a time when..." is exactly what you'll hear in job interviews. Stories are never scored on delivery, only on the story and its structure.

MILE MARKER

Mile Marker #11: My Community Impact

The assignment, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

Your community is bigger than you think, and you're already part of how it works.

This module asked you to notice the communities you're already part of, and to look at how each one works, including where you have influence. This Mile Marker asks you to put that into words, then name the four skills your STAR(T) Stories will show. Keep it short and honest.

What you'll do

1. **Before you start,** fill in your Community Snapshot.
   - Community Snapshot (it has most of what you need for Questions 1 to 3)
2. **Answer four questions** in the form below.
3. **Save as PDF** and upload it to the **Mile Marker #11** assignment in Blackboard.

●○ AI use: AI-supported

You may use AI as a thinking partner to make your reflection more specific. Your final responses must be in your own words. Leave out your full name and other identifying details. See the AI Course Policy in the syllabus and Lesson 1.4: AI use labels.

Optional prompt to try: "I'm working on a short reflection about my community impact for a college course. Here's what I have so far for where I show up, how I make a difference, and how I want to grow that going forward: [paste your notes]. Can you ask me a few questions to help me make this more specific?" Use what's useful. Your final responses must be in your own words.

Your Mile Marker

Type your answers in the boxes. Your typing is saved in this browser as you go, so you can come back later on the same device. Nothing is sent anywhere until you upload it.

Your name (required) | **Date**

Part I: Your Community Impact

QUESTION 1

Where You Show Up

Think back to the community you worked with in this module, or pick another one that fits better now. **Community word bank:** family · friends · roommates · classmates · coworkers · neighbors · online groups or gaming communities · faith or cultural groups · customer service or caregiving roles · teams, clubs, or interest groups. Example: "My job. I work the front desk at a campus office. I'm usually the first person someone talks to, so I try to make sure people feel heard even when I can't fix their problem myself."

A STRONG ANSWER

Names **one real community**, describes **your role**, and gives a **specific example** of how you already show up.

1. Name the community, and describe your role in it.

2. Describe how you already show up or contribute, even in small, everyday ways.

Look back at: Lesson 11.2: You're already in community

QUESTION 2

Your Influence, Named

Use what you practiced in this module: noticing the people, rules, and influence in a system. Small and real is exactly right. **Impact word bank:** being reliable · supporting others · encouraging someone · helping someone understand something · practicing patience · speaking up in discussions · leading in small ways · being a good roommate · showing up consistently · noticing what others miss.

A STRONG ANSWER

Describes **one specific action** and **the difference it makes**, connected to something you noticed about how the community works.

1. Describe one specific way you've made, or could make, a positive difference in that community.

Look back at: The shared kitchen example

QUESTION 3

Looking Ahead

As your circles grow (new classes, jobs, programs, organizations), how do you want to show up more intentionally?

A STRONG ANSWER

Names **one intention**, connects it to a **specific strength or value**, and names a **first step** you could take.

1. Name one way you want to show up more intentionally, and the strength or value from Module 7 it connects to.

2. Name one realistic first step you could take.

Look back at: Lesson 11.3: Your offer and your boundary; Mile Marker #7

Part II: Your Four STAR(T) Skills

QUESTION 4

Choose Your Stories

Look back through your Mile Markers and your life this semester. For each skill, name the experience you plan to tell, in a phrase or a sentence. Use a different experience for each. Example: "Professionalism: the week my car broke down and I still got every assignment in by arranging rides and emailing my instructor ahead of time."

A STRONG ANSWER

Names a **real, specific experience** for each skill, uses a **different experience** for each, and explains **why you chose your fourth skill**.

1. Adaptability & Leadership: my experience

2. Professionalism: my experience

3. Knowledge Application: my experience

4. Choose your fourth skill.

Circle one: #1 Communication / #2 Critical & Creative Thinking / #3 Quantitative Reasoning / #4 Interpersonal Relations / #7 Civic Engagement / #8 Collaboration & Teamwork / #10 Information Literacy

5. Your choice skill: my experience

6. Explain why you chose this skill, in two or three sentences.

Look back at: Prompts for every skill in the STAR(T) Stories Guide

Submit it

Upload your PDF to the **Mile Marker #11** assignment in Blackboard. Check Blackboard for the due date.

In an in-person class? Your instructor may give you a printed copy. Fill it in by hand, then upload a photo or scan.

How it's scored: full credit means every prompt is answered, and each answer is about you, with at least one real detail. See How Mile Markers are scored.

WRAP UP

Module 11 Wrap Up

Pull it together before you head back to your course.

You've reached the end of Module 11. These are the ideas to carry forward.

Key takeaways

You're already in community. Home, work, class, teams, and online spaces all count, and you're already shaping how they work.

Every community runs on a system. Look for the people, the rules (especially the unwritten ones), who has influence, and the leverage points.

Small and real beats big and vague. Naming a pattern out loud, to the people already in the room, is civic engagement too.

Know your offer and your boundary. Say what you can bring, and what you're not available for, before you get more involved.

Your stories are already here. Pick your four STAR(T) skills, draft one, and say it out loud.

REFLECT

Which of your four STAR(T) Stories are you most ready to tell, and which one needs the most work?

That's Module 11.

Head back to your course in Blackboard for this module's activities.

MODULE 12

Reflecting Back, Moving Forward

The last mile marker on the trail, and a look at everything you've built along the way.

10 ESSENTIAL SKILLS IN THIS MODULE


#1 Communication


#5 Adaptability & Leadership


#6 Professionalism


#9 Knowledge Application

Why this matters

This is the last module of new content. From here, it's about finishing strong: completing your STAR(T) Stories, taking stock of how far you've come, and getting ready for the rest of the semester.

Your STAR(T) Stories are your capstone: four true stories that show what you've built, in your own voice. Mile Marker #12 is short on purpose, so you can spend most of your time on them.

What you'll be able to do

By the end of this module:

A

I can record four STAR(T) responses, one per selected Essential Skill, that are specific, honest, and clearly structured.

B

I can articulate how each skill connects to my future in college, my career, and my life: the Transfer step.

C

I can explain my choice of student-selected skill in my own words.

D

I can reflect honestly on my growth this semester, what I am taking with me, and what I want to work on next.

AI Literacy: BE behaviors in this module

- BE Honest
- BE Reflective

Your STAR(T) Stories bring all ten skills together: three assigned, and one you choose.

Lessons in this module

Trail Tool: Look Back

Your Mile Markers in one place, and room to notice what stands out.

12.1 Finish Your STAR(T) Stories

Final review, and how to submit your capstone.

Trail Tip: Finishing Strong

FYE 100 may end before your other classes do. Here's how to finish the semester.

Mile Marker: Mile Marker #12: My Story to Share

Your final reflection, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

Wrap Up: Module 12 Wrap Up

You've walked the whole trail.

TRAIL TOOL

Look Back

Your Mile Markers in one place, and room to notice what stands out.

Before you write your final reflection, take a quick look back at the trail.

You don't need to reread everything. Skim your Mile Markers, notice what stands out, and jot it down here. Then use it for Mile Marker #12 and your STAR(T) Stories.

WHERE ARE MY ANSWERS?

Forms in this book save only in the browser on the device you used. If you switched devices, your submitted Mile Markers are in Blackboard, along with any PDFs you saved.

Your Mile Markers

- #1 My Starting Point
- #2 My Support Team
- #3 Managing My Time & Energy
- #4 My Academic Toolkit
- #5 Understanding My Money
- #6 My Academic Plan
- #7 My Strengths Snapshot
- #8 My Career Snapshot
- #9 Think It Through
- #10 My Collaboration Profile
- #11 My Community Impact

Fill in your look back

Your answers save in this browser as you go. Select **Save as PDF** to keep a copy.

Your name (required) | **Date**

STEP 1

Then and now

Open Mile Marker #1 and compare.

Then: what success meant to me

Now: what success means to me

Then: my goal for the semester

Now: how it went

Then: where I stood on AI

Now: where I stand on AI

STEP 2

What stands out

Skim your Mile Markers. A few words for each is plenty.

Challenges I worked through (and which Mile Marker)

Habits that improved (and which Mile Marker)

Academic or personal wins (and which Mile Marker)

Skills I strengthened (and which Mile Marker)

Shifts in my confidence or mindset (and which Mile Marker)

LESSON 12.1

Finish Your STAR(T) Stories

Final review, and how to submit your capstone.

This is the module to finish and submit your four STAR(T) Stories.

If you started in Module 11, you're most of the way there. Use this module to finish any remaining stories, give all four a final review, and turn them in. Your stories are your capstone: four true stories that show what you've built this semester, in your own voice.

> **LOOK BACK AT**
>
> Mile Marker #11, Question 4, where you named your four skills and stories

Where you are

Open each practice guide and see where that story stands. Then spend your time on the ones that need it most.

- 

Adaptability & Leadership
- 

Professionalism
- 

Knowledge Application
- ?Your choice

Each skill opens its practice guide in the STAR(T) Stories Guide, where you can finish your draft and check how long it runs out loud.

Final review

Before you submit, run each story through this list.

All five steps are there. Situation, Task, Action, Result, and Transfer.

The Action is yours. You say "I," not just "we," and you name what you actually did.

The skill is evident, not just stated. Someone listening could name the skill even if you didn't.

The Transfer is specific. You say how and where this skill shows up next: your next classes, a job, your life, rather than "this will help me."

It sounds like you. Not a template, and not AI-generated.

Your fourth story explains your choice. Start it by naming the skill and why you chose it.

LOOK BACK AT

What Makes a Strong Story, with three fixes that move a story up

The 4C Check on a draft

Submitting your stories

- Submit each story in its own portal, in the **Capstone module**'s CAPSTONE SUBMISSION PORTALS folder in Blackboard. Check Blackboard for the due date. Your Capstone Assignment has the full picture.
- Recording is strongly encouraged, video or audio only. Tell It Out Loud walks you through it. Writing one instead? Use its practice guide so you cover all five steps, save it as a PDF, and upload it. You can mix and match.
- Recordings are never scored on delivery, only on the story and its structure.

PATHFINDER TIP

Say each story out loud once before you record it. The preparation matters more than the recording.

AI Literacy BE Honest BE Reflective

Your stories, your voice

AI can ask you questions that help you remember details or tighten a step. It can't know what happened to you, and a story AI wrote won't sound like you, because it isn't.

Use AI the way the assignment's AI use label allows, and tell the story yourself.

TRAIL TIP

Finishing Strong

FYE 100 may end before your other classes do. Here's how to finish the semester.

FYE 100 ends before your other courses do. Finish the rest of the semester the way you finished this one.

Once your STAR(T) Stories are in, you're done with FYE 100. Your other classes keep going, often through finals. A few things to keep in mind for that stretch:

Heading into finals

1. ### Check every syllabus now

   Finals look different across classes. Some are a single test, some are comprehensive, and some are a final paper or project. Find out what each one is, and when, so nothing catches you off guard.

2. ### Go back to your time plan

   The time and energy strategies from Module 3 matter most in the final stretch of the semester. Map your week, and watch your batteries.

3. ### Use your support team

   FYE 100 has ended, but you can keep working with your Success Coach. The people and resources from Module 2 are still available, too. Asking for help at the end of the semester is exactly as valid as asking at the beginning. The Lookout below lists decisions your coach can help with now.

4. ### Know your grades

   Check where you stand in each class, and what a final can and can't change. The grades Trail Tip shows how to figure it out. If a final can't raise your grade enough, talk with your Success Coach about your next steps.

Lookout: Ask Your Success Coach



Several big decisions come up near the end of the semester. Talk with your Success Coach before finals start, while you have the most options. Your coach can help with:

- **Withdrawing from a course**, and what it would mean for your plan and your financial aid
- **Asking an instructor about an incomplete**, if something outside your control has kept you from finishing
- **What a final grade means for your program**, if your program has admission or grade requirements
- **Registering for next semester**, if you haven't yet

Not sure who your coach is? Lesson 2.2 shows you how to find them.

> **LOOK BACK AT**
>
> My Week at a Glance
>
> Lesson 4.2: Study Strategies That Actually Work

You've made it through a full Pathfinder journey. Finish this last stretch the same way: one step at a time.

MILE MARKER

Mile Marker #12: My Story to Share

Your final reflection, with support, and a form you can fill in and save.

The last Mile Marker on the trail, and the one only you could write.

You started the semester with a reflection on where you were. This one is about where you are now, and what you'd want to pass along to someone just starting out. This module is your main working time for finishing your STAR(T) Stories, so this Mile Marker is intentionally short. Be honest, and let it be what it is.

What you'll do

1. **Before you start,** skim your Mile Markers from Modules 1 through 11. Notice challenges you worked through, habits that improved, wins, skills you strengthened, and shifts in your confidence or in how you think about AI.
   - Look Back (your Mile Markers in one list, with room to jot down what stands out)
2. **Answer four questions** in the form below.
3. **Save as PDF** and upload it to the **Mile Marker #12** assignment in Blackboard.

●○ AI use: AI-supported

You may use AI to ask you questions that help you remember and get specific. Your reflection must be in your own words. AI wasn't there for your semester. You were. Leave out your full name and other identifying details. See the AI Course Policy in the syllabus and Lesson 1.4: AI use labels.

Optional prompt to try: "I'm writing a final reflection for a first-year college success course. Interview me about my semester, one question at a time, and wait for my answer before you ask the next one. Help me think about four things: how I've grown since the start of the semester, what I wish I'd known at the start and one habit I'll keep, what I'd tell a new student, and one area where I still want to grow. When my answer is vague, ask a follow-up that helps me get more specific. Don't write my reflection for me." Use what's useful. Your final responses must be in your own words.

Your Mile Marker

Type your answers in the boxes. Your typing is saved in this browser as you go, so you can come back later on the same device. Nothing is sent anywhere until you upload it.

Your name (required) **Date**

QUESTION 1

Growth

Open your Mile Marker #1 and compare. If your thinking about AI has changed since then, you can include that too. Example: "I used to put off everything until the last minute. Tracking my time in Module 3 showed me where my hours were going, and I've kept using a weekly schedule since then."

A STRONG ANSWER

Names **two or three specific changes** and **compares them to where you started**.

1. Name two or three specific ways you've grown this semester, academically, personally, or professionally.

Look back at: Mile Marker #1: My Starting Point

QUESTION 2

Lessons Learned

Example: "I wish I'd known how many resources were on campus. I didn't ask for help for weeks because I didn't know who to ask. I'm keeping the 4C Check for big decisions."

A STRONG ANSWER

Names **one real lesson** and **one habit, strategy, or tool** you'll keep, and says why.

1. What do you know now that you wish you'd known at the start of the semester?

2. Name one habit, strategy, or tool from this course that you'll actually keep using, and why.

QUESTION 3

Words of Wisdom

Example: "Don't wait until you're overwhelmed to use the support that's already around you. It's there the whole time."

A STRONG ANSWER

Sounds like you, and comes from **something you actually lived** this semester.

1. Write a short message to who you were in the first week, or to a future FYE 100 student.

QUESTION 4

Still Growing

Example: "I still freeze up when I have to talk to an instructor. Next step: go to one office hour in my math class before finals."

A STRONG ANSWER

Names **one honest area** and a **next step you could put on your calendar**.

1. Name one area where you still want to grow.

---

2. Name one concrete next step you'll take.

Submit it

Upload your PDF to the **Mile Marker #12** assignment in Blackboard. Check Blackboard for the due date.

In an in-person class? Your instructor may give you a printed copy. Fill it in by hand, then upload a photo or scan.

Rather talk it through? You can record your reflection instead, as video or audio, in the assignment.

How it's scored: full credit means every prompt is answered, and each answer is about you, with at least one real detail. See How Mile Markers are scored.

WRAP UP

Module 12 Wrap Up

You've walked the whole trail.

You've walked the whole trail.

You started this semester reflecting on where you were. You're finishing it with four true stories about what you can do, in your own voice.

What you're taking with you

A support team. People and places to go when things get hard, and the words to ask.

A way to plan your time and energy. Map the week, and watch your batteries.

A plan and a direction. Your program, your next courses, and a career you've researched.

Words for who you are. Your strengths, your values, how you work with others, and what you bring to your communities.

Tools for thinking. SIFT for information, the 4C Check for decisions, and the judgment to use AI on your own terms.

Your stories. Four STAR(T) Stories you can tell in an interview, a scholarship conversation, or any time someone asks, "Tell me about a time when..."

ONE MORE THING

In Blackboard, take the **My Skills Snapshot** one more time and compare it to your answers from the start of the course. Where did you grow the most?

That's the trail.

The guides stay here whenever you need them: the STAR(T) Stories Guide for your next interview, and the Merit Guide for getting involved. Finish strong.

GUIDE

Merit Guide

Learning that happens outside class counts. This guide shows how to find it, and how to make it count for you.

About this guide

Merit activities run through the whole course, from setting up your Merit page early on to your third activity near the end. This guide keeps everything about them in one place, so you can come back to it whenever you need it.

Whether you take classes on campus or online, you'll find a path that works for you.

In this guide

1 How Merit Works in FYE 100

The requirement, what it's worth, and three activities paced across the course.

2 Setting Up Your Merit Page

Your Merit page is your official record of involvement and achievement at OCTC.

3 Find Your Activity

On campus, online, or in your community.

4 On-Demand Options

Approved options you can do from anywhere. Updated each semester.

5 Write Your Reflection

Going is the requirement. The reflection is where the learning happens.

Trail Tool: Merit Reflection

Draft it, count your words, and copy it into Blackboard.

PART 1

How Merit Works in FYE 100

The requirement, what it's worth, and three activities paced across the course.

Some of the most important learning in college happens outside class.

Merit activities are your chance to step into it: a campus event, a workshop, a community gathering, something you wouldn't have tried otherwise. You'll complete **three Merit-approved activities** of your choice during the course. After each one, you'll write or record a short reflection on what you experienced and why it matters.

The requirement

Merit is a required part of FYE 100: **three Merit-approved activities, each worth 5 points**, for 15 points of your course grade.

Each activity earns its points when you do all three of these:

Go to a Merit-approved activity. On campus, online, or in your community.

Submit it the way the instructions say, to the matching Merit Activity submission portal in Blackboard, with the event name and date, and proof if your activity needs it.

Respond to the reflection prompts. Going is the requirement. Your points come from the reflection.

MERIT AND YOUR GRADE

Without your three Merit activities, the highest grade you can earn in FYE 100 is an **85/B**, and that's only with a perfect score on everything else. Each missed activity costs 5 points.

Each activity has its own due date, and those dates are real deadlines. Plan ahead: you'll have the most options to choose from early in the semester, and fewer as the semester winds down.

Three activities, paced across the course

Each activity is due with a module: Merit #1 with Module 4, Merit #2 with Module 7, and Merit #3 with Module 10. You can always go earlier than its due date.

1. Merit #1By Module 4Start exploring early
2. Merit #2By Module 7Try something new
3. Merit #3By Module 10Stretch yourself

Each activity has its own submission portal in Blackboard: Merit Activity #1, #2, and #3. Check Blackboard for the due dates, and make sure you use the portal that matches the activity.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> Put a reminder in your calendar two weeks before each Merit checkpoint. That's enough time to find an activity that interests you.

How it works, start to finish

1. ### Set up your Merit page

   Do this once, early. It's where OCTC records your involvement. Setting Up Your Merit Page walks you through it.

2. ### Find an activity

   On campus, online, or in your community. Find Your Activity shows your options and what proof each one needs.

3. ### Go, and pay attention

   Notice what you learn, who you meet, and what surprises you. Jot down the event name and date.

4. ### Reflect and submit

   Write or record a short reflection and submit it to the matching Merit Activity submission portal in Blackboard. Write Your Reflection shows what to include.

What counts, and what doesn't

Merit is about stepping into something new.

Counts

- Merit-approved campus events
- Approved virtual or on-demand activities
- Community or off-campus events your instructor approves before you go
- Something that stretches you: a new place, new people, a new idea

Doesn't count

- Things already part of your regular routine, like a standing weekly commitment
- Your usual work shifts
- Events you would have attended anyway
- Community events approved after the fact

Why it matters

Students who get involved outside class tend to feel more connected to their college, and connected students are more likely to keep going. Merit activities are also where you meet people you wouldn't meet in class: staff, employers, community members, other students.

And your reflections become evidence. When you build your STAR(T) Stories at the end of the course, a Merit activity can be exactly the kind of real, specific experience you need.

LOOK BACK AT

The STAR(T) Stories Guide explains the capstone.

PART 2

Setting Up Your Merit Page

Your Merit page is your official record of involvement and achievement at OCTC.

Merit is OCTC's official student recognition platform.

It tracks your accomplishments, activities, and achievements throughout your time at OCTC, including the Merit activities for this course. Setting up your page takes less than ten minutes.

CAN'T GET IN YET? THAT'S NORMAL.

OCTC's Student Affairs office adds students to Merit **after the add/drop period ends**. If your invitation hasn't arrived, or your login doesn't work yet, wait a day or two and try again.

Still stuck after that? Let your instructor know. They'll follow up with the Student Affairs office for you.

What your Merit page does for you

Celebrates your involvement

Documents your participation in campus and community life beyond the classroom.

Builds your digital presence

A professional profile you can share with family, employers, and future programs.

Tracks your activities

A single place to record the events and activities you take part in, including the ones your courses ask for.

Set up your page

1 Check for your invitation email

Look in your KCTCS email for an invitation with this subject line:

"Claim Your Merit Page at Owensboro Community & Technical College"

Open it and select **Claim My Page**.

> **DIDN'T GET THE EMAIL?**
>
> Go to owensboro-kctcs.meritpages.com (https://owensboro-kctcs.meritpages.com/), select **Sign In**, then **Forgot Password**, and enter your KCTCS student email to activate your account.

2 Claim and personalize your page

Once you're logged in, take a few minutes to make it yours:

1. Add a profile photo (optional, but encouraged).
2. Review your bio and update your academic program, hometown, and goals.
3. Link your LinkedIn profile if you have one.
4. Review any preloaded achievements, such as Dean's List or program awards.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
>
> Keep your Merit page professional: a friendly photo, proper capitalization, and short, clear sentences. Think college résumé, not social media.

3 Stay connected

After you claim your page, you'll get notifications automatically when:

- You attend a Merit-approved event
- You're recognized for an achievement or milestone
- OCTC adds new updates

Keep an eye on your KCTCS email for Merit updates.

4

Find and customize your profile URL

Merit assigns your page a web address when you claim it. To make it easier to share, go to **My Account → Merit Page Settings**. You can personalize the address and add profile and background photos there.

Examplehttps://meritpages.com/yourname

PATHFINDER TIP

Copy your Merit page address and save it somewhere handy. You'll need it whenever you're asked to share your page.

Helpful links

- OCTC Merit home page (https://owensboro-kctcs.meritpages.com/)
- KCTCS student email login (MyPath) (https://mypath.kctcs.edu/)

Merit helps you track and share your growth, so set it up now while it only takes a few minutes.

PART 3

Find Your Activity

On campus, online, or in your community.

There are three ways to find a Merit activity. Which one fits best depends on where and how you take this course.

If you're on campus regularly, campus events are the easiest and most connected option, and that's really what Merit is for. If you take your classes online, you can still come to campus events, and there are online, on-demand, and community options too.

Your three paths

On campus

Best for: in-person students, and anyone who can come to campus

- Look for the **Merit badge** on campus flyers and OCTC social media posts.
- Check the current listing your instructor posts in Blackboard.
- Bring your **student ID**. Your attendance is recorded on your Merit page.

Proof: none to upload. Include the event name and date in your reflection so it can be checked against the event roster.

Online or on demand

Best for: online students, or anyone whose schedule makes campus events hard

- Virtual workshops and on-demand sessions that are approved for Merit.
- Options change each semester. See On-Demand Options for what's available now.

Proof: attach a screenshot, confirmation, or certificate of completion.

In your community

Best for: anyone who finds something worthwhile close to home

- A community event, workshop, or volunteer opportunity you find yourself.
- **Get your instructor's approval before you go.** Approval isn't given afterward.

Proof: attach brief proof, like a photo, flyer, or confirmation.

Getting a community event approved

Found something on your own? Message your instructor through Blackboard **before the event**. Include:

The name of the event

The date and where it is

A sentence or two about what it is and why you want to go

Remember, Merit is about something new. Your regular routine, your usual work shifts, and events you'd attend anyway don't count.

> **PATHFINDER TIP**
> Ask early. If you wait until the day before, your instructor may not see your message in time.

> Example: asking for approval
> Hi Professor [Last Name],
>
> I'd like to use an event for Merit Activity #2. It's the [event name] at [place] on [date]. It's a [short description], and I want to go because [your reason]. Would this count?
>
> Thank you,
> [Your name], FYE 100 section [number]

Proof at a glance

Type of activity	What to submit with your reflection
Campus Merit event	No file. Include the event name and date.

Type of activity	What to submit with your reflection
Virtual or on-demand	A screenshot, confirmation, or certificate of completion.
Community or off-campus	Approval before the event, then a photo, flyer, or confirmation.

Every submission needs the **event name and date**, no matter which path you choose.

PART 4

On-Demand Options

Approved options you can do from anywhere. Updated each semester.

Can't make it to campus? These options count toward Merit, too.

On-demand and virtual options are mainly for online students, but anyone can use them. What's available changes from semester to semester, so this page is updated regularly. Your instructor also posts the current Merit listing in Blackboard, and that listing is always the final word.

What's available

Career readiness

Career Services workshops (https://owensboro.kctcs.edu/current-students/experiential-learning-center/index.aspx)

OCTC Career Services

Workshops each semester on resumes, interviewing, and career readiness. Some are virtual or on demand.

▶ How to start and what to submit

Learning online

KOOL Online Orientation (https://alt-5beddfe10b70f.blackboard.com/bbcswebdav/institution/KOOL_Training/Student%20Orientation/content/index.html?one_hash=ACD7EA11670AA61E8BE57DCCCDFC0042&f_hash=13455CECB6D1CBCDC3FF1CAE187CD407#/)

KCTCS

A self-paced orientation to learning online, built for students across KCTCS.

▶ How to start and what to submit

AI literacy

GenAI Literacy 101 for Students (https://www.aiforeducation.io/genai-literacy-101-for-students-course)

AI for Education · About 2 hours

Five short, free lessons on how generative AI works, prompting it well, spotting its mistakes, and writing your own code for using it.

▶ How to start and what to submit

Making an on-demand activity count

Make sure it's approved. Use an option on this page or on your instructor's Merit listing. Found something else online? Ask your instructor before you start.

Save your proof as you go. Take a screenshot of the confirmation or the last screen, or save your certificate.

Give it your full attention. An on-demand session is only as useful as the attention you bring to it. Your reflection will show the difference.

Reflect and submit. Include the session name and the date you completed it, and attach your proof.

LOOK AHEAD

Write Your Reflection

PART 5

Write Your Reflection

Going is the requirement. The reflection is where the learning happens.

Going is the requirement. The reflection is where the learning happens.

Your reflection is short on purpose: a few honest sentences about what the experience meant to you, not a report on what happened.

Choose your format

Pick one. Either way, start with the **event name and date**.

Written

50 to 100 words, typed into the Merit submission box in Blackboard.

The Merit Reflection tool counts your words and lets you copy your reflection straight into Blackboard.

Audio or video

1 to 2 minutes. Use the Blackboard recorder, upload an MP4, or share a OneDrive or YouTube link.

Talking it through is a great way to practice telling a story out loud, just like your STAR(T) Stories.

Answer all three

1. **What did you attend, and what did you do or experience?**

   Name it and describe it briefly. One or two sentences is enough.

2. **What did you learn, or how did it make you think differently?**

   This is the heart of it. Be specific: one idea, one moment, one thing you didn't know before.

3. **How does this connect to your personal, academic, or career goals?**

   Make the link real. Which goal, and how?

What a strong reflection sounds like

This made-up example, about 85 words, answers all three.

> Example reflection
> *Career Services resume workshop, completed on [date].*
>
> I watched the on-demand resume workshop and rebuilt my resume while I followed along. I learned that my job at the grocery store counts as real experience if I describe what I actually did, like training new cashiers and handling closing counts. I'd been leaving it off because it didn't seem "professional." I'm applying for a pharmacy tech position next spring, and now I can show that I'm trusted with money and with teaching others.

WHY IT WORKS

It names one specific thing learned, says what changed in the student's thinking, and connects to a real goal. "It was helpful and made me think" doesn't do any of that.

How it's scored

Going to the activity is the requirement, but your credit is based on the reflection.

Level	What it looks like
Full credit	Specific and honest. Answers all three prompts with real personal insight or connection. Sounds like you.
Partial credit	Shows effort but is brief, vague, or general, or skips one of the prompts.
No credit	Missing, off-topic, not reflective, or no qualifying activity.

Before you submit

- [ ] I'm using the **right Merit Activity submission portal** in Blackboard: #1, #2, or #3.
- [ ] I included the **event name and date**.
- [ ] I attached **proof** if my activity needs it (virtual, on-demand, or community).
- [ ] I answered **all three** prompts, in my own words.

LOOK BACK AT

Proof at a glance

Try it: the Merit Reflection tool

Three boxes for the three prompts, a word count, and a button that copies your reflection for Blackboard.

Open the Merit Reflection tool

TRAIL TOOL

Merit Reflection

Draft it, count your words, and copy it into Blackboard.

Draft your Merit reflection here, check your word count, then copy it into Blackboard.

Use this tool for all three Merit activities. When you finish one, copy or save it, then select **Clear my answers** to start the next.

LOOK BACK AT

Write Your Reflection for the prompts and an example.

Draft your reflection

Your draft saves in this browser as you go. It isn't sent anywhere until you paste it into Blackboard.

RECORDING INSTEAD?

Use these boxes as talking points, then record 1 to 2 minutes in Blackboard.

Your name (required)

Which activity?

Circle one: Merit Activity #1 / Merit Activity #2 / Merit Activity #3

THE ACTIVITY

What and when

Event or session name

Date

Type of activity

Circle one: Campus Merit event (no proof file needed) / Virtual or on-demand (attach proof) / Community event, approved first (attach proof)

Proof, if you need it, is attached separately in Blackboard.

YOUR REFLECTION

Answer all three

1. What did you attend, and what did you do or experience?

2. What did you learn, or how did it make you think differently?

3. How does this connect to your personal, academic, or career goals?

Words: 0 (aim for 50 to 100)

GUIDE

STAR(T) Stories Guide

Anyone can claim a skill. Your stories show it.

About this guide

Your capstone for FYE 100 is four STAR(T) Stories: short, true stories about times you showed four of the 10 Essential Skills. Each one follows the same five steps: Situation, Task, Action, Result, and Transfer.

You can record your stories, video or audio only, or write them. Recording is strongly encouraged, because "Tell me about a time when..." is exactly what you'll hear in job interviews, and telling your story out loud now is the best practice you can get. Recordings are never scored on delivery, only on the story and its structure.

Your four stories

- 

Adaptability & Leadership
- 

Professionalism
- 

Knowledge Application
- ?Your choice

In this guide

1 Your Capstone Assignment

Why it matters, what you'll turn in, and how it's scored.

2 The STAR(T) Framework

Five steps for telling the story of a skill you've actually built.

3 Find Your Stories

Four skills, four true stories. Here's how to pick them.

4 Tell It Out Loud

Why recording is worth it, and how to do it in 2 to 4 minutes.

5 What Makes a Strong Story

How stories are scored, and three fixes that move a story up.

Trail Tool: Practice Guide: Adaptability & Leadership

Find your story and draft it, one step at a time.

Trail Tool: Practice Guide: Professionalism

Find your story and draft it, one step at a time.

Trail Tool: Practice Guide: Knowledge Application

Find your story and draft it, one step at a time.

Trail Tool: Practice Guide: Your Choice

Choose your skill, then draft your story.

PART 1

Your Capstone Assignment

Why it matters, what you'll turn in, and how it's scored.

Your capstone is four short, true stories. Each one shows a time you used one of the 10 Essential Skills.

You build them across the semester, and you turn in all four in Module 12.

Why this matters beyond FYE 100

Saying "I'm a hard worker" is easy. Showing it with a real story is what makes people believe you. You'll be asked for that kind of story again and again:

- **In job interviews.** Many employers ask behavioral questions that start with "Tell me about a time when..." A STAR story is the answer they're listening for.
- **In applications.** Scholarships, competitive programs like many health programs, and transfer applications often ask you to describe a real experience.
- **At work.** Performance reviews, promotions, and references all come down to examples of what you actually did.

The skills you'll show are the 10 Essential Skills, the same ones every public college in Kentucky, including OCTC, builds its programs around. By the end of this course you'll have four true stories, practiced out loud, that you can adapt for any of those moments.

What you'll turn in

Four STAR(T) Stories, one for each skill below. Every story uses all five steps: Situation, Task, Action, Result, and Transfer.

Story	The skill it shows
1	#5 Adaptability & Leadership: adjusting when things changed, or stepping up when it mattered.
2	#6 Professionalism: following through, owning a mistake, or being someone others could count on.
3	#9 Knowledge Application: a time something you learned met a moment you needed it.
4	Your choice: any other Essential Skill. Start this story by naming the skill and why you chose it.

How to turn it in

Record it (strongly encouraged). Video or audio only, about 2 to 4 minutes. Recording is the best interview practice you can get, and it's never scored on delivery.

Or write it. Fill in that skill's practice guide so you cover all five steps, save it as a PDF, and upload it.

Mix and match. You can record some stories and write others.

One portal per story. In Blackboard, the Capstone module's CAPSTONE SUBMISSION PORTALS folder has one portal for each skill. Check Blackboard for the due date.

How you'll build it

You don't write all four at the end. Each piece comes up along the way.

When	What happens
Modules 3, 6, and 7	The Skill Spotlights for your three assigned skills: Professionalism, Knowledge Application, and Adaptability & Leadership. Start noticing stories that fit.
Module 9	You learn the STAR(T) framework and write your first draft in Mile Marker #9.
Module 11	Working time. Choose your four stories and start drafting in the practice guides.
Module 12	Finish, review, and submit all four.

How it's scored

All four stories are scored the same way, on the story and its structure. A strong story has all five steps, and each one is specific to you: your Action says what *you* did, your Result names something concrete, and your Transfer names a real situation ahead. What Makes a Strong Story has the full scale and three fixes that move a story up.

Your stories have to be yours. AI can help you brainstorm or ask you questions, but it can't tell your story.

Where to start

Read The STAR(T) Framework for the five steps, then Find Your Stories for help choosing. Each practice guide walks you through one story, one step at a time.

PART 2

The STAR(T) Framework

Five steps for telling the story of a skill you've actually built.

Anyone can claim a skill. A STAR(T) story shows it.

STAR comes from behavioral interviewing, the method many employers use when they want to know not just what you know, but what you've actually done. When an interviewer says "Tell me about a time when...", they're asking for a STAR story. "I'm a hard worker" is a claim. A specific story is evidence.

This course adds one more step, Transfer, the (T). It turns a good story into a reflection on where you're headed.

The five steps

1. S

Situation: set the scene

Briefly describe where you were and what was happening. Give just enough background for someone who wasn't there.

What was going on?

Watch out: don't linger. The Situation is setup, not the story.

2. T

Task: define your role

What were you responsible for? What were you trying to accomplish, and why was it yours to handle?

What did you need to do, and why was it on you?

Watch out: your task is your part, not the group's general goal.

3. A

Action: show what you did

The most important step. Use "I": I decided, I reached out, I applied, I chose. Describe what you did, not what the team did or what happened in general. The Action is where the skill lives.

What did you specifically do, step by step?

Watch out: "we" hides your contribution. Describe your part, even in a group effort.

4. R

Result: name the outcome

What happened because of what you did? Results don't have to be perfect. An honest, imperfect result is more believable than a vague positive one.

What happened, and what did it mean?

Watch out: "It went well" isn't a result. Name what changed.

5. T

Transfer: connect it forward

So what? What does this experience mean for your next semester, your career, or your life beyond college? This is what makes a STAR(T) story a reflection, not just a story.

What does this mean for what comes next?

Watch out: "This will help me in the future" isn't a Transfer. Say where, when, and how.

KEY TERM

Behavioral interview: a job interview built on "Tell me about a time when..." questions, where your past actions are the evidence.

WHY THE T?

Standard STAR ends with the Result, which is enough for an interview. Transfer shows you learned from the experience and know where you're taking it. It's the hardest step for most students, and the one that most sets a strong story apart.

What it looks like

Below is a complete STAR(T) story with Knowledge Application as the focus skill.



9 Example: Knowledge Application

Situation

I was working as a medical receptionist when a patient came in upset about a billing error. The front desk staff weren't sure how to handle it, and the office manager wasn't available.

Task

I needed to help with the patient's concern without making promises I couldn't keep, and without making things worse while we waited for the manager.

Action

I used what I'd learned in my Medical Billing course about how insurance claims are processed to explain what likely caused the problem. I pulled up her account, walked her through the codes that had been submitted, and explained what the next step in the review would be, without guessing at the outcome.

Result

The patient calmed down and agreed to wait for the manager to follow up with the insurance company. She thanked me for taking the time to explain what was happening instead of just telling her to wait.

Transfer

It showed me that what I'm learning in my Healthcare Administration program isn't just for passing tests. It's for moments like that one, when a real person needs someone who understands the system. I'm going to keep asking, in every course: what does this knowledge look like when it matters?

PATHFINDER TIP

Your story doesn't have to be dramatic. A quiet moment at work, in class, or with your family is exactly what STAR(T) is built for. Specific and honest beats impressive and polished.

PART 3

Find Your Stories

Four skills, four true stories. Here's how to pick them.

For most students, picking the right story is harder than telling it.

You need four stories, one for each skill. Three skills are assigned. The fourth is your choice. Your stories can come from this course, from work, from your family, or from your community, and they don't have to be dramatic. They have to be real, specific, and yours.

Your four skills

- 

  ### Adaptability & Leadership

  A time you adjusted when something changed, stepped up without being asked, or helped someone keep going when things got hard.

  Practice guide

- 

  ### Professionalism Course focus skill

  A time you followed through when it was hard, owned a mistake, managed competing responsibilities, or were someone others could count on.

  Practice guide

- 

  ### Knowledge Application Course focus skill

  A time you applied something you learned, in a class, at work, or through experience, to a real situation.

  Practice guide

- ?

  ### Your choice

  Any of the other seven skills. Begin by naming your skill and explaining in a sentence or two why you chose it.

Practice guide

Prompts for every skill

For the three assigned skills, these prompts help you find *which* moment fits. For the other seven, they're there to help something click. If one sparks a real memory, that might be your fourth story.

Assigned: find your moment

- 

Adaptability & Leadership Assigned

Adapting to changing circumstances, finding ways to work and thrive in different settings, and supporting others toward a shared goal.

Leadership doesn't have to mean team captain or club president. It also means leading your own life: making decisions, taking responsibility for your choices, or stepping up in a small way without anyone assigning you the role. Sometimes it's just becoming someone others quietly look to because of how you handled something.

Starting college is itself a major adjustment. Was there a moment early this semester when you had to adapt to something that caught you off guard? Or think about Module 3 (time and energy) or Module 10 (collaboration): when did something change unexpectedly, and how did you adjust? When did you lead yourself, or quietly help a group move forward?

- 

Professionalism Assigned

Acting with honesty and fairness, prioritizing tasks, managing time, taking initiative, and following through reliably.

At its core, professionalism is being someone others can rely on: doing what you said you'd do, acting with integrity, and staying aware of how your actions affect the people around you.

Think about Module 3 (your time plan) or Module 8 (your career snapshot). When did you follow through on something even though it was hard or inconvenient? When did your word matter to a classmate, coworker, or instructor, and you kept it? When did you balance what you wanted to do with what you knew was the responsible thing?

- 

Knowledge Application Assigned

Applying what you've learned, including academic knowledge, skills, and abilities, to real situations connected to your field or career direction.

It doesn't have to be a big "aha" moment. It can be something from a class showing up somewhere outside that class: a concept that clicked once you saw it in real life, or a skill from an assignment that turned out to be useful for something else.

Think about Module 6 (academic planning) or Module 8 (career exploration). When did something you learned in a class, or discovered about a career path, change how you thought about your future or what you did next?

Your choice: does one of these spark something?

- 

Communication Your choice

Listening, weighing different perspectives, and expressing your thoughts clearly, in writing, in conversation, or in a formal setting.

Real communication goes beyond the words. It includes listening, and being honest with yourself about *why* you're saying what you're saying: angling for something, nervous and filling space, or trying to control where a conversation goes.

When did you have a conversation you weren't looking forward to: asking for help, clearing up a misunderstanding, or explaining something to someone who saw it differently? Or when did you notice something about *how* you were communicating, and what was driving it?

- 

Critical & Creative Thinking Your choice

Evaluating information and assumptions to reach informed conclusions, and combining ideas in original ways to solve problems.

Part of this is being strategic instead of reactive. A lot of what competes for your attention is designed to provoke a quick reaction. Noticing that, and choosing your response anyway, is critical thinking too.

Think about Module 9's 4C Check or Module 4's SIFT method. When did you slow down and think something through instead of going with your first reaction? When did you notice emotion pulling you toward a quick conclusion, and step back?

- 

Quantitative Reasoning Your choice

Using data, numbers, and evidence to guide decisions and choose the best approach to a problem.

If "I'm bad at math" is your first reaction, you're probably using more math than you give yourself credit for: budgeting, fitting time between classes and shifts, adjusting a recipe, comparing prices.

Think about Module 5 (financial planning). When did looking at actual numbers (a budget, a schedule, a pattern you tracked) change a decision? Or when did you use numbers to figure something out in everyday life, even if you wouldn't have called it math?

- 

Interpersonal Relations Your choice

Showing self-awareness and appreciation for different perspectives, and working respectfully with others.

Think of this one as your own planet: what's going on with *you* in relationships, how you connect, and what you need. (Collaboration & Teamwork is the solar system: how you operate within a group.)

Think about Module 2 (your support system). When did you notice something about how you connect with people, or navigate a relationship that mattered to you?

- 

Civic Engagement Your choice

Taking part in activities, political, social, or otherwise, that address issues and benefit a shared community.

There's a saying often associated with Gandhi: "Be the change you want to see in the world." It doesn't have to mean something huge. It can mean noticing a gap in a community you're part of and helping close it.

Think about Module 11 and your Mile Marker #11. When were you part of that kind of change, even informally? Or how do you want to start being that kind of presence, building on your offer and boundary?

- 

Collaboration & Teamwork Your choice

Working effectively in teams, being an effective team member, and managing conflict constructively.

Where Interpersonal Relations is your own planet, this one is the solar system: how you operate within a group, and how everyone's orbits affect each other.

Think about Module 10 (your collaboration profile). Almost everyone has a group work story, and it's not always a good one. A project that went sideways often makes a *better* story than a smooth one, especially if you can point to something you did or learned because of it.

- 

Information Literacy Your choice

Identifying, evaluating, and responsibly using information to make decisions.

This one connects to Critical & Creative Thinking. Approaching information, especially news and what you see online, with healthy skepticism often means staying calm enough to evaluate it before reacting.

Think about Module 4, where you learned SIFT. When did you have to stop and check whether something was true or trustworthy before relying on it or reacting to it?

PATHFINDER TIP

You don't need a perfect match. If two or three prompts spark something, pick the one with the most specific, real memory attached. Specific beats impressive every time. You'll name your four in Mile Marker #11.

Mine your own work

You've been collecting stories all along. Before you start from scratch, look back at what you've already written.

Your Mile Markers. Each one asked you to reflect on something real: your time, your money, your plan, your strengths, your career research.

Your Merit reflections. Each activity was something new you stepped into.

Your life outside class. Work, family, caregiving, volunteering, a team, a hard season you got through. These count.

LOOK BACK AT

Mile Marker #1

Mile Marker #7

Mile Marker #8

The Merit Guide

Is it a good story?

A story is worth telling if you can say yes to these:

You did something. There's a clear Action that was yours, not just something that happened to you or your group.

It shows the skill. Someone listening could name the skill without you saying it.

Something changed. You can name a Result, even an imperfect one.

It points forward. You can see where this skill shows up next for you.

PATHFINDER TIP

Use a different story for each skill. One experience can show several skills, but four different stories show more of who you are.

PART 4

Tell It Out Loud

Why recording is worth it, and how to do it in 2 to 4 minutes.

You can type your stories. But if you can bring yourself to record them, even audio only, even nervous, you'll get something typing can't give you.

In a real interview, you'll be talking, not typing. Recording your STAR(T) Stories is the low-stakes version of that moment. Saying your story out loud, in a clear order, is the practice.

This isn't a public speaking class

Recordings are **not graded on delivery or presentation**. No one is scoring your eye contact, your voice, your lighting, or your camera. They're scoring your story and its structure. It only needs to be clear enough to follow.

If you stumble, keep going. Interviewers don't expect polish either. They listen for honesty, structure, and a clear point.

The rambling problem

Even experienced professionals ramble when they're nervous. They back up to add context, circle around the point, and suddenly realize they've talked for four minutes without reaching the Action. That's nerves, not a lack of preparation.

A tight two-minute story that hits all five steps beats a wandering seven-minute one every time. The fix is simple: **know your story before you hit record.** Read your practice guide out loud at least once. Know where each step starts and ends. Then trust the structure.

What 2 to 4 minutes looks like

1. Situation20 to 30 secondsTwo or three sentences. Don't linger.
2. Task15 to 20 secondsYour role or challenge, in a sentence or two.
3. Action60 to 90 secondsSpend most of your time here. Use "I."
4. Result20 to 30 secondsWhat specifically happened.
5. Transfer30 to 45 secondsWhere this skill shows up next.

PATHFINDER TIP

Practice once with a timer. Running long? Your Action or your Situation is doing too much. Trim the Situation first. Each practice guide also estimates how long your draft runs out loud.

Your options

Recording is strongly encouraged. Video gets you the most realistic interview practice, and audio only is excellent practice too. A written story is accepted. If you write yours, use your practice guide so you cover all five steps. You can mix and match: record some stories and write others.

Video, camera on

Closest to a real interview. Face a window for good light, and look at the camera, not the screen.

Audio only

Your voice, no video. Completely fine. A headphone mic often sounds better than your device's built-in one.

Record on your phone

Record, then upload. A good backup if the Blackboard recorder gives you trouble. Prop the phone steady, sideways for video.

Written story

Accepted, but recording is better practice. Fill in your practice guide so you cover all five steps, save it as a PDF, and upload it.

Recording in Blackboard

Blackboard has a built-in recorder, Video Studio. You don't need a separate account or download.

1. ### Open the submission box

   In the My STAR(T) Story submission portal for the skill you're submitting, find the **camera button** in the editor toolbar.

2. ### Choose camera or audio

   Allow your browser to use your camera or microphone when it asks.

3. ### Record

   Select Start Recording. There's a short countdown. You can pause, resume, or retake as you go.

4. ### Preview, then save

   Watch or listen once. You can rename the recording (the name is just a label). If you want another try, delete it and record again before you submit. When you're happy, save it and submit.

On the Blackboard app: tap into the editor box. If you don't see the camera button, tap **+** to show more tools. The first time, your phone will ask to use your camera or microphone. Tap **Allow**, or the recording won't work.

You have plenty of room: Video Studio recordings can run up to 30 minutes. Your target is still 2 to 4.

> **MORE HELP**
>
> Blackboard help: Create Video Studio recordings (https://help.anthology.com/blackboard/student/en/course-content-and-materials/video-studio/create-video-studio-recordings.html)

> **FIND A QUIET SPOT**
>
> A closed room, a parked car, an empty study room. You're not scored on polish, but speak clearly and aim for decent audio, as a courtesy to whoever is listening.

Know your story, say it out loud once before you record, and trust the structure. Then tell it.

The preparation matters more than the recording.

PART 5

What Makes a Strong Story

How stories are scored, and three fixes that move a story up.

All four stories are scored the same way: on the story and its structure.

Recorded stories are never scored on delivery. Written and recorded stories are held to the same standard. The table below shows that standard, and the fixes after it show how to move your story up a level.

How stories are scored

Level	What it looks like
Strong	All five steps are there, and each one is specific to you. Your Action says what you did, your Result names something concrete, and your Transfer names a real situation ahead.
On Track	All five steps are there and the story is real, but one step is general. Often it's the Transfer, or "we" in the Action.
Developing	All five steps are there, but two or more are general or thin.
Needs Revision	A step is missing, or the story doesn't show what you did.
No Evidence	Nothing was submitted, or the response doesn't use STAR(T).

Three fixes that move a story up

Swap "we" for "I"

BeforeWe reorganized the schedule so everyone could make it.

AfterI asked each person for their work hours, built a new schedule around them, and sent it to the group that night.

Make the Result concrete

BeforeIt went really well.

AfterEveryone made the next three meetings, and we turned the project in a day early.

Name where the Transfer goes

BeforeThis will help me in my future career.

AfterIn clinicals next year I'll be coordinating with nurses on different shifts, and I now know to ask about everyone's constraints before I plan.

Submitting your stories

There are four separate My STAR(T) Story submission portals in Blackboard, one for each skill, in the Capstone module's CAPSTONE SUBMISSION PORTALS folder. The Fillable Forms folder there links to your four practice guides. You don't have to submit them all at once. Each portal is separate, so you can pace yourself. Check Blackboard for the due date.

I'm using the **portal that matches the skill** in my story.

My recording is about **2 to 4 minutes**, or my written story is my practice guide, saved as a PDF, with all five steps.

All **five steps** are there, in order.

For my choice story, I **named my skill and why I chose it** at the start.

It sounds like me, not a template and not AI.

AI AND YOUR STORIES

AI can help you brainstorm which experience to use, or ask you questions that help you remember details. It can't tell your story. Your stories have to be yours, in your own words and voice.

TRAIL TOOL

Practice Guide: Adaptability & Leadership

Find your story and draft it, one step at a time.



10 Essential Skills · #5

Adaptability & Leadership

A story about adjusting when things changed, or stepping up when it mattered.

Adaptability & Leadership is about adjusting when things change and stepping up to help others toward a goal. Leadership here doesn't need a title. It shows up when you take initiative, keep someone else going, or keep moving when circumstances shift.

This is practice, and it isn't graded. Draft your story here, see how long it runs out loud, then record it (strongly encouraged). Writing yours instead? Use this form so you cover all five steps, save it as a PDF, and upload it to the matching My STAR(T) Story submission portal in Blackboard.

LOOK BACK AT

The STAR(T) Framework

Find Your Stories

Find your story

Your story can come from school, work, family, or your community. It doesn't have to be dramatic. It has to be real, and yours.

MINE YOUR OWN WORK

Your Mile Markers may already hold a story worth telling.

Mile Marker #7: My Strengths Snapshot

Mile Marker #3: Managing My Time & Energy

Questions to help you find it:

Was there a time your plan fell apart and you had to change course, without falling apart yourself?

Have you ever stepped up to lead, in a group, at work, or in your family, even though nobody officially asked you to?

Is there a moment when you helped someone else stay motivated or on track when things got hard?

Did you have to adjust to a new place, a new system, or new expectations, and figure it out?

Draft it, one step at a time

Your draft saves in this browser as you go. Nothing is sent anywhere.

USING AI?

Ask it to help you find your story, not to write it: "Don't write my response for me. Help me find it." Your story has to sound like you.

Your name (required)

Date

STEP 0

Find your story first

The experience I'm going to use

SSituationSet the scene. What was going on?

Give just enough context for someone who wasn't there. Two or three sentences is usually plenty.

Situation

Watch out: The Situation is the setup, not the story. Get to the Task quickly.

TTaskDefine your role. What was yours to do?

For this skill, the Task is often something unexpected landing in your lap, or noticing that someone needed to step up and deciding that someone was you.

Task

Watch out: Your Task is what you were responsible for, not the group's general goal.

AActionShow what you did, step by step.

This is the most important step. Use "I": I decided, I reached out, I chose. Show how you responded when things changed: the decisions you made, the steps you took, and how you supported others.

Action

Watch out: "We figured it out" hides your part. Describe what you did, even inside a group effort.

RResultName the outcome. What happened because of what you did?

Results for this skill often show up in how the group did, in relationships, or in your own growth, not just in getting the task done.

Result

Watch out: "It went well" isn't a result. Name what specifically happened.

TTransferConnect it forward. What does this mean for what comes next?

College, work, and life will keep asking you to adapt and step up. Where specifically do you expect to need this skill next, and what does this story tell you about how you'll handle it?

Transfer

Watch out: "This will help me in the future" isn't a Transfer. Name a specific place, role, or situation.

About 0 out loud (0 words; aim for 2 to 4 minutes)

AFTER YOU DRAFT IT

Quick reflection

Which step was hardest to write, and why do you think that is?

Does anything sound generic, like anyone could have written it? Where could you be more specific?

TRAIL TOOL

Practice Guide: Professionalism

Find your story and draft it, one step at a time.



10 Essential Skills · #6

Professionalism

A story about following through, owning a mistake, or being someone others could count on.

Professionalism is about how you show up: following through, taking responsibility, managing your time and commitments, acting ethically, and communicating with care. Think of a moment when you showed reliability, integrity, or accountability in a real situation.

This is practice, and it isn't graded. Draft your story here, see how long it runs out loud, then record it (strongly encouraged). Writing yours instead? Use this form so you cover all five steps, save it as a PDF, and upload it to the matching My STAR(T) Story submission portal in Blackboard.

LOOK BACK AT

The STAR(T) Framework

Find Your Stories

Find your story

Your story can come from school, work, family, or your community. It doesn't have to be dramatic. It has to be real, and yours.

MINE YOUR OWN WORK

Your Mile Markers may already hold a story worth telling.

Mile Marker #8: My Career Snapshot

Mile Marker #3: Managing My Time & Energy

Questions to help you find it:

Was there a time you met a deadline or commitment even when it was hard?

Have you ever owned a mistake, taken responsibility for something that went wrong, and handled it well?

Is there a moment when you juggled competing responsibilities and made deliberate choices about priorities?

Was there a time when doing the right thing was harder than taking the easy way out?

Draft it, one step at a time

Your draft saves in this browser as you go. Nothing is sent anywhere.

> **USING AI?**
> Ask it to help you find your story, not to write it: "Don't write my response for me. Help me find it." Your story has to sound like you.

Your name (required)

Date

STEP 0

Find your story first

The experience I'm going to use

SSituationSet the scene. What was going on?

Give just enough context for someone who wasn't there. Two or three sentences is usually plenty.

Situation

Watch out: The Situation is the setup, not the story. Get to the Task quickly.

TTaskDefine your role. What was yours to do?

What were you accountable for? What was expected of you, and what made it hard to meet?

Task

Watch out: Your Task is what you were responsible for, not the group's general goal.

AActionShow what you did, step by step.

This is the most important step. Use "I": I decided, I reached out, I chose. Show the specific choices you made, especially when the easier choice would have been to do less, avoid the conversation, or let it slide. Describe what you actually did, not what you were supposed to do.

Action

Watch out: "We figured it out" hides your part. Describe what you did, even inside a group effort.

RResultName the outcome. What happened because of what you did?

Results for this skill often show up in relationships: trust built, a problem solved, a standard kept. They don't have to be dramatic to matter.

Result

Watch out: "It went well" isn't a result. Name what specifically happened.

TTransferConnect it forward. What does this mean for what comes next?

How will this shape the way you show up at work or in your program? Name a field, a role, or a situation where this skill will be tested.

Transfer

Watch out: "This will help me in the future" isn't a Transfer. Name a specific place, role, or situation.

About 0 out loud (0 words; aim for 2 to 4 minutes)

AFTER YOU DRAFT IT

Quick reflection

Which step was hardest to write, and why do you think that is?

Does anything sound generic, like anyone could have written it? Where could you be more specific?

TRAIL TOOL

Practice Guide: Knowledge Application

Find your story and draft it, one step at a time.



10 Essential Skills · #9

Knowledge Application

A story about a time something you learned met a moment you needed it.

Knowledge Application is about using something you learned, in a class, at work, or through experience, in a real situation. Think of a moment when "I learned this" met "I need it right now."

This is practice, and it isn't graded. Draft your story here, see how long it runs out loud, then record it (strongly encouraged). Writing yours instead? Use this form so you cover all five steps, save it as a PDF, and upload it to the matching My STAR(T) Story submission portal in Blackboard.

LOOK BACK AT

The STAR(T) Framework

Find Your Stories

Find your story

Your story can come from school, work, family, or your community. It doesn't have to be dramatic. It has to be real, and yours.

MINE YOUR OWN WORK

Your Mile Markers may already hold a story worth telling.

Mile Marker #6: My Academic Plan

Mile Marker #4: My Academic Toolkit

Questions to help you find it:

Was there a moment in this course, or another class, when something you learned helped you handle a real situation?

At work or in your community, have you used what you knew to solve a problem others couldn't?

Is there something you know how to do that you had to actually use when it mattered?

Draft it, one step at a time

Your draft saves in this browser as you go. Nothing is sent anywhere.

USING AI?

Ask it to help you find your story, not to write it: "Don't write my response for me. Help me find it." Your story has to sound like you.

Your name (required)

Date

STEP 0

Find your story first

The experience I'm going to use

SSituationSet the scene. What was going on?

Give just enough context for someone who wasn't there. Two or three sentences is usually plenty.

Situation

Watch out: The Situation is the setup, not the story. Get to the Task quickly.

TTaskDefine your role. What was yours to do?

What were you trying to solve, and what part of it was yours to handle?

Task

Watch out: Your Task is what you were responsible for, not the group's general goal.

AActionShow what you did, step by step.

This is the most important step. Use "I": I decided, I reached out, I chose. Name the specific knowledge or skill you brought to the situation, and exactly how you used it.

Action

Watch out: "We figured it out" hides your part. Describe what you did, even inside a group effort.

RResultName the outcome. What happened because of what you did?

What changed or got resolved? An honest, imperfect result is more believable than a vague "it went well."

Result

Watch out: "It went well" isn't a result. Name what specifically happened.

TTransferConnect it forward. What does this mean for what comes next?

Try this shape: "This showed me that [something specific], and I expect to use this skill when [a specific situation]."

Transfer

Watch out: "This will help me in the future" isn't a Transfer. Name a specific place, role, or situation.

About 0 out loud (0 words; aim for 2 to 4 minutes)

AFTER YOU DRAFT IT

Quick reflection

Which step was hardest to write, and why do you think that is?

Does anything sound generic, like anyone could have written it? Where could you be more specific?

TRAIL TOOL

Practice Guide: Your Choice

Choose your skill, then draft your story.

The fourth story is yours. Pick the skill you can tell the most honest story about.

Three of your four stories are assigned. This one is yours to choose. Pick the skill that connects most honestly to a real experience, from this course or from your life before college. The best choice is the one where you have the most specific, honest thing to say, not the one that sounds most impressive.

This is practice, and it isn't graded. Draft your story here, see how long it runs out loud, then record it (strongly encouraged). Writing yours instead? Use this form so you cover all five steps, save it as a PDF, and upload it to the matching My STAR(T) Story submission portal in Blackboard.

LOOK BACK AT

The STAR(T) Framework

Find Your Stories

Choose your skill

Read through the options and pick the one you can tell the most specific, honest story about.

MINE YOUR OWN WORK

Your Mile Markers may already hold a story worth telling.

Your Merit reflections

Mile Marker #5: Understanding My Money

- 
1**Communication**Listening carefully, responding clearly, and writing or speaking in ways that actually land.

- 
2**Critical & Creative Thinking**Evaluating information carefully, questioning assumptions, or finding a new approach to a real problem.
- 
3**Quantitative Reasoning**Using numbers, data, or calculations to understand a situation and make a better decision.
- 
4**Interpersonal Relations**Handling relationships thoughtfully: understanding other perspectives, building trust, or working through conflict respectfully.
- 
7**Civic Engagement**Taking action in your community and contributing to something beyond yourself.

- 
8**Collaboration & Teamwork**Working well with others: contributing to a team, sharing the work, and building toward a shared goal.
- 
10**Information Literacy**Finding, evaluating, and using information responsibly, and knowing what to trust before you act on it.

Draft it, one step at a time

Your draft saves in this browser as you go. Nothing is sent anywhere.

USING AI?

Ask it to help you find your story, not to write it: "Don't write my response for me. Help me find it." Your story has to sound like you.

Your name (required) **Date**

STEP 0

Choose your skill

My chosen skill

Circle one: #1 Communication / #2 Critical & Creative Thinking / #3 Quantitative Reasoning / #4 Interpersonal Relations / #7 Civic Engagement / #8 Collaboration & Teamwork / #10 Information Literacy

Why I chose it, in one or two sentences. Your submission starts with this.

The experience I'm going to use

SSituationSet the scene. What was going on?

Give just enough context for someone who wasn't there. Two or three sentences is usually plenty.

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Watch out: The Situation is the setup, not the story. Get to the Task quickly.

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What were you trying to do or solve, and what part of it was yours?

Task

Watch out: Your Task is what you were responsible for, not the group's general goal.

AActionShow what you did, step by step.

This is the most important step. Use "I": I decided, I reached out, I chose. Describe the specific things you did and the choices you made. This is where your skill lives. Show it, don't just claim it.

Action

Watch out: "We figured it out" hides your part. Describe what you did, even inside a group effort.

RResultName the outcome. What happened because of what you did?

What changed or got resolved because of what you did? Be specific.

Result

Watch out: "It went well" isn't a result. Name what specifically happened.

TTransferConnect it forward. What does this mean for what comes next?

Where will this skill show up next? Name a program, a kind of work, a relationship, or a responsibility where it will matter.

Transfer

Watch out: "This will help me in the future" isn't a Transfer. Name a specific place, role, or situation.

About 0 out loud (0 words; aim for 2 to 4 minutes)

AFTER YOU DRAFT IT

Quick reflection

Which step was hardest to write, and why do you think that is?

Does anything sound generic, like anyone could have written it? Where could you be more specific?